

Delhi Police detain 4 for molesting, assaulting women in Nehru Place

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a swift action, the Delhi Police has detained four accused in connection with the alleged molestation and assault of two women near a club in Nehru Place in the early hours of May 10. Out of the two victims, one woman was from Assam while the other was from Bihar.

The police also said that preliminary investigation had found no evidence so far of any racial slur targeting the Northeastern woman, even though one of the women had earlier alleged racist abuse during the altercation.

According to police, the incident began early morning



when four men riding on two motorcycles allegedly verbally harassed the two women while passing by them. The women allegedly responded verbally, following which they moved to a nearby tea stall. Police said the accused returned to the tea shop within a few minutes, leading to another verbal altercation that escalated into a quarrel. Some bystanders later intervened

and helped the women.

A PCR call regarding women in distress was received at Kalkaji police station around 7 am, after which local police teams rushed to the spot near a tea stall in Nehru Place. "Preliminary inquiry revealed that the victims were subjected to derogatory remarks and abuses which led to a physical altercation amongst the victims and accused," South-East DCP Hemant Tiwari had

earlier said in a press note.

The women alleged that two men began verbally harassing them while they were having tea outside a hotel, after which several others joined in. One of the women further alleged that she was molested, her clothes were torn, and she was attacked with a bamboo stick while trying to leave the area.

A case has been registered at Kalkaji police station under Sections 115(2) (voluntarily causing hurt), 74 (assault or criminal force against a woman with intent to outrage her modesty), 126(2) (wrongful restraint), 351(2) (criminal intimidation), 78 (stalking) and 3(5) (common intention) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

EV policy draws strong public response

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has received nearly 700 suggestions and feedback submissions on the Draft Delhi EV Policy 2026 during a month-long public consultation exercise, indicating strong public and industry interest in the future of electric mobility in the Capital.

The consultation process, conducted by the Delhi Transport Department, remained open for 30 days until May 10. During this period, the Government invited comments from citizens, industry representatives, institutions, and organisations connected to the electric vehicle ecosystem.

Transport Minister Dr. Pankaj Kumar Singh said the large response reflected



Delhi's growing support for cleaner and sustainable mobility solutions. He said the Government is committed to preparing a practical and future-oriented EV policy that supports wider adoption of electric vehicles while protecting environmental and public health interests.

The minister said the final policy is being designed as a comprehensive framework that could become a model for other Indian cities as well as international urban centres. According to the Transport

Department, around 400 submissions were received from members of the public. These included feedback from individual residents, commuters, vehicle owners, students, Resident Welfare Associations, delivery workers, and gig economy employees.

Another 200 submissions came from industry stakeholders, including vehicle manufacturers, charging infrastructure providers, battery swapping operators, recyclers, fleet operators, and power distribution companies.

Rescue drive launched for destitute and sick in Capital



CM Rekha Gupta launched a special rescue and welfare campaign for destitute and needy people in New Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday launched a five-day "Seva and Rescue Campaign" aimed at helping destitute, homeless, and critically ill people living on roads, pavements, and public spaces across the national Capital. The campaign, which will continue till May 15, will cover all 13 districts of Delhi with the support of rescue teams, ambulances, social workers, and volunteers.

The Chief Minister flagged off 19 specially equipped ambulances and rescue vehicles from the Mukhyamantri Seva Sadan in Delhi. The initiative is being jointly carried out by the Department of Social Welfare, Apna Ghar Ashram, and Seva Bharti. The Government said more than 300 vulnerable people are expected to be assisted during the drive.

Addressing the gathering, the Chief Minister said the campaign was launched to ensure that no helpless person in Delhi is left without care, shelter, or treatment. She said the Government's priority is to serve people living in extremely difficult conditions and provide them with dignity and protection.

IP University launches seven new paramedical courses

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Guru Gobind Singh Indraprastha University has introduced seven new paramedical programmes for the 2026 academic session and started the online application process for admissions.

The university announced that the newly launched courses include undergraduate, postgraduate and diploma programmes in clinical psychology, emergency medical services, epidemiology, speech language pathology and optometry. Officials said the move is aimed at expanding professional



healthcare education.

University has opened admissions for BSc Clinical Psychology, Bachelor of Science in Emergency Medical and Trauma Technology, Epidemic Intelligence Service or Master in Applied Epidemiology, MA in Clinical Psychology, Post Graduate Diploma in Rehabilitation Psychology, MSc in Speech Language Pathology and Bachelor of Optometry.

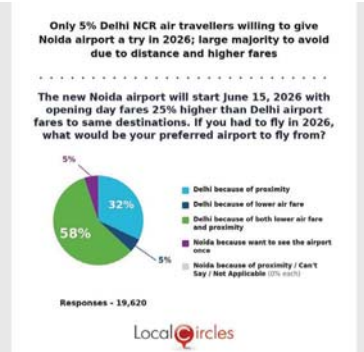
High fares, weak connectivity cast shadow over Noida Airport launch

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

The much-awaited Noida International Airport at Jewar is set to begin commercial operations on June 15, marking a major milestone in India's aviation infrastructure expansion. However, even before the first flight takes off, concerns are growing over whether the airport will be able to attract enough passengers amid higher airfares, limited connectivity and inadequate transport infrastructure.

Positioned as a major alternative to Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport (IGIA), the new airport is expected to ease congestion in the National Capital Region and boost economic development in western Uttar Pradesh. Yet, recent passenger feedback and airfare trends suggest the airport could face a challenging start.

A LocalCircles survey conducted earlier this month among more than 19,000 air travellers across Delhi, Noida, Gurugram, Ghaziabad and Faridabad found that 95 per cent of



respondents would still prefer flying from Delhi airport if ticket prices from Noida remain significantly higher. Around 58 per cent cited both lower fares and easier accessibility as the primary reasons for choosing Delhi, while 32 per cent preferred it mainly because of proximity.

Only 5 per cent of respondents expressed willingness to use the Noida airport, largely out of curiosity to experience the newly built facility.

Govt reviews CETPs to boost Yamuna cleanup

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Monday reviewed the functioning of Common Effluent Treatment Plants (CETPs) as part of its ongoing efforts to reduce pollution in the Yamuna River. Water Minister Parvash Verma and Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa held a meeting to assess how industrial waste treatment systems can be strengthened to improve the condition of the river.

The review comes as the Government intensifies its Yamuna cleaning campaign, which has remained one of the key focus areas for the administration amid growing concerns over pollution levels in the river. Officials said industrial waste flowing into the Yamuna continues to be one of the major causes of pollution. During the meeting, discussions focused



on improving the efficiency and monitoring of CETPs so that untreated industrial discharge can be stopped before reaching the river.

Verma said the Government is working towards making the treatment plants more effective and ensuring proper monitoring of their operations. He said efficient functioning of CETPs is critical for the revival of the Yamuna. "If CETPs work right, the Yamuna gets a real chance to recover, and that is the direction we are pushing towards," Verma said in a statement shared on the social media platform X.

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE COMMISSIONER OF TRANSPORT, ASSAM

PARIBAHAN BHAWAN, JAWAHARNAGAR, KHANAPARA, GUWAHATI-22.

No. E/432115/3189

Expression of Interest (EOI)

In continuation to the Expression of Interest (EOI) communicated vide this office letter No. E/432115/2080-82 dated, Guwahati, 13th March, 2026, it is hereby informed that the detailed EOI for empanelment of AIS-140 compliant Vehicle Location Tracking Devices (VLTDS) manufacturers and registration of authorised fitment centres for installation of such devices in vehicles in the State of Assam, in accordance with the provisions of the Motor Vehicles Act, 1988 and the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989, has been released with effect from 5th May, 2026.

Accordingly, interested manufacturers possessing AIS-140 Type Approved VLTDS devices certified by testing agencies notified under Rule 126 of the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989, may submit their applications as per the prescribed procedure laid down in the EOI document.

The detailed EOI document, eligibility criteria, terms and conditions, and application procedure are available on the official website of the Commissionerate of Transport, Assam at Commissionerate of Transport, Assam.

Sd/-
Commissioner of Transport, Assam,
Khanapara, Guwahati-22.
DIPR/C/ECR/32/12-May-26

PUBLIC NOTICE
Original Conveyance Deed bearing Registration No.15,031 in Book No. 1 VOL No. 4, 144 on Pages 177 TO 178 on Dated 29.08.2011 issued by DDA in favour of Purchaser Smt. Vatsala Gulati W/o D.V. Gulati of Flat No. 127, Siddharth Enclave, New Delhi-110014 has been lost by me. Whoever finds the same kindly inform on my mobile no 9811055406.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mr. Mohsin Khan to inform to the public at large that Mr. Mohsin Khan is purchasing the Entire Property Built-up Property No.C-5, area measuring 55 Sq. Yds. Out of Khara No. 303, Situated Village Bindapur area abadi known as Colony Bhagwati Vihar V-Block Uttam Nagar New Delhi-110059 from of Mr. Mohd. Nishad who became owner through General Power of Attorney, Agreement to Sell & Will dated 15.10.2018, duly attested with the Notary Public Delhi dated 15/10/2018 which was executed by Mr. Krishan Gupta and same to be financed & mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd. So, to comply the requirements of BANKINGFC, we give public notice that if any person having any type of claim/rights/interests/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, with all his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucern Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact # 911-4054516 & 4168732

कार्यालय नगर पालिका परिषद खुरई, जिला- सागर (म.प्र.)

क्र./लो. नि.सा./निविदा/2026/186

खुरई दिनांक 11.05.2026

//निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना//

निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु केन्द्रीयकृत प्रणाली में पंजीकृत टेकेदारों से ऑन लाईन निविदायें आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा का विस्तृत विवरण निम्न वेबसाइट www.mptenders.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है।

क्र.	टेंडर क्रमांक जारी दिनांक	कार्य का नाम एवं स्थान	कार्य की समयावधि एवं लागत	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य एवं ई.एम.डी.	निविदा की अंतिम तिथि
01	2026_UAD_504915_12.05.2026	समय-समय पर आवश्यकता अनुसार विभिन्न कार्य हेतु मेन पीपर /श्रमिक/ व्यक्ति (अक़शल एवं कुशल) श्रमिक उपलब्ध कराये जाने हेतु।	12 माह 2,00,00,000/-	12,500/- 1,00,000/-	13.06.2026

नोट:- निविदा से संबंधित किसी भी प्रकार के संशोधन का प्रकाशन ऑनलाइन www.mptenders.gov.in की वेबसाइट पर ही किया जावेगा, पृथक से समाचार पत्र में प्रकाशन नहीं किया जावेगा।

अध्यक्ष
नगर पालिका परिषद खुरई

मुख्य नगर पालिका अधिकारी
नगर पालिका परिषद खुरई

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER(HEALTH & EDUCATION)

P.W.(H&E) DEPTT.:CHANDMARI: GUWAHATI-3.

No. CE/TB-II(H&E)/53/2024/47

PRESS NOTICE

The Chief Engineer (Health & Education), P.W.(H&E) Deptt., Chandmari, Guwahati-3, on behalf of the Governor of Assam invites online EPC Mode-1 e-tenders in two bid system (Eligibility and Financial) on **Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) Mode-1** basis from eligible firms/contractors of repute for the following work:
Details of the bid may be seen at e-procurement portal website i.e. www.assamtenders.gov.in.

Sl. No.	Name of Work	Approx value of work	Time of Completion	E.M.D.	Tender Cost (Rs.)
1.	Setting up Speciality Burns Unit (Ward) at Jorhat Medical College & Hospital	Rs. 7,82,52,105.00	18 month	(2% for General, and 1% for Reserved category)	Rs. 15,700/-

Notes:- 1. NIT value may be changed during uploading of tender in the website, which may be seen in Detailed NIT of the bid document.
2. The bidders must be enrolled in www.assamtenders.gov.in

Sd/-
Chief Engineer (Health & Education)
P.W.(H&E) Deptt.
Chandmari, Guwahati-3

DIPR/C/PIO/31/12-May-26

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Khushbu W/o Ramjaan ALI R/o F- 229, Madipur J J Colony, VTC Paschim Vihar, P.O., Paschim Vihar, Punjabi Bagh West Delhi - 110063 have changed my name to KM khushbu Bano. that Khushbu and KM Khushbu Bano is One and the Same Person.
PD(1072)C
I, Khamos Devi W/o- No.16016187K CHM Kamlesh Kumar, R/o- Post- Barnagar, Teh- Kotputli, Dist- Jaipur, Rajasthan- 303106, have changed my name from Khamos Devi to Khamosh Devi, vide affidavit dated 11/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1073)C
I, Sundri Mother of No. 19001595A Hav Pardeep Kumar, R/o- VPO- Haripur, Teh- Thanesar, Distt- Kurukshetra Haryana- 136135, have changed my name from Sundri Devi to Sundri, vide affidavit dated 11/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1074)C
I, No.6396632K Hav Rajendra Prasad Pandey, R/o- Vill&PO- Kandaila, PS- Baikunthpur, Dist- Rewa, M.P. 486001, have changed my Mother's name in my Army Service Record from Smt Sita Devi to Sita Devi Pandey, vide affidavit dated 11/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1075)C
I, No.16016187K CHM Kamlesh Kumar, R/o- Post- Barnagar, Teh- Kotputli, Dist- Jaipur, Rajasthan- 303106, have changed my daughter's name from Pooja Devi to Pooja, vide affidavit dated 11/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1076)C
I, No.16016187K CHM Kamlesh Kumar, R/o- Post- Barnagar, Teh- Kotputli, Dist- Jaipur, Rajasthan- 303106, have changed my daughter's name from Anjali Devi to Anjali, vide affidavit dated 11/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1077)C
I, No.15785391K Hav (DS) A Arockia Alex R/o- Thalakkavoor, Post- Managiri, Teh- Karaikudi, Dist- Sivagangai- 630307 have changed my Daughter's name from Jocasta to A Jocasta, vide affidavit dated 11/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1078)C

Govt may take over Janakpuri’s school after 3-year-old’s alleged rape

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government may take over the management of a private school in west Delhi’s Janakpuri as a show-cause notice to the school authorities over the alleged rape of a three-year-old girl on its premises is still unanswered, officials said on Monday.

Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood said that education department officials visited the school on Monday and collected relevant documents, which will be verified on Tuesday, and further actions will follow.

“DoE officials were in the school today; they inspected the school premises to assess safety measures and collected documents which will be verified on Tuesday, and accordingly, actions will be taken,” he said.

The minister further said the Government may

approach the court to take over management of the school if the documents are found to be unsatisfactory.

Citing serious lapses in child safety, supervision and compliance with statutory norms, the Directorate of Education (DoE) on May 8 issued a show-cause notice to the school management, warning that failure to furnish a satisfactory response could lead to withdrawal of recognition and takeover of management under provisions of the Delhi School Education Act and Rules (DSEAR).

The school authorities were granted three days to file their response. However, it is yet to be received by the DoE, and the department is planning to initiate disciplinary action against the school over the alleged deficiencies in child safety measures, officials said.

According to police, the child’s mother lodged a complaint at Janakpuri police

station on May 1, alleging that her daughter was sexually assaulted during school hours on April 30, the second day after her admission to the school. A 57-year-old staff member of the school was arrested in this connection.

Police said the child complained of pain after returning home and later told her mother that she had been taken to an isolated area inside the school where the accused allegedly assaulted her.

In its notice dated May 8, the DoE said a preliminary inquiry found several violations and deficiencies on the part of the school administration.

The department alleged that the school failed to maintain adequate surveillance and monitoring systems, including the non-installation or absence of CCTV cameras at sensitive locations.

It also flagged alleged failures in the implementation of child protection safeguards



and preventive mechanisms within the campus.

The notice further stated that nursery and pre-primary classes were allegedly being run from a separate private premises located around one kilometre from the recognised main campus without prior approval from authorities.

“The alleged shifting of students to an unapproved premises raised concerns related to safety, statutory compliance and violation of land allotment conditions,” it said. The DoE had asked the school management to submit details related to staff deployment, CCTV records,

POLICE MOVE HC AGAINST BAIL TO STAFFER

New Delhi: The Delhi Police has moved Delhi High Court against the bail granted to the 57-year-old staff member accused of raping a three-year-old girl inside a private school in west Delhi’s Janakpuri.

On the other hand, family members and relatives of the child gathered outside the school on Monday and demanded strict punishment for the accused. They also expressed anger over the bail granted to him and sought speedy justice in the case. A senior police officer said an appeal has been filed before the high court challenging the trial court bail order in the case registered under provisions of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

The accused, employed as a caretaker at the school, was arrested on May 1 after the child identified him during the investigation. “He was later sent to judicial custody but was granted bail on May 7 despite opposition from the prosecution,” the police officer said.

received from the school authorities on Monday noon, and the department is planning to initiate action against the school.

According to police, a case has been registered in connection with the alleged sexual assault on the nursery student under Section 64(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita pertaining to rape of minors and Section 6 (aggravated penetrative sexual assault) of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

The child identified the accused, following which the 57-year-old school caretaker was arrested on May 1, police said. He was later produced before a court and sent to judicial custody.

However, he was granted bail by a court in Dwarka on May 7 despite strong opposition by the prosecution. Police said they are checking CCTV footage on the school premises.

MCD asks agencies to shift homeless to shelters ahead of global summits

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has asked multiple agencies, including the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board (DUSIB), Delhi Police and the Public Works Department (PWD), to shift homeless people staying under flyovers, on footpaths and central verges to shelter homes ahead of two international summits scheduled in the national Capital later this month.

In its bid to prepare for the upcoming summit, the MCD, in its May 4 communication, said the exercise was being planned in view of the fourth India-Africa Forum Summit (IAFS-IV) 2026 and the first International Big Cats Alliance (IBCA) Summit, scheduled to be held at the



Bharat Mandapam from May 28 to June 1.

The letter, issued by the deputy commissioner (DC) of MCD’s Central Zone to agencies, said joint field inspections had found homeless persons “temporarily residing or congregating” on footpaths, central verges and beneath flyovers along important arterial roads, many of which fall under the jurisdiction of PWD.

“This is resulting in sanitation challenges, unhygienic conditions and compromised aesthetics of key stretches in the city,” the letter read.

The civic body, in its communication, said that Delhi is expected to host heads of state and Government, along with representatives of international organisations, and several public spaces, transit corridors, hotels and her-

itage sites will come under international scrutiny during the events. Civic officials noted that all its zones were carrying out focused interventions aimed at improving cleanliness, urban aesthetics and overall city presentation around summit venues, airport and hotel routes, markets, tourist spots and heritage areas.

According to the communication, DUSIB has been asked to shift homeless persons to nearby notified shelter homes while ensuring their safety, dignity and access to basic amenities.

Furthermore, the corporation has instructed all deputy commissioners that all beautification, sanitation, and branding-related tasks must be completed “well in advance of the summits” and continuously monitored

throughout the event period. The PWD has been directed to identify such locations under flyovers and coordinate the shifting operations with other agencies. It has also been asked to ensure cleaning, sanitisation and upkeep of these areas after the exercise.

Additionally, the Delhi Police has been asked to assist during the shifting process and ensure that re-encroachment does not take place under flyovers and on footpaths.

The Revenue Department has also been asked to supervise the exercise on the ground through executive magistrates wherever required. The letter highlighted that the measures were necessary to maintain public health, safety, cleanliness and a “dignified urban

environment” during the summit period.

Main key roads identified for the summit include several roads and public places identified for focused action, including Mahatma Gandhi Road, Mathura Road, Lodhi Road, Tilak Marg, Sri Aurobindo Marg and Dhaula Kuan.

Markets such as South Extension, Lajpat Nagar, GK-I and GK-II, Nehru Place and Chandni Chowk have also been included, along with tourist and heritage locations such as Rajghat, Humayun’s Tomb, Qutub Minar, Lotus Temple and Red Fort. Several hotels are expected to host delegates, including The Lodhi, Hyatt Regency, Sheraton Saket and properties in Aerocity and Dwarka.

Gadkari launches MLFF tolling on UER-II at Mundka-Bakkarwala plaza

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister for Road, Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari on Monday inaugurated the Multi-Lane Free Flow (MLFF) tolling system at the Mundka-Bakkarwala plaza on Delhi’s Urban Extension Road-II (UER-II).

This significant upgrade introduces barrier-less toll collection, allowing vehicles to pass through without stopping. Vehicles no longer need to slow down or stop at toll plazas. The system automatically detects the FASTag linked to the vehicle and deducts the toll amount while it is in motion.

Using FASTag and Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR) technology, the system aims to drastically reduce congestion, save travel time, improve fuel efficiency, and lower vehicular emissions for daily commuters in and around the national Capital.

In cases of insufficient balance, invalid FASTag, or technical issues, an Electronic Notice (E-Notice) is generated, giving users 72 hours to make the payment.

The Mundka-Bakkarwala Toll Plaza in Delhi is the second Multi-Lane Free Flow (MLFF) barrier-less tolling system in India after Choryasi Toll Plaza on the



Union Minister for Road, Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari, during the inauguration of a Multi Lane Free Flow (MLFF) tolling plaza on UER-II in New Delhi on Monday

Surat-Bharuch section of NH-48 in Gujarat inaugurated on May 1.

Speaking at the inauguration, Gadkari emphasized that this is an important step toward the Government’s vision of a “zero-wait” highway network.

The National Highway Authority of India (NHAI) has already identified 17 fee plazas across nine states including Haryana, Rajasthan, Maharashtra, and Tamil Nadu-to be upgraded to the MLFF system by September 2026. “Our goal is to make the entire national highway network barrier-free by the end of 2026,” Gadkari said.

The National Highway Authority of India (NHAI) is planning to roll out more MLFF tolling at national highway fee plazas during the

current financial year.

The national rollout covers 17 fee plazas across nine states. All are aimed to go live by September 2026. These plazas are in states such as Gujarat, Delhi, Haryana, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Maharashtra, and Assam.

An additional 108+ plazas under phase 2 will follow by March 2027.

The state-of-the-art system enables seamless toll collection without requiring vehicles to stop, using advanced technologies such as Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR) and FASTag. The initiative is aimed at reducing queues and delays at plazas, saving fuel costs and travel time, besides giving better driving experience.

Regular fire audits ordered for schools and hospitals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Regular fire safety audits of schools, colleges, hospitals and night shelters will be conducted, while RWAs, market associations and other social organisations will take part in awareness campaigns and mock drills as part of measures to strengthen emergency preparedness across the Capital.

Delhi Home Minister Ashish Sood issued these directions while chairing a review meeting with senior and divisional officers of the Delhi Fire Services at the secretariat, on Monday.

The meeting focused on fire prevention measures,



bottlenecks in the existing fire safety mechanism, emergency preparedness, availability of modern fire-fighting equipment, procurement of new fire vehicles and the proposed modernisation of the fire department.

Discussions were also held on improving the

response time of the fire department, upgrading the internal communication system, developing a modern command and control mechanism and providing advanced technical training to fire personnel in line with evolving technologies, according to a statement.

Sood directed officials to strengthen Delhi’s fire safety system to ensure swift and effective action during emergencies. He said the Government is continuously working towards modernising the infrastructure and machinery of the fire department while giving priority to the safety of residents.

Delhi lines up ₹18 cr for AI-driven rebrand as investor-friendly hub

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

From informative short films touting investment prospects, to AI-driven sentiment tracking and round-the-clock digital campaigns, Delhi is preparing for a sweeping image makeover to project itself as a modern metropolis, teeming with economic opportunities driven by ‘good governance’, and cultural heritage.

A nearly ₹18-crore fund



has been allotted for creating a ‘brand identity’ for Delhi through coordinated media outreach, strategic communication campaigns, digital engagement and reputation

management over a one-year period, an official told PTI on Monday.

He said the project includes preparation of a comprehensive “City Brand

Playbook” defining Delhi’s identity, messaging and communication strategy across departments and public platforms. “The effort is to showcase Delhi’s transformation in governance, infrastructure, investment and civic life through a professional and coordinated communication framework,” he said.

To this extent, a selected agency will manage national and international media engagement, including feature stories, leadership

Capital plans to raise funding for parks and green spaces



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government is planning a major increase in financial support for the maintenance and development of parks and gardens across the Capital, with Resident Welfare Associations, NGOs, and registered societies likely to receive up to 100 per cent Government funding for eligible projects.

Under the proposed changes, annual maintenance assistance for parks may rise from ₹2.55 lakh per acre to ₹3.8 lakh per acre. The move is aimed at improving cleanliness, irrigation systems, and long-term upkeep of green spaces in the city. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said strengthening Delhi’s green cover remains one of the Government’s key priorities. She said the proposed changes would encourage greater community participation while improving the quality and sustainability of parks and gardens across the Capital.

The financial assistance is provided through the Delhi Parks and Gardens Society. Officials said the Government is considering a complete overhaul of the existing funding pattern to make participation easier for local organisations and housing groups.

At present, projects operate on a 90:10 cost-sharing model, under which RWAs and societies are required to contribute 10 per cent of the project cost. The Government is now proposing to fully finance eligible projects. Officials believe the change will help smaller organisations that often struggle to arrange funds for park maintenance and development.

According to the proposal, the Government also plans to significantly increase one-time assistance for creating new parks. The amount may be raised from ₹1 lakh per acre to ₹2.9 lakh per acre. The proposal is expected to benefit newly developed colonies and densely populated neighbourhoods where green spaces are limited.

Officials said the city’s rapid urban expansion has increased pressure on existing parks and public green areas. The Government believes stronger financial support will help local communities create and maintain better open spaces.

The Chief Minister said parks are essential not only for beautification but also for improving public health and environmental conditions in the city. She said green spaces provide cleaner air, reduce the impact of rising temperatures, and create areas for social interaction and recreation.

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Woman assaults guard over dog beating claim

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A dispute over the alleged beating of a stray dog in west Delhi escalated outside Kirti Nagar Police Station after an animal lover allegedly assaulted a security guard, police said on Monday.

The incident came to light after a video showing a woman repeatedly slapping and hitting the guard with slippers went viral on social media. Police said both the alleged assault on the dog and the attack on the security guard are being examined.

According to police, the



matter began on May 7 in the J Block area of Kirti Nagar. A complaint was later filed by Tarun Ghai, a resident of Ramesh Nagar, at Kirti Nagar Police Station on May 8. In his complaint, Ghai alleged that the security guard, identified as Vinod Paswan, had

attacked a stray dog with an iron rod. He claimed the animal suffered serious injuries in the incident.

Police said the injured dog was first taken to a private veterinary doctor for treatment and was later shifted to Najafgarh for further medical

care. However, the dog reportedly died later during treatment. Officials said the veterinary facility where the animal was treated has not yet formally informed the local police about the death of the dog.

A senior police officer said that while the enquiry into the dog assault allegation was underway, another incident took place outside the police station premises involving a woman who identified herself as an animal lover. The officer said the woman allegedly assaulted the security guard during an argument linked to the dog’s death.

HC forms task force for Anand Vihar Terminal beautification

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has constituted a special task force under the chairpersonship of the Urban Development Department’s joint secretary for the beautification, redevelopment, and maintenance of the Anand Vihar Bus Terminal area.

A bench of Justices Prathiba M Singh and Madhu Jain said a beautification plan – prepared by the PWD and approved by the task force – be placed before it on May 26 and directed the police to ensure that no unauthorised vending takes place in the



area in the meantime.

In an order passed on May 5 on a petition concerning vending activities in the area, the bench said the task force would comprise a deputy commissioner and assistant commissioner of the Municipal

Corporation of Delhi.

It will also have nominated officials from the PWD, Delhi Transport Department, Indian Railways, Delhi Metro Rail Corporation, Regional Rapid Transit System, National Capital Region

Transport Corporation, Irrigation and Flood Control Department and the SHO of Patparganj Industrial Area police station.

The court remarked that a task force was required in this case as the redevelopment of Anand Vihar Bus Terminal area could not be done by any particular agency on a standalone basis.

It directed the first meeting of the officials to be held on May 20, and said, “The special ‘Task force’ shall work towards formulating a comprehensive plan for the beautification, development, and maintenance of the Anand Vihar Bus Terminal area.”

IN FOCUS



A jewellery shop employee displays gold chains at a store in Kalbadevi PTI

LG Sandhu urges tech-driven innovation for Delhi’s future

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Monday said technology, scientific research, and innovation must become the foundation of Delhi’s urban transformation, stressing the need for stronger coordination between governance and scientific institutions to address challenges related to public health and environmental sustainability.

Speaking at a National Technology Day programme organised by Indraprastha Vigyan Bharati at the Vice Regal Lodge of Delhi University, the Lieutenant Governor said India’s future growth would depend on how effectively



science and technology are integrated with governance and public service delivery.

Addressing scientists, academicians, researchers, and students, Sandhu said modern cities cannot rely on isolated solutions to tackle complex urban

problems.

He said technology-driven systems and scientific planning are necessary to improve civic services and strengthen sustainability in rapidly growing cities like Delhi. The Lieutenant Governor said Delhi has the

institutional capability to become a leader in technology-based public health systems. Referring to diseases such as dengue and malaria, he said AI-powered forecasting models, PCR testing, and predictive disease surveillance systems could help authorities identify health risks before they escalate into larger public health crises.

He said institutions such as AIIMS, IIT Delhi, and the National Institute of Immunology possess the expertise required to build advanced health monitoring systems. However, he added that the key challenge lies in connecting scientific research with governance mechanisms and practical implementation.

Northern railway to run Nanded-Shakur Basti special

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

To facilitate rail passengers and manage the anticipated extra rush during the ongoing summer season, the Northern Railway has announced the operation of a special train service between Nanded and Shakur Basti.

According to a press release issued by Northern Railway, the 07658/07659 Nanded - Shakur Basti - Nanded Summer Special will undertake a single round trip to assist commuters.

The details of the special service are as follows: Train Number 07658 is scheduled to depart from Nanded at 11.20 pm on May 21, 2026, reaching Shakur Basti at 10.15 am the following day. Train Number 07659, the return service, will depart from Shakur Basti at 10.30 pm on



May 24, 2026, arriving back at Nanded at 09.00 am.

The train is slated to halt at several key stations in both directions, including Agra Cantt, ViranganaLakshmbai Jhansi Junction, Bhopal, Nagpur, Wani, Lingti, Pimpalkuti, and Kinwat. The summer special will comprise Sleeper and General coaches, catering to a wide range of passengers. Railway authorities have advised passengers to visit the National Train Enquiry System (NTES) website or dial 139 for further updates regarding timings and seat availability.

Polling for local bodies in Punjab on May 26

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chandigarh

Polling for 105 municipal bodies in Punjab, including eight municipal corporations, is scheduled for May 26, as announced by State Election Commissioner Raj Kamal Chaudhury on Monday.

Vote counting will take place on May 29. Addressing the media, Chaudhury shared details about the elections, stating that they will occur in the following eight municipal corporations: Mohali, Bathinda, Abohar, Barnala, Kapurthala, Moga, Batala, and Pathankot.

Additionally, elections will be held for 76 municipal councils and 21 nagar panchayats, totalling 2,019 wards across the 105 municipal bodies, he added.



With the announcement of the election schedule, the Model Code of Conduct has come into force with immediate effect, in the jurisdiction of all the municipal corporations, municipal councils and nagar panchayats where the elections are to going to be held. It will remain in force till the completion of the electoral process.

Om Birla highlights India-Sri Lanka’s deep cultural, spiritual ties

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla observed on Monday that India and Sri Lanka are bound by deep civilisational, cultural, and spiritual ties that have evolved over centuries. Referring to the shared Buddhist heritage of the two nations, he noted that these enduring links continue to form the foundation of the warm and friendly relations between India and Sri Lanka.

Birla made these remarks while interacting with the Women Parliamentarians’ Caucus of Sri Lanka at Parliament House on Monday. The delegation was led by HE Saroja Savithri Paulraj, Minister of Women and Child Affairs, Government of Sri Lanka. Recalling his recent interac-



tion with a Sri Lankan parliamentary delegation led by Hon SM Marikkar, Chairman of the Parliamentary Oversight Committee on

infrastructure and strategic issues, Birla expressed satisfaction over the growing frequency of parliamentary exchanges between the two

countries. He noted that sustained dialogue and regular engagement between parliamentarians have imparted fresh momentum to India-Sri

Lanka inter-parliamentary relations and strengthened mutual understanding.

Highlighting the increasing role of women in India’s democratic framework, he remarked that India’s approach has transitioned from “Women’s Development” to “Women-led Development.” He added that Prime Minister Narendra Modi firmly believes that when women lead development, societies become more inclusive, balanced, and sustainable.

Birla further noted that the first legislation passed by the Parliament of India in the newly inaugurated Parliament House was the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, which mandates 33 per cent reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies.

Emphasising the strong

grassroots foundation of Indian democracy, Birla mentioned that several Indian States have implemented 50 per cent reservation for women in local self-Government institutions. Speaking on the occasion, HE Saroja Savithri Paulraj thanked Birla for the warm hospitality extended to the delegation. She observed that the visit provided the Women Parliamentarians’ Caucus of Sri Lanka with deeper insights into India’s transformative initiatives, particularly in the fields of SHGs, women-led entrepreneurship, and digital commerce.

HE Paulraj also expressed gratitude to the Government of India for its steadfast support to Sri Lanka during challenging times, including the COVID-19 pandemic and natural disasters such as Cyclone Ditwa.

No power can bend India: PM Modi

The PM alleged that some political forces in the country continue to prioritise appeasement politics over national self-respect. Drawing a comparison with the construction of the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya, he claimed similar opposition was witnessed during the temple movement.

Modi praised Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel and India’s first President Rajendra Prasad for their efforts in rebuilding the Somnath temple after Independence. He also claimed that then Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru had opposed the reconstruction initiative.

“We must move forward by embracing both development and heritage together,” PM Modi said, adding that neglecting cultural centres had hindered national progress.

On the occasion, the Prime Minister released a commemorative stamp marking 75 years of the restored Somnath temple. Before attending the event, PM Modi held a roadshow along a 1.5-kilometre stretch from the helipad to Veer Hamirji Circle near the temple. Large crowds gathered along the route, waving flags and greeting the Prime Minister as artists from various states performed traditional dances.

PM’s calls for restraint on gold to fuel as Rupee...

If Indians sharply reduce gold purchases even for a single year, the impact on the economy could be substantial. A 30-40 per cent decline in gold imports could save the country an estimated \$20-25 billion in foreign exchange outflows, while a 50 per cent reduction could conserve nearly \$36 billion. India’s total import bill stood at \$775 billion in the last fiscal year. The largest component was crude petroleum, with imports worth \$134.7 billion. Gold imports surged to a record \$72 billion, while vegetable oil imports stood at \$19.5 billion and fertiliser imports rose to \$14.5 billion. Global crude oil prices have jumped from around \$60 per barrel to nearly \$126 per barrel in recent weeks and India imports 88 per cent of its oil needs, those saved foreign exchange matter. However, the current conflict is making conditions more complicated because rising crude oil prices are also fuelling concerns about extended inflation and increased interest rates worldwide.

The war has kept the Strait of Hormuz — one of the world’s most critical oil shipping routes — partially disrupted for weeks, triggering fears of prolonged supply shortages. India, which imports more than 88 per cent of its crude oil requirements, has been hit hard from the spike in global oil prices. The rupee has also weakened sharply against the US dollar in recent weeks.

India is one of the world’s largest importers of gold, and purchases rise significantly during weddings and festive seasons. Since gold is largely imported higher demand increases dollar outflow and widens the country’s import bill. At the same time, the IMF has projected that India’s current account deficit (CAD) could widen to \$84.5 billion in 2026, roughly 2 per cent of GDP. A widening CAD means one thing: more dollars going out than coming in. And gold is a big reason for that. India imported about \$72 billion worth of gold in FY26 — this is a 24 per cent jump from the previous year.

As far as avoiding foreign visits is concerned, data shows Indians spent approximately \$31.7 billion (₹2.72 lakh crore) on international travel in the 2023-24 financial year. This represents a massive 25 per cent jump from the previous year, driven largely by younger travelers and a surge in leisure trips. Indians are now spending about \$1.42 billion (₹12,500 crore) every month on foreign trips. Travel has overtaken education to become the single largest category of outward remittance for Indian individuals, accounting for over 53 per cent of all money sent abroad under the Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS).

Adhikari pushes to secure border

The core bottleneck was land acquisition and handover to the BSF. The Union Government had already acquired and paid compensation for substantial stretches, but the State Government repeatedly delayed physical transfer.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah and CM Adhikari had accused the Mamata of prioritising alleged vote bank politics linked to illegal immigration and cross-border smuggling over national security. The move fulfils a pre-poll promise by Shah, who had highlighted the need to secure the porous border and curb infiltration and smuggling. Reports indicate that around 600 acres of land are involved in the expedited process. BSF requests for land had been pending for years despite multiple letters and central funding.

Terrain challenges, riverine stretches, marshes and local resistance compounded the issue, but judicial interventions repeatedly pointed to state-level inaction as the primary hurdle. As of early 2026, hundreds of kilometres remained unfenced in key districts such as Malda, Murshidabad, and Nadia, areas long identified as vulnerable to infiltration.

After the Cabinet meeting, Adhikari said that the new journey of good governance, security, and a double-engine Government in West Bengal would move forward on the same path of development as in other BJP-ruled states across the country. He reaffirmed the Government’s commitment to the ideals of Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar and the principle of “For the People, By the People, of the People.”

The BJP Government’s swift cabinet approval signals a sharp policy shift toward full cooperation with the Centre. By committing to transferring the pending land, including the court-mandated stretches and additional areas totalling 600 acres, within 45 days, it aims to enable the rapid completion of fencing.

West Bengal fast-tracks welfare plans

Addressing the media after the meeting, Adhikari described the session as the beginning of a “people-first administration” that would deliver on the “double-engine” model of governance promised by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah. “Bengal saw a deathless, intimidation-free election for the first time,” he said, paying tribute to voters, officials, and the Election Commission of India. He also remembered the 321 families of BJP workers killed in political violence over the past decade,

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assuring them of state support.

On Monday the West Bengal Government formally joined the Union Government’s flagship Ayushman Bharat-PM Jan Arogya Yojana, providing health cover to families previously excluded from the scheme. Several other welfare programmes such as PM Vishwakarma, Beti Bachao Beti Padhao, PM Ujjwala, and PM Fasal Bima Yojana, will also be implemented without delay. Officials added that existing state schemes would continue, but with a transparency drive to remove “illegal beneficiaries” and ensure genuine targeting. The Cabinet also decided to roll out the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) in the State. Reversing the previous regime’s policy, the Government cleared IAS, IPS, and State public service commission officers to participate in training programmes in other States and at Central institutions.

Fulfilling a key election promise made by Shah, the Cabinet extended the upper age limit for Government job applications, particularly school service recruitment, by five years. The decision is designed to benefit thousands of educated youth who missed opportunities during the TMC years. The Government also issued orders to begin the nationwide Census operations immediately, ending what Adhikari called a year-long delay under the previous administration. Accurate data, he said, would form the foundation for targeted development and welfare.

Political observers see these early decisions as a combination of symbolism and substance. By prioritising border security and central schemes, the Adhikari Government has signalled its intent to end West Bengal’s political isolation from Delhi. The focus on jobs and transparency directly addresses two major voter grievances, unemployment and alleged corruption in welfare distribution. (PNS)

Digital trail helps nab Rath’s killers from Bihar

The rest was old-fashioned legwork, coordination with the Bihar Police, mobile tower dumps, and vehicle tracking. By Sunday evening, a joint team swooped down on three suspects in Buxar. Officials confirmed they are locals with no prior criminal record, a detail that has only deepened the mystery.”

The men were produced before a court late Sunday night and remanded in police custody till May 24 to allow intensive interrogation, forensic examination of their phones, and reconstruction of their movements on the fateful night.

The SIT was constituted within 48 hours of the murder at the highest levels of the state administration, reflecting the political sensitivity of the case. Rath was not just any staffer; he was Suwendu Adhikari’s eyes and ears on critical files, often the last man standing in late-night meetings. His killing has triggered murmurs in political corridors, whispers of revenge, leaked secrets, or a message intended for the very top. Chief Minister Adhikari, who has remained stoic in public, is said to have personally reviewed SIT updates.

As the three accused sit in a Howrah lock-up, the SIT is racing against the clock. Forensic teams are analysing call records, financial transactions, and possible links to vehicles used in the crime. Interrogation is expected to reveal whether the trio acted alone or was part of a larger network.

Sources say the probe is now widening to examine Rath’s recent movements, his access to sensitive Government correspondence, and any threats he might have received. For the SIT, the next 13 days in custody will decide whether this digital clue unravels a conspiracy that reaches far beyond a Bihar backwater.

Himanta set to start second term as CM

Sarma, who first became chief minister in 2021, will be the first non-Congress leader in Assam to serve two consecutive terms as CM. This will be the NDA’s third consecutive term in the State since the BJP-led alliance first came to power in 2016 under then CM Sarbananda Sonowal.

The massive election victory follows a campaign fought on ‘identity, land and security’ — including eviction drives and curbing illegal immigration.

Echoing this on Monday, Sarma posted on X: “Assam’s land, identity and future are non-negotiable. After freeing 1.5 lakh *bighas* land from encroachment, #NDA3.0 moves ahead with a firm resolve to reclaim 5 lakh more bighas for the people of Assam. Because for us, *Jati, Mati, Bheti* comes first.”

The NDA, comprising the BJP, Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) and Bodoland People’s Front (BPF), secured a sweeping mandate in the Assembly polls, winning a record 102 seats in the 126-member House. The BJP alone bagged 82, its first single-party majority in the state, while AGP and BPF won 10 seats each. Former Union minister Rameshwar Teli, Atul Borah, Charan Boro, Ajanta Neog are also likely to be sworn in alongside Sarma.

AIADMK headed for a split after poll drubbing

The internal fight became visible as the AIADMK legislators came to the Assembly in two groups, one headed by former minister SP Velumani and another led by Palaniswami.

The party’s internal turmoil has emerged at a tough period for the AIADMK, which had faced successive electoral defeats, including in the 2019 General Election, the 2021 Assembly election, the 2024 Lok Sabha polls and the 2021 Assembly election. In addition, the party also lost the Erode by-election in 2025.

Congress summons Kerala leaders...

Regarding the delay in announcing the CM’s name, Sudheeran said he could not comment on it now and would give clear explanations to questions asked by the leadership.

Referring to the Congress-led UDF’s victory in the Assembly elections, Sudheeran said, “There is no doubt that it was a victory of Team UDF. Let Kerala get a CM and other mechanisms soon and let them work up to the expectations of the people.” Senior leader K Muraliedharan also confirmed that he had been directed to meet the party leadership in New Delhi on Tuesday. He said he would travel on a 6 am flight and attend discussions at the party headquarters by 10 am. “I was asked to reach Delhi, and I said I will reach

there. The rest will be known after reaching there,” he said. When asked whether he had been called for discussions related to the CM’s selection, Muraliedharan said the leadership would not summon him merely to discuss the weather. “The decision is expected by Tuesday or Wednesday. I expect the uncertainty to end within the next 48 hours,” he said.

Muraliedharan said he had already conveyed his opinion on the chief ministerial candidate during the Congress Legislature Party meeting attended by AICC observers in Thiruvananthapuram.

However, he said all Congress leaders and workers would accept the decision taken by the party high command.

There are reports that senior leaders K Sudhakaran, Thiruvanchoor Radhakrishnan and MM Hassan have also been called to New Delhi.

Recently, the AICC leadership held discussions in New Delhi with the three main contenders for the chief minister’s post — VD Satheesan, KC Venugopal and Ramesh Chennithala — along with current KPCC president Sunny Joseph.

The Congress Legislature Party had passed a resolution authorising Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge to take a final decision on the next CM of Kerala.

The UDF secured a major victory in the Assembly elections, winning 102 seats, of which the Congress accounted for 63 constituencies.

Iran’s foreign minister likely to visit India

Iran’s participation assumes significance as Tehran continues to examine a 14-point US peace proposal that seeks suspension of Iran’s uranium enrichment programme for at least 12 years in return for a phased lifting of American sanctions.

Iran, which became a member of BRICS in 2024 along with Egypt, Ethiopia, Saudi Arabia and the UAE, has attached considerable importance to the grouping. Both Araghchi and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian have urged India to work towards building consensus within BRICS for a joint statement condemning US-Israel actions in the ongoing West Asia conflict.

India, however, has maintained that deep divisions among member nations — particularly between Iran and the UAE — have prevented the grouping from arriving at a consensus document. This was evident during last month’s meeting of BRICS special envoys, which concluded only with a Chair’s Statement instead of a joint declaration.

Government sources had then indicated that efforts by India and other member states to bridge differences between the two sides did not succeed. For New Delhi, ties with the UAE remain a strategic priority. Prime Minister Narendra Modi is expected to make a brief stop in Abu Dhabi on May 15 for talks with UAE President Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan while en route to Europe.

Araghchi’s possible visit is also expected to provide India an opportunity to engage comprehensively with Tehran on immediate concerns, including disruptions in LPG supplies arising from tensions around the Strait of Hormuz.

India has so far preferred diplomatic engagement with Iran and has refrained from considering participation in any military coalition aimed at securing maritime movement through the strategically vital Hormuz Strait.



Nida Khan remanded in judicial custody till May 24

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nashik

A Nashik court on Monday remanded TCS sexual harassment-converted case accused Nida Khan in judicial custody till May 24.

Khan was produced in the court of Additional Sessions Judge KG Joshi after her police remand ended during the day. She was arrested on May 7 from Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar after being on the run since the case came to the fore following complaints from staffers of the IT major's Nashik unit.

Khan, who is pregnant, was sent to judicial custody as the police did not seek her remand during the hearing. She is lodged in Nashik Road central jail.



Police personnel escort Nida Khan, the prime accused in the TCS Nashik case involving alleged sexual harassment and forced religious conversions at the Additional Sessions Court in Nashik Road

NIDA KHAN WAS ARRESTED ON MAY 7 FROM CHHATRAPATI SAMBHAJINAGAR AFTER BEING ON THE RUN SINCE THE CASE CAME TO THE FORE

Besides Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) provisions for sexual harassment and defamation, Khan has also been booked under Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act as the complainant is a Scheduled Caste individual and Khan tried to forcibly convert her despite knowing the fact.

The Special Investigation Team (SIT) of the Nashik police is investigating nine

FIRs in the matter. One case was registered at Deolali Camp police station and eight with Mumbai Naka police station.

The complainants have alleged exploitation, attempt of forceful conversion to Islam, hurting religious sentiments, molestation and mental harassment, as per police.

After her name figured in a First Information Report registered at Deolali Camp police station, Khan (27) had moved the sessions court last month seeking anticipatory bail, pleading innocence and citing her three months pregnancy. Rejecting the plea on May 2, the court had said there seemed to be a "systematic plan" of brainwashing the victim.

Nation Focus



SOMNATH REFLECTS SANATAN CIVILISATION: GOVERNOR VARMA

Maharashtra Governor Jishnu Dev Varma on Monday described the Somnath Temple in Gujarat as a living example of the "Sanatan civilisation" that has stood tall despite repeated invasions over thousands of years. Speaking at a cultural event held to mark 75 years of the inauguration of the restored shrine of Lord Shiva, Varma noted that the temple is not just a place of worship, but "a symbol of the soul of Indian culture, faith and the Sanatan tradition". The event, titled "Somnath Swabhimana Parv - 1,000 Years of Unbroken Faith", was organised by the Maharashtra Department of Cultural Affairs at Dhakleswar Mahadev Temple. The programme was held in conjunction with a special 'Maha Pooja' conducted at Somnath Temple in Gujarat in the presence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to commemorate the reconstruction milestone.



ODISHA GOVT COMMITTED TO STRENGTHEN CULTURAL: CM

Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi on Monday said his Government was committed to strengthen the State's cultural and spiritual infrastructure to boost growth. Majhi said the Odisha Government would also focus on promoting 'Orange Economy' (culture-based economy). The CM was addressing a gathering near the Shree Lingaraj Temple here during the 75th anniversary celebrations of the inauguration of the restored Somnath Temple in Gujarat. "There is an invisible bond between Somnath and Lingaraj. While the Somnath shrine stands as the sentinel of Western India, Shree Lingaraj represents the unwavering spiritual force of the East," he said.



Punjab CM's cousin Gian Singh Mann joins BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Gian Singh Mann, the cousin of Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, on Monday joined the BJP, targeting the AAP Government over corruption, which he alleged has "doubled" and other issues, including the menace of drugs and unemployment.

Lashing out at the Arvind Kejriwal-led outfit, Gian Singh Mann alleged that the AAP has "drifted away" from its policies and also alleged that the leaders from Delhi were taking the shots in Punjab.

Gian Singh Mann, who hails from Satoj village in Sangrur district, is the son of the younger brother of Chief Minister Mann's father. His mother and that of his cousin are sisters.

He joined the BJP in a ceremony attended by Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini and Punjab BJP Chief Sunil Jakhar, who welcomed him into the party at the Punjab BJP headquarters here.

"We welcome Gian Singh Mann to the BJP," Saini announced to the media.

The Punjab Assembly elections are scheduled for early next year. Previously, Gian Singh Mann had been an active supporter of the AAP and campaigned for the party during the 2022 assembly

elections. However, he later became a vocal critic of the Mann Government, specifically criticising the land pooling policy last year.

Speaking to the media after joining the BJP, Gian Singh Mann said he had initially joined the AAP in 2014 because he was impressed by Arvind Kejriwal's vision. He noted that Mann had been elected MP from Sangrur twice before becoming chief minister.

However, he lamented that after AAP formed the government in 2022, it shifted from being the "Aam Aadmi Party" to the "Khas Aadmi Party."

Mann criticised the AAP for neglecting party volunteers when distributing tickets for the upcoming 2024 Lok Sabha elections, claiming the party has "completely forgotten" about Punjab.

He condemned the functioning of the AAP Government, alleging that drugs have infiltrated every corner of the State and that corruption has "doubled."

He recounted how party volunteers used to reach out to him for assistance with issues in the tehsil offices and police stations. Furthermore, he accused the State Government of failing to address unemployment.

VB-G RAM G Act to come into force from July 1: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Monday announced that the Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act (VB-G RAM G) will come into force across the country from July 1, replacing the two-decade-old Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA).

The new Act will have a fresh framework that promises 125 days of statutory wage employment to rural households, it said. In a statement, the Ministry of Rural Development described it as a "historic transition" in India's rural development architecture, aligned with the vision of "Viksit Bharat @2047".

The Act seeks to usher in a "future-ready and productivity-oriented rural transformation" while strengthening livelihood security, rural



incomes and village-level infrastructure development, it said.

Reacting to the announcement, Congress on Monday described it as "yet another lazy headline-grabbing exercise" and alleged that the only guarantee that the law offers is that of "extreme centralisation" and "weakening of the bargaining power of rural labour". According to notifications issued by the ministry, the VB-G RAM G Act will come into force in all states and Union Territories

on July 1, and the MGNREGA will stand repealed from the same date.

The ministry's statement assured that the transition from MGNREGA to the new framework would be seamless, without disruption to workers. "Ongoing works under MGNREGA as on June 30 shall be saved and carried over to the new framework seamlessly," the notification said.

The existing e-KYC verified MGNREGA job cards will

remain valid until the new "Gramin Rozgar Guarantee Cards" are issued, it said, adding that workers without job cards can continue to register at the gram panchayat level. Workers will not be denied employment due to pending e-KYC, the ministry said.

Draft rules related to wage payments, grievance redressal, allocation norms, administrative expenditure and transitional provisions are being prepared in consultation with states and Union Territories and will soon be published for public consultation, it added.

Under the VB-G RAM G Act framework, every rural household whose adult members volunteer to undertake unskilled manual work will be entitled to 125 days of guaranteed wage employment in a financial year, an increase from the existing 100-day guarantee under MGNREGA.

Yogi Adityanath model praised at CII Summit

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

At the CII Annual Business Summit-2026, industry leaders highly praised Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath's leadership and the transformation seen in Uttar Pradesh. Industrialists, investors, and corporate representatives from across the country said that under Yogi Adityanath's leadership, Uttar Pradesh has established a new identity in the fields of law and order, investment, infrastructure, and industrial development.

Welcoming Chief Minister Yogi, CII Director General Chandrajit Banerjee said, "Uttar Pradesh has made an exceptional contribution to India's economic progress



Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath at the CII Annual Business Summit 2026 in New Delhi

PIONEER PHOTO

in the past few years. Infrastructure has developed rapidly in the State and investment and business activities have gained new momentum under the leadership of CM Yogi."

Banerjee added that manufacturing, logistics, digital governance, urban development, and youth empowerment have given Uttar Pradesh a new direction.

CII President Rajiv Memani said, "Uttar Pradesh has witnessed a phenomenal transformation in the last few years and the industry now views the state from a completely different perspective."

Addressing the CM, Memani further added, "Industrialists from India and abroad now want to invest in

Uttar Pradesh, and with his guidance and support, this path will become even stronger."

At the same time, he also praised the Yogi Government's law and order situation and administrative functioning.

During the event, projects such as the Purvanchal Expressway, Bundelkhand Expressway, Ganga Expressway, and Jewar International Airport were specially highlighted. Memani said that these projects have completely transformed connectivity and industrial opportunities in Uttar Pradesh.

He added that people's perception of UP changes completely when they travel through the State.

Omar meets Amit Shah, discusses several issues concerning UT

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Monday attempted to build bridges by calling on Union Home Minister Amit Shah in New Delhi.

The meeting between the two leaders immediately triggered rumour mills in the Union Territory, as the same took place after the BJP's spectacular performance in the recent Assembly polls.

Though no details emerged on what transpired during the meeting, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah had dropped clear hints that he was going to New Delhi to discuss issues concerning the Union territory, including restoration of statehood.

Before leaving for the national capital, the chief minister told reporters in Srinagar that he would discuss all the issues concerning Jammu and Kashmir.

"I wish we could have got our statehood after one meeting with the home minister. If that were the case, we would have got it a long time ago. But yes, I will raise statehood, business rules and other issues concerning Jammu and Kashmir in the meeting," he said.

According to the political grapevine, the National



Conference leadership is hoping to initiate a fresh round of dialogue with the centre in order to restore statehood to Jammu and Kashmir at the earliest.

To mend the ties with the centre, Omar Abdullah has also stopped criticising the working of the office of Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha.

A clear indication came when Abdullah said that there was "nothing wrong" in giving telecom powers to the Lieutenant Governor (LG) during public safety events, as he holds the charge of security and law and order.

"This is the right thing. These powers should be with the lieutenant governor. This is not against the business rules or the reorganisation act," the chief minister told reporters.

He said that orders to stop phone services or internet are issued by the home department, which comes under the LG.

The Centre last week authorised the Jammu and Kashmir LG to exercise powers, such as interception of signals, suspension of service and decryption of messages, related to telecom services in the UT during public safety events or national emergencies.

According to the order issued on Thursday, the President directed the LG to exercise the powers and discharge the functions of the state government under Sub-Section 20 (2) of the Telecommunications Act, 2023 (44 of 2023), which deals with situations involving public safety and national security, within the UT.

Gold worth ₹3 crore seized at Mumbai airport, two held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Mumbai Customs officers have seized smuggled gold worth around ₹3.15 crore in two separate cases involving passengers arriving from Dubai, including a finance professional who allegedly told investigators he

attempted to move his assets to India amid tensions linked to the ongoing US-Iran war.

According to an official statement issued by the

Airport Commissionerate, Mumbai Customs Zone-III, the first seizure was made on May 10 after officers intercepted a passenger arriving on Spicejet flight SG5023 from Dubai based on APIS profiling. During the examination, customs officials recovered four pouches containing 24-carat gold dust mixed in wax, weighing 1.02 kg net and provisionally valued at ₹1.41 crore.

In a clever man, the passenger had allegedly concealed the gold inside a

packet of cigarettes. In the second case, customs officers intercepted a passenger arriving from Dubai on Emirates flight EK 506 and recovered 1.257 kg of 24-carat crude gold worth around ₹1.74 crore. Officials said the passenger, described as a high-income professional working in the financial sector, was arrested under the Customs Act, 1962.

During preliminary questioning, the passenger allegedly told investigators that fears arising from the



US-Iran war and recent attacks in Dubai prompted him to move his foreign assets to India by converting them into gold and smug-

gling them to avoid duties and regulatory scrutiny. Further investigation is underway in both cases, officials said.

Konkan backbone of Maharashtra's progress: Pawar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Roha (Raigad)

Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Sunetra Pawar on Monday said the Konkan region is the backbone of the state's development and pledged to carry forward the development vision of her late husband Ajit Pawar.

Addressing a public meeting after laying foundation stones for multiple projects in Roha-Ashtami Municipal Council area in Raigad district, the NCP president said Konkan was a devbhoomi (sacred land) built through the hard work and resilience of its people.

"Konkan is the backbone of Maharashtra's development. True development is not limited to cement roads, but lies in bringing economic prosperity to people's



Deputy Chief Minister Sunetra Pawar

lives and ensuring their happiness," she said.

Recalling Ajit Pawar's deep affection for the coastal region, Sunetra Pawar said he had always stood firmly for Konkan and shared a close bond with its people.

"He loved the people of Konkan immensely. As his life partner, I

know how deeply attached he was to this region," she said while assuring that her own affection for Konkan would remain as strong as that of her late husband.

Pawar also said she would pay special attention to the constituency represented by Women and Child Development Minister Aditi Tatkare, whom she described as her daughter. NCP state president and MP Sunil Tatkare, while paying tribute to Ajit Pawar, who died in a plane crash on January 28, said the late stalwart's leadership and vision would continue to guide the party.

"No one can become another Dada, but we will continue to work with the farsighted vision he gave us," Tatkare said.

He described Ajit Pawar as a development-oriented leader who had

shown particular concern for Konkan and Raigad district.

Tatkare recalled that Ajit Pawar had rushed to assist the region with a special package after Cyclone Nisarga and had personally reached out to help people during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Tatkare said several infrastructure projects were planned for Raigad and expressed confidence that Sunetra Pawar would return later this year to inaugurate the projects whose foundation stones were laid during the event.

Women and Child Development Minister Aditi Tatkare became emotional while remembering Ajit Pawar, saying the party considered itself fortunate to have had a leader like him and that his affection for Raigad would continue to inspire them.

States Focus



NAIDU EXTENDS GREETINGS ON SOMNATH AMRUT MAHOTSAV

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Monday extended greetings on the occasion of Somnath Amrut Mahotsav and praised Prime Minister Narendra Modi for promoting development alongside preservation of India's cultural heritage. Today, PM Modi visited the Somnath temple in Gujarat and participated in the Somnath Amrut Mahotsav celebrations marking 75 years since the rebuilt shrine opened to devotees, highlighting its enduring civilisational and spiritual significance. "Ours is a land where faith is respected and serves as a force that unites everyone. Somnath temple is more than a place of worship, it stands as an enduring symbol of India's civilisational spirit," Naidu said in a post on X replying to PM Modi.

(PTI)



TELUGU ACTOR AMONG TWO KILLED IN ROAD ACCIDENT

Two people, including a Telugu actor, were killed in an accident after the car they were travelling in collided with a truck near here, police said on Monday. The accident occurred at Bonguluru on the Outer Ring Road (ORR) at around 3.20 am on May 10, when the car hit the rear of the truck moving ahead, resulting in the spot death of actor Bharath Kanth (31) and a cameraman (31). The duo was returning to Hyderabad from Nellore district of Andhra Pradesh, a police official said. Bharath Kanth has acted in movies, including 'Gramam' and 'Tenant'.

(PTI)

IAF commemorates Op Sindoor anniversary with 88-hour run



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Commemorating the first anniversary of the successful air operations conducted during Operation Sindoor that lasted nearly 88 hours, the Indian Air Force organised an 88-hour run in a continuous relay format from May 7-10 in Delhi. The route encompassed important landmarks in the capital, including the India Gate, Brigadier Hoshiyar Singh Marg, Air HQ Vayu Bhawan, Nehru Park and the New Moti Bagh Road, before concluding at the Air Force Station in New Delhi, officials said. Operation Sindoor was launched in the early hours of May 7, 2025, to avenge the Pahalgam terror attack, with

Indian forces conducting precision strikes on multiple terror infrastructure in Pakistan and Pakistan-occupied-Kashmir (PoK). The strikes triggered a rapid escalation in tensions, with Pakistan launching retaliatory strikes, though most of them were thwarted by the Indian military. The military conflict between the two nuclear-armed neighbours, lasting nearly 88 hours, halted after both sides reached an understanding on the evening of May 10. The commemorative run marked the first anniversary of "88 hours of successful air operations carried out by the Indian Air Force (IAF), which demonstrated its capability to deliver decisive and precise strikes", the defence ministry said.

Ahead of crucial floor test, Vijay calls on Stalin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Monday called on his predecessor, DMK President MK Stalin at Vijay for his debt burden jibe. Later, Vijay called on MDMK founder Vaiko. Vijay's brief meeting with Stalin and Udhayanidhi happens days ahead of the crucial floor test in the TN Assembly to demonstrate the TVK regime's majority strength in the House on May 13. VCK, IUML and the Left parties that have extended support to the TVK are part of the DMK-led front. Vijay was accompanied by his cabinet colleague N Anand. Congress party, which has extended support to TVK is a former ally of the DMK. The party has five MLAs in the

had also indirectly hit out at the DMK for "multiple power centres" and had asserted that he was the only power centre in his TVK regime. DMK chief Stalin had hit back at Vijay for his debt burden jibe. Later, Vijay called on MDMK founder Vaiko. Vijay's brief meeting with Stalin and Udhayanidhi happens days ahead of the crucial floor test in the TN Assembly to demonstrate the TVK regime's majority strength in the House on May 13. VCK, IUML and the Left parties that have extended support to the TVK are part of the DMK-led front. Vijay was accompanied by his cabinet colleague N Anand. Congress party, which has extended support to TVK is a former ally of the DMK. The party has five MLAs in the



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, left, being felicitated by state former chief minister MK Stalin during a meeting in Tamil Nadu

PTI

234-member House. In the Assembly, TVK has 107 seats (after Vijay's resignation from Tiruchirappalli East) and the support of 13 MLAs of Congress, VCK, IUML and the Left parties. On Monday, Udhayanidhi initially welcomed Vijay with a handshake and a warm embrace upon the CM's arrival. Later, Stalin also hugged Vijay, held his hands and took him inside his house. Vijay and Stalin honoured each other with silk shawls and bouquet. Udhayanidhi presented a book on the historic political journey of the DMK "Kalathin Niram Karuppu Sivappu-DMK 75." The meeting comes after an acrimonious electoral battle between DMK and Vijay's TVK ahead of the April

23 polls, which the latter won. Vijay later proceeded to the residence of MDMK founder Vaiko and met the veteran leader. Vaiko's son Durai Vaiko welcomed Vijay. Vaiko presented a white silk shawl to Vijay and also garlanded him. The CM honoured Vaiko with a shawl. Later, the two leaders were seen briefly chatting and those present at Vaiko's residence greeted Vijay. Later, addressing reporters, Vaiko said Vijay has emerged as a big leader post elections and that the elections showed the people wanted a change. Lauding Vijay for reaching out to opposition leaders like him, Vaiko said the "signal being given out is that healthy politics should be encouraged in Tamil Nadu."

Keerthana takes oath after missing initial opportunity

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

The oath-taking of MLA-elects in the Tamil Nadu Assembly witnessed some interesting moments as a young woman minister initially failed to produce her election certificate, prompting her to go back for it, while another legislator mistakenly presented his party colleague's document before the mix-up was pointed out.

An AIADMK MLA broke down after seeing a portrait of late Chief Minister J Jayalalithaa, officials said. Hours later, Keerthana took the oath after submitting the certificate, they said. When the Assembly Principal Secretary K Srinivasan invited



Keerthana, announcing her name in the microphone, to take oath, she walked to the podium, which was right in front of the chair of the chief minister from one side. Also, MLAs who take oath would face the chair of the pro tem speaker.

While Keerthana neared the podium, Srinivasan raised his hand and asked her the certificate, which could be seen in the live coverage of the Assembly proceedings.

TN CM, newly elected MLAs take oath in Assembly

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, nine other ministers, former CMs including Edappadi K Palaniswami, former deputy CM Udhayanidhi Stalin and the newly elected MLAs on Monday took the oath of office in the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly. Pro-team Speaker MV Karuppaiah, praising Vijay's leadership and victory, initiated the proceedings on administration of the oath of office for MLAs in the first session of the 17th Assembly. The CM was the first to take oath as an MLA and ministers N Anand, Aadhav Arjuna, KG Arunraj, KA Sengottaiyan, P Venkataramanan, R Nirmalkumar, Rajmohan and TK Prabhu followed suit. Following this, DMK legislature party leader and



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay taking oath of office as a Member of the Legislative Assembly

PTI

former Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin, former CMs Palaniswami and O Panneerselvam (DMK), and other MLAs took oath of office. Vijay, Udhayanidhi and

Panneerselvam were among those who "solemnly affirmed" and took oath. Palaniswami and PMK's Sowmya Anbumani were among those who took oath in the name of God. Panrutti

AIADMK MLA K Mohan while taking oath suddenly broke down and hailed late chief minister J Jayalalithaa and with folded hands paid tributes to the portrait of the late AIADMK matriarch in the Assembly hall. When the Assembly Principal Secretary K Srinivasan invited Keerthana, announcing her name in the microphone, she walked to the podium, which was right in front of the chair of the CM from one side. Also, MLAs who take oath would face the chair of the pro tem speaker. While Keerthana neared the podium, Srinivasan raised his hand and asked her the certificate, which could be seen in the live coverage of the Assembly proceedings. However, she could not produce the certificate and what she replied to Srinivasan was not known.

Adhikari allocates portfolios to first 5 ministers

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

New West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Monday allocated portfolios among the first five members of his council of ministers. A Government order said senior BJP leader Dilip Ghosh was given charge of the Panchayat and Rural Development Department, along with Animal Resource Development and Agricultural Marketing. Agnimitra Paul was given the Women and Child Development and Social Welfare department and Municipal Affairs portfolios, while Ashok Kirtania was assigned the Food and Supplies and Co-operation departments, it said. Kshudiram Tudu was made minister for Tribal Development, Backward Classes Welfare and Minority Affairs and Madrasa Education. Nisith Pramanik was entrusted with the North Bengal Development Department along with Youth Services and Sports. "The rest of the departments will be looked after by Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari," the notification said. A senior BJP leader said the distribution of portfolios reflected the party's attempt to balance organisational experience with regional and social representation.



West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari addressing a press conference after the first Cabinet meeting of the State Government in Howrah on Monday

PTI

MANOJ AGARWAL APPOINTED CHIEF SECRETARY IN WEST BENGAL

Kolkata: West Bengal's Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Manoj Agarwal was appointed the chief secretary of the Suwendu Adhikari-led BJP Government in the State, according to an official order issued on Monday. Agarwal, a 1990-batch IAS officer of the West Bengal cadre, helmed the EC-mandated SIR exercise in the state in the run-up to the assembly polls in which around 91 lakh voters were removed from the electoral rolls. Incumbent Chief Secretary Dushyant Narijala was named Principal Resident Commissioner in New Delhi, the order stated. Nariwala, a 1993-batch IAS, was named the chief secretary of West Bengal by the poll body, removing Nandini Chakravorty from the position of the state's top bureaucrat. An IIT Kanpur alumnus, 59-year-old Agarwal has had a distinguished

administrative career, serving in several key departments of the West Bengal government, including Personnel and Administrative Reforms, Food, Fire and Emergency Services, and Forest, while also handling important positions at the Centre, officials said. He also served as the chairman of the State Highways Authority, planning the crucial elevated corridor over Kona Expressway, a major infrastructure upgrade designed to ease traffic congestion, featuring a six-lane elevated, signal-free path. As of now, the 7.8 km project, aimed at streamlining connectivity to the Kolkata port, is under construction. Kona Expressway is the arterial thoroughfare connecting Kolkata to the Delhi-bound National Highway 19 and the Mumbai-joining NH 16.

(PTI)

PM Modi to embark on 5-nation trip to UAE

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will undertake a six-day visit to the United Arab Emirates (UAE), the Netherlands, Sweden, Norway and Italy beginning Friday to further deepen India's bilateral ties amid the ongoing geopolitical upheavals. PM Modi's first destination will be the UAE, where he will meet President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan with an aim to advance the bilateral comprehensive strategic partnership and exchange views on the West Asia conflict. "The two leaders will have the opportunity to exchange views on bilateral issues, in particular energy cooperation, as well as regional and international issues of mutual interest," t-he

Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Monday. It said the visit will serve to promote the significant trade and investment linkages between the two countries. The UAE is India's third-largest trade partner and its seventh-largest source of investment cumulatively over the past 25 years. With the UAE hosting over 4.5 million-strong Indian community, the visit will also be an opportunity to discuss their welfare, the MEA said. In the second leg of his trip, Modi will visit the Netherlands from May 15 to 17. This will be his second trip to the Netherlands, following his visit in 2017. The Prime Minister will meet King Willem-Alexander and Queen Maxima, and hold talks with Prime Minister Rob Jetten. PM Modi's visit will build



TMC, BJP spar over SC nod to fresh pleas on voter deletions in West Bengal elections

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

The TMC on Monday claimed that the Supreme Court's decision to allow fresh petitions over SIR-induced voter removals in West Bengal validated its claim that the election results did not reflect the people's true mandate, as the party's defeat margins in several Assembly seats were "lower than the number of deleted electors". Rubbishing that claim, the BJP called the erstwhile Mamata Banerjee dispensation "sore losers", insisting that the poll data showed that it was the Trinamool Congress, and not the BJP, which fared better in seats where the maximum number of ineligible voters were deleted. The Supreme Court said former chief minister

Mamata Banerjee and others can file fresh applications regarding their claim that the victory margins in 31 constituencies in the recent assembly polls were less than the deletion of voters there during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalaya Bagchi took note of the submissions, after senior advocate and TMC MP Kalyan Banerjee referred to an earlier observation of Justice Bagchi that the court can look into the grievances if victory margins of opponents are less than the number of names deleted during the SIR. He claimed that there were 31 such seats. The bench was hearing a batch of petitions, including one filed by Mamata Banerjee, related to the SIR of

electoral rolls in the State. "We have, for now, drawn the court's attention to the 31 seats where our defeat margins were less than the number of deletions which took place during the 'Under Adjudication' phase of SIR. After this, we will inform the court about the seats where the defeat margins were between 5 and 20 per cent of the total deletions. "The number of such seats will go up significantly once we do that, establishing our claim that the people's mandate weren't truly reflected in the poll results," Kalyan Banerjee claimed. The MP alleged that the SIR exercise was held in a "non-transparent manner, and was manipulative" and "unscrupulously targeted a specific section of voters", whose voting rights were snatched to offer an unfair



advantage to the BJP. "There were CCTV cameras in booths and EVM storing strong rooms providing live feed to monitors outside. But, were there camera coverage at counting centres where the real game took place? There were at least 60 seats where our counting agents were beaten up and forced to leave the venue,"

he said. Kalyan Banerjee took to social media on Monday to post a picture of Bengal CEO Manoj Agarwal present at what appeared to be the first cabinet meeting of the Suwendu Adhikari-led BJP government in Bengal, the authenticity of which PTI couldn't independently verify, to vindicate his BJP and EC hand-in-glove claim.

"How can Manoj Agarwal, Chief Electoral Officer, be present in a cabinet meeting? It establishes deep connection of the CEO with the BJP during the elections. Existence of election was eye wash during election, and actually the election was conducted by the BJP party office," he wrote. Adding to his claims, TMC spokesperson and MLA-elect Kunal Ghosh alleged that the polls were vitiated by three factors, "electoral roll deletions, EVM manipulations and counting centre loot". "The total vote difference between us and the BJP was 32 lakh. The SIR deletion itself was three times that figure," Ghosh said. Responding sharply, the BJP maintained that TMC's claims weren't backed by poll data or SIR figures from the EC.

"We are aware of 49 seats where the SIR deletion figure is higher than the victory margin of candidates. Only 12 per cent of seats falling in this category went to the BJP, while the TMC won 26 per cent of those seats. In fact, both seats won by the Congress in these elections fall within this category, giving them a 100 per cent strike rate," said BJP spokesperson Keya Ghosh. In an earlier post on X, the BJP's IT cell head Amit Malviya claimed that the top five seats with the maximum deletion of ineligible electors during SIR were all won by the TMC. In contrast, seats with the least deletions were won by the BJP, he said. "It is absolutely clear that attributing BJP's victory to SIR deletions is not supported by data," Keya Ghosh said, adding, "The TMC is yet to

come to terms with the shock that the people of Bengal have rejected the party and how, uprooting it completely from the soil of the state." The BJP's Rajya Sabha MP Rahul Sinha echoed those sentiments, stating that the TMC should accept the clear mandate of people. "In the 2021 edition of state polls, there were 97 seats where the BJP's defeat margin was 1,000 votes or less. Even if, for argument's sake, we consider that the TMC would have won the 31 seats it is talking about, would they have come anywhere close to securing majority?" he said. "A loss is a loss and they should try to avoid attempts at camouflaging the shame of defeat with such frivolous legal petitions," he added.

Congress infighting in Kerala exposed: MA Baby

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

CPI(M) general secretary MA Baby on Monday took a swipe at the Congress-led UDF over the ongoing tussle for leadership positions in Kerala, saying the coalition's internal divisions had been "thoroughly exposed".

Talking to PTI Videos, Baby said a decision on the name of the leader of opposition (LoP) in Kerala would be decided by the CPI(M)'s State unit at an appropriate time.

"In fact, we need to discuss the LoP in Kerala when there is some guarantee that there is going to be a chief minister and the Assembly session is being convened," the CPI(M) general secretary said.

"As you all know, there is a race going on within the

Congress and the UDF as to who should be chosen as the chief minister. So, there is no hurry for the opposition to discuss and decide about the leader of the Opposition," Baby added.

He said the issue would be discussed in Kerala and "a proper decision" would be taken "at the right time".

Taking a dig at the Congress over the leadership race, Baby said the developments reflected a "very strange situation" within the party.

"They claim that this is a United Democratic Front, UDF; but there is no unity at the top level of the leading party of the UDF, which is the Congress," he said.

Baby also mocked the frequent consultations between Kerala and Delhi amid the



leadership discussions. "Dozens of people are flying from Kerala to Delhi and back to Thiruvananthapuram. So, it is benefiting only various airlines. People are not having

any benefit," he said. He also claimed that the Congress-led Governments in the State had often witnessed destabilisation arising from factional rivalries.

"Anyway, we will wait and see how it will evolve in the coming days," he added.

Earlier, addressing a press conference, Baby clarified that the CPI(M) Politburo

had not discussed the question of the LoP in Kerala, saying that the decision would be taken by the State unit itself.

The decision on the next Kerala chief minister is currently under consideration of the Congress high command, with VD Satheesan, KC Venugopal and Ramesh Chennithala being seen as contenders for the post.

The Congress high command has called former KPCC presidents and senior party leaders to New Delhi for discussions on Tuesday.

The CPI(M)-led LDF lost power in the just-concluded assembly elections and the alliance managed to win only 35 out of the 140 seats.

On the other hand, the Congress-led UDF secured 102 seats.

Police recover Maoist explosives bunker in Chhattisgarh



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bijapur

Police have recovered a cache of explosives, weapons and equipment allegedly hidden by Maoists in a forested hill area of Chhattisgarh's Bijapur district, an official said on Monday.

The recovery was made on Sunday evening from an underground bunker on a hilly area near Dodi Tumnar village under Gangoor police station limits, the official said.

Acting on a tip-off, a police team launched a search operation in the forested area and detected the bunker allegedly built by Maoists in the past to hide explosive materials and other equipment, he said. After undertaking demining and safety procedures, the team recovered a large quantity of Maoist materials from the site, the official informed.

The seized items included a country-made barrel grenade launcher (BGL), 29 BGL shells, around 50 metres of cord wire (a detonating cord used to trigger IEDs), two generators, two lathe

machines, an inverter, four batteries, eight solar panels, a motor, welding machine, drill machine, and two plastic drums, he said.

Security forces have intensified operations to trace and recover materials like explosives and weapons from forests across the Bastar region — comprising seven districts, including Bijapur — after the State Government declared Chhattisgarh free from armed Maoist activity on March 31. Based on inputs from surrendered Maoists and intelligence gathered from other sources over the past few months, security forces have recovered and defused hundreds of improvised explosive devices (IEDs) allegedly planted earlier by Naxalites across the Bastar range, police said.

During one such operation on May 2, four police personnel, including an inspector of the District Reserve Guard (DRG), were killed in Kanker district after a dump of gunpowder, allegedly hidden by Maoists in the past, exploded while a team was attempting to dispose it of.

Telangana CM slams PM Modi over gold purchase remark

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Monday hit out at PM Narendra Modi over his appeal to save forex through measures such as postponing gold purchases, alleging that it was an attempt to cover up the Centre's "failures" in foreign policy.

Reddy claimed Modi was effectively imposing an unofficial ban on gold purchases through such remarks.

"The Centre has failed completely in foreign policy. It should convene an all-party meeting on dealing with the fallout of the West Asia conflict. The government must build consensus and consult experts,"



he said during an informal interaction with media persons here.

Referring to Modi's "join me" remark at an official function in Hyderabad on Sunday, Reddy said there was no politics involved in either the event or the context. He said the PM was responding to his request for

expeditious clearances for the state government's development projects and had suggested that the state join the Centre's development efforts. The CM also alleged that the Centre's cooperation had fallen short of expectations, although some state project proposals had received clearances.

Telangana CM Reddy orders probe into POCSO case against Bandi Sanjay's son

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Hyderabad

Telangana CM A Revanth Reddy on Monday directed DGP CV Anand to constitute special teams and intensify the investigation into the POCSO case registered against Union Minister Bandi Sanjay Kumar's son, following allegations of sexual harassment of a minor girl.

The CM sought an explanation from the DGP as to why "no action" had been taken despite the complaint being registered on May 8, according to a release from the CMO.

The DGP reportedly explained that police officials and personnel had been occupied with security arrangements for PM Narendra Modi's visit to Hyderabad on May 10.

Reddy directed Anand to immediately begin the investigation into the case registered at the Pet Basheerabad Police Station against the union minister's son.

The case was registered following allegations of sexual harassment of a minor girl—a charge denied by the accused, who in turn alleged extortion and criminal intimidation by the teenager and her parents. According



to the 17-year-old girl's mother, Kumar's son Bhageerath, who was allegedly in a relationship with her daughter, had "sexually harassed" her.

Police said the alleged relationship began around seven to eight months ago.

Meanwhile, Bhageerath lodged a complaint with the police in Karimnagar, alleging that the girl, who had become acquainted with him, had invited him to family functions and group gatherings.

Last rites of minister Sudhakar performed with full State honour

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chitradurga (Karnataka)

The last rites of Karnataka Minister D Sudhakar were performed with full state honours at Challakere on Monday, as a large crowd gathered to bid their final adieu to the departed leader.

The last rites were performed as per Jain traditions, with his son Suhas lighting the funeral pyre.

The Planning and Statistics Minister died early Sunday at a private hospital in Bengaluru. He had been undergoing treatment for a lung infection for some time now.

Sudhakar, a senior Congress leader and the MLA from Hiriyur in Chitradurga district, was 66. He is survived by his wife, a son and a daughter. Chief Minister Siddaramaiah, Deputy CM DK Shivakumar, Karnataka Assembly Speaker UT Khader, and Home Minister G Parameshwara were

among the host of leaders who paid their last respects to the departed leader.

Sudhakar won his first election in 2004 from Challakere on a Congress ticket. He shifted his base to Hiriyur after Challakere became an ST-reserved constituency following delimitation. As Congress denied him the ticket in the 2008 Assembly polls, Sudhakar contested as an independent and won. He supported the then BS Yediyurappa-led BJP Government and became a Minister. He later returned to Congress and won from Hiriyur in 2013 and 2023.

According to the party leaders, Sudhakar was also a businessman who often donated to serve the needy. They said that despite being from the minority Jain community, which has a very small presence in the region, he enjoyed popularity and had political grip in both Hiriyur and Challakere.



Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah and Deputy Chief Minister DK Shivakumar console family members during the last rites of minister D Sudhakar in Challakere, Chitradurga district, Karnataka



Union Minister Pralhad Joshi flags off new train services connecting Hubballi to Vijayapura and Hubballi to Rishikesh at the Hubballi railway station in Dharwad district, Karnataka on Monday

Two cheetahs released into wild in Kuno

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Sheopur (MP)

Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav on Monday released two cheetahs brought from Botswana into an open forest in the Kuno National Park following the completion of their quarantine period.

The reintroduction of cheetahs brought from Nigeria, South Africa, and now Botswana is achieving consistent success, and today Madhya Pradesh has earned nationwide recognition as the 'Cheetah State', the CM said on the occasion.

Yadav released female cheetahs, with identification numbers CCV-2 and CCV-3, at a site on the banks

of the Kuno River. This will give impetus to 'Project Cheetah' and add another important chapter to India's wildlife conservation history, an official said. The objective of Project Cheetah is to restore the endangered animal species in the state, increase their numbers, and prepare them for free hunting and roaming.

CM Yadav said that Madhya Pradesh has embraced cheetahs and made them a part of its family.

"The cheetah reintroduction project was launched in Kuno about three and a half years ago by the country's illustrious Prime Minister Narendra Modi, and it is progressing successfully. Madhya Pradesh is setting new

records in this important project," the CM said.

Madhya Pradesh is emerging as a major centre for religion, investment, and genetic biodiversity, he noted. After releasing the two cheetahs, CM Yadav toured the Kuno National Park. Nine cheetahs — six females and three males — brought from Botswana to Kuno in February had been kept in small enclosures to allow them to adapt to local conditions. They have now completed their quarantine period.

With the arrival of these cheetahs, the total number of cheetahs in India, including domestically born cubs, increased to 57, the official said.

Parked buses catch fire at depot in Indore; no casualties

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Indore

Three empty buses caught fire, causing explosions at a private depot in Madhya Pradesh's Indore on Monday, police said.

No casualties were reported in the blaze that broke out at a bus depot located near a residential colony in the Musakhedi area, said Lokesh Singh Bhadoria, in-charge of the Azad Nagar police station.

Three buses and six motorcycles parked at the depot were completely gutted in the fire, he said.

"The fire brigade has brought the blaze under control. The cause of the fire



Dark smoke billows after a fire broke out at a private bus parking yard in the Teen Imli area of Indore on Monday

is being ascertained," Bhadoria said.

According to locals, empty passenger buses caught fire, causing explosions, triggering panic in the area as people rushed out of their homes.

They further alleged that although a similar fire had occurred at the depot previously, passenger buses continued to be parked in the residential area, posing a threat to lives and property.

Women-led cafe set up 13,000 ft to boost tourism in East Sikkim

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Gangtok

A cafe with all-women staff has been set up close to the Baba Harbhajan Singh Shrine in East Sikkim at an altitude of 13,000 feet with the Indian Army's help for the economic empowerment of communities in remote areas, an official said on Monday.

A public relations officer of the Army said the initiative reflects resilience, enterprise and self-reliance in the remote



high-altitude region, and is expected to further enhance visitor experience in the area. The project has been conceptualised and facilitated by the Trishakti Corps in coordination with civil administration and local stakeholders, a statement from the Army said.

As part of the broader Ranbhoomi Darshan initiative, it aims to promote tourism in the areas while showcasing the region's heritage and strategic significance, it added.

Bihar Govt launches portal, helpline number to resolve people's grievances

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Monday launched an online portal and a helpline number for prompt resolution of people's grievances concerning Government departments in the State, officials said.

The 'Sahyog Portal' and toll-free helpline number '1100' was rolled out during the day for the purpose, they said.

The CM made it clear that

strict departmental action, including suspension, would be initiated against those who fail to act on applications listed on the portal and issue orders accordingly within 30 days.

"The issues will be resolved within 30 days by organising 'Sahyog' camps at the panchayat level. Concerned district magistrates (DMs) and superintendents of police (SPs) will monitor the process in real time. Work is underway to install CCTV cameras in all

blocks, circle offices, and police stations for constant monitoring of activities of officials," Choudhary said.

"Resolving problems of the common people is the top priority of the Bihar Government. Under the initiative, 'Sahyog' camps will be organised at the panchayat level on the first and third Tuesday of every month. Applications may be submitted both online and offline. Every application will be disposed of within 30 days, and



Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary during a meeting with Bihar Legislative Council Chairman Awadhesh Narain Singh in Patna

compliance details will be uploaded on the Sahyog Portal," he said.

The objective of the 'Sahyog' camps is to resolve citizens' problems in an integrated and transparent manner, said the CM.

"The Bihar Government is continuously striving to resolve the problems of ordinary citizens effectively and within a fixed timeframe," he said.

Choudhary said former chief minister Nitish Kumar had also undertaken several

public outreach tours, and made every effort to ensure prompt resolution of people's grievances.

"If the officer concerned fails to dispose of an application and issue an order within 30 days, or shows negligence, they will automatically be suspended on the 31st day.

"An online mechanism is also being put in place whereby the suspension order format against negligent officials will automatically be generated on the portal," the CM said.



Editor's
TAKE

Rising crime against
senior citizens

As India moves steadily towards becoming an ageing nation, ensuring safety, dignity and emotional security for senior citizens must become a national priority

India, at present, is a young nation, but is ageing rapidly. By 2050, the country will have a significant elderly population. As the country progresses and new technologies emerge, they also have a downside: they are alienating a large section of society - senior citizens who find it difficult to cope with evolving technology and changing times. They are increasingly becoming vulnerable as the joint family system gives way to nuclear families and fast-paced life becomes the norm. They often find themselves emotionally, physically and mentally vulnerable. Adding to this, some people take advantage of their vulnerability and exploit them for personal gain. It is both disturbing and shameful that there is a steady rise in crimes against senior citizens, which reflects a society undergoing rapid social and economic change without creating adequate systems of care and protection for its elderly.

According to the latest National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) report, crimes against citizens aged 60 and above are on the rise. Crimes against the elderly rose by nearly 17 per cent in 2024, increasing from 26,306 cases in 2023 to 31,067 cases this year. While Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra continue to remain among the worst places for the elderly, Delhi leads metropolitan cities in crimes against senior citizens. This is a disturbing statistic. It is not merely a law-and-order issue; it reflects the neglect and insecurity faced by those who were once the backbone of families and the nation.

Urbanisation and migration have weakened the traditional joint family system, while no adequate support system has emerged in its place. Many children leave home for employment opportunities, leaving ageing parents to fend for themselves. Their dependency makes them easy targets for theft, fraud, cheating and physical abuse.

Increasing digitalisation has also exposed many elderly people to cyber fraud, financial scams and identity theft, as their familiarity with digital technologies may be limited. Often, abuse comes from within families themselves, driven by property disputes, inheritance conflicts or financial dependence. The decline in social values and respect for elders has created a silent crisis that is rarely discussed. Many elderly people hesitate to report crimes because of fear and the difficulties associated with legal procedures. As a result, many continue to suffer in silence. The real scale of the problem may therefore be much larger than official figures suggest. Addressing this challenge requires both institutional reform and societal introspection. There is a strong case for dedicated senior citizen cells within police departments and regular monitoring of elderly people living alone. Community policing and periodic welfare visits can improve their sense of security. Technology can also play an important role through emergency helplines, wearable alert systems and awareness campaigns on cyber safety. Resident welfare associations, local communities and civil society organisations must create networks to regularly engage with and assist senior citizens. If senior citizens continue to live in fear and insecurity, it will represent not just a failure of governance, but also a failure of society.

The global failure to protect women

Weak enforcement and the absence of a binding global framework against violence towards women continue to shatter lives, weaken economies, erode public trust and stall social progress across the world



ARCHANA
DATTA

The latest World Bank report, Women, Business and the Law, after reviewing 190 world economies, revealed that only 4 per cent of women worldwide enjoy full legal equality. The countries in which women have such equal legal rights, scoring 100/100, are Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Greece, Iceland, Ireland, Latvia, Luxembourg, Portugal, Spain and Sweden, and more recently, Germany and the Netherlands (WEF). Women in India have only 60 per cent of the legal rights granted to men, lower than the global average of 64.2 per cent. Nevertheless, Indian women fared better than their South Asian counterparts, where there is only 45.9 per cent of legal protection comparable to men.

The World Bank's 2026 report showed a considerable dip in the overall global percentage of women enjoying equal rights from 77 per cent in 2024 to 64 per cent in 2025, which the report attributed to the inclusion of 'safety for women' as one of the critical indicators in the overall assessment. While the UN Women and UN System reports in 2026 highlighted that justice systems have been failing women in protecting them from violence and discrimination. In over 54 per cent of countries, rape is still not defined based on consent, and in nearly 3 out of 4 countries (74 per cent), laws still permit child marriage, often through exceptions regarding consent. In 112 countries, marital rape is still not criminalised. Around 1.8 billion women live in countries which do not specifically protect them from online abuse. While in 44 per cent of countries, the law does not mandate equal pay for work of equal value.

Nevertheless, the number of countries having laws against violence against women (VAW) has grown significantly. However, legal experts and researchers contend that many of them are not 'comprehensive legislations', lacking clear conceptualisation of different forms of VAW - physical, sexual, psychological or economic - covering private and public spheres, and often falling short of adopting a holistic and multi-sectoral approach with measures for prevention, protection, prosecution, and reparations. As of 2026, at least 162 countries have laws against domestic violence, but only about 55 per cent of them have all-encompassing provisions. In 151 countries, there are laws prohibiting sexual harassment in the workplace, but only 39 countries have specific laws addressing it in public spaces. According to Women, Business and the Law 2024, countries have established less than 40 per cent of the frame-



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works necessary to effectively implement laws against child marriage, sexual harassment, domestic violence, and femicide, creating an 'enforcement deficit'.

In India, women's safety laws have definitely undergone changes with new Acts and amendments to the existing ones in the aftermath of the 2012 Nirbhaya episode and through the recent Bharatiya Naya Sanhita updates. However, the latest ground reports reveal a dual reality, indicating that the legal protections for women's safety remain confined largely 'on paper', with a stark 'on-ground' disconnect, driven by systemic failures such as pervasive under-reporting, an abysmally poor conviction rate, tardy judicial processes, inefficiency in resource utilisation and absence of women's representation in law enforcement and justice dispensation mechanisms. While a 2025 multi-state field analysis suggested that legal and policy frameworks must move beyond reactive and scheme-based interventions towards a coordinated and survivor-centred institutional ecosystem, strengthening accountability mechanisms, inter-departmental coordination, and investing in long-term rehabilitation and reintegration. Some social scientists also contend that the issues of gender and labour force participation should be seriously addressed, as law-and-order and safety concerns intersect with each other, limiting women's economic empowerment and mobility (Saha, 2014).

While national laws are often handicapped by 'implementation gaps', at the global level there is a significant 'normative gap' with no single, legally binding global treaty dedicated specifically to ending VAW, and no uniform definition of violence or a specific international monitoring body with the power to hold erring states legally accountable. The world is run more

on a patchwork of broad anti-discrimination treaties and non-binding 'soft law' declarations, mostly emanating from the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW). The Convention also has several limitations, and its original 1979 text does not explicitly define or even mention any form of VAW, such as serious offences like 'rape' or 'domestic abuse'. The CEDAW Committee only interpreted violence against women as a form of discrimination. However, the subsequent Declaration on the Elimination of Violence against Women (DEVAW) addressed the issue, but it is only a resolution, not even a treaty, and is not legally binding on states. Global legal frame-

works also failed to keep pace with new forms of violence committed in digital spaces such as AI-generated deepfakes or non-consensual pornographic images, 90-95 per cent of which depict women.

Now, when justice is denied to women and girls, the damage goes far beyond any single case.... it creates all-pervasive impacts, eroding public trust, weakening the rule of law and denying institutions their legitimacy (UN Women). It also has repercussions for the economy, as it has been estimated that elimination of discriminatory laws and practices could increase the global GDP by more than 20 per cent, almost doubling the global growth rate over the next decade (World Bank). Moreover, the economic costs of VAW not only affect the victims or survivors but also the state and communities, both tangibly and intangibly. While nations must further strengthen their legislative, supportive and enforcement frameworks against VAW, they must also come together for a legally binding global treaty to standardise protections and eliminate legal impunity worldwide for a just, prosperous and equitable world.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

When a few flout rules, all pay the price



SANJAY
CHANDRA

2ND
OPINION

A recent conversation with my wife and daughter proved revealing, bringing together observations from within our residential society. My wife had taken the initiative to set up an in-house compost plant within the condominium, aligned with state regulations that mandate bulk waste generators to process their own waste, failing which penalties may be imposed. Yet, what followed was resistance. Several residents opposed the move, citing concerns about foul odour.

One argument was that the government itself is failing in its duties, and that the sight of uncollected garbage in public spaces stands as evidence of this apathy; in such a scenario, our own lapses seemed inconsequential. The estate management staff remains indifferent; for them, the plant exists more in form than in function.

It is convenient because when responsibility is diffused across a system, accountability tends to disappear. What is perhaps overlooked in such resistance is that these measures are not merely regulatory burdens, but responses to a growing environmental crisis. When a few choose not to comply, the consequences do not remain confined to them but are passed on to everyone else.

This is evident not only in how we handle waste, but also in how we engage with shared resources such as water, reflected in steadily declining groundwater levels. A neighbour had once suggested that there was a need to ration water supply within the society. My immediate response was shaped by a different expectation - that one of the reasons for moving into a builder apartment was uninterrupted water supply.

My daughter was direct in her assessment, arguing that rationing would eventually become inevitable, because without restraint, survival itself would be at risk. Her view, though uncomfortable, carried a certain inevitability, and it raised a larger and more difficult question, one that extends beyond water to many such instances of rule-flouting: should a few be made to bear the consequences for the actions of others?

There is a tendency to justify violations simply

because others have done the same. A number of residents, including some office-bearers of the Residents' Welfare Association, have chosen to cover their kitchen balconies despite builder guidelines prohibiting such modifications due to fire safety concerns and stipulations from the gas supplier. When one such office-bearer was requested to rectify the alteration, the response was not one of compliance, but of deflection - suggesting that the matter be taken up first with another senior member who had committed a similar breach.

What makes this more concerning is that such disregard rarely remains an individual act; it gradually alters the system itself, where the consequences are no longer limited to those who default, but are borne collectively, often by those who have complied. Systems exist to create order, but they depend on individuals to sustain them, and when rules become negotiable, the system itself begins to erode. The answer, then, may lie in recognising that individual responsibility and systemic reform must

operate together. When responsibility is shared without accountability, the consequences are borne by all, even when the failure lies with a few.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The writer is founder of Kala - Krazy About Literature And Arts, is an author, speaker, coach, arbitrator, and strategy consultant

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

When parenting turns into competition

The article on school WhatsApp groups and parenting anxiety captures a growing yet under-discussed social problem. What began as a simple communication tool has gradually turned into a marketplace of comparison. Every uploaded certificate, Olympiad medal, coding class achievement, foreign trip or "perfect" progress report silently pushes parents towards competitive parenting and children towards performance anxiety.

Comparison slowly erodes confidence. Children begin to link self-worth with rankings and validation, while parents mistake anxiety for responsibility. Schools must recognise that education is not a corporate race.. Childhood cannot become a résumé-building exercise driven by constant competition. Parent WhatsApp groups should remain limited to essential academic communication rather than becoming spaces for displaying privilege and achievement. Equally important, parents must understand that every child grows at a different pace and possesses different strengths. A generation raised under relentless comparison may appear accomplished outwardly, yet remain deeply insecure within. Confidence grows through encouragement, emotional security and individuality - not endless benchmarking.

HARSH PAWARIA | ROHTAK

Sacred spaces need responsibility

Apropos "Cleaning up India's sacred and scenic spaces" (11 May 2026), the Supreme Court's directive to enforce waste management rules at tourist and pilgrimage sites is welcome, but it risks repeating a familiar pattern where judicial urgency collides with administrative inertia. We have witnessed this cycle repeatedly: orders are issued, committees formed, and public spaces briefly cleaned before neglect returns with the next tourist season or festival.

The court's emphasis on monitoring is important, but without proper funding it achieves little. Many municipalities lack scientific landfills, trained staff and even basic waste collection systems. While the proposal to use corporate social responsibility funds is practical, CSR cannot replace long-term public investment. AA dedicated cleanliness cess on tourism and pilgrimage revenue could support sustainable waste infrastructure. More importantly, public spaces must stop being treated as somebody else's responsibility.

Laws alone cannot create civic discipline. Pilgrimage committees, hotel associations and local bodies must be made accountable for cleanliness, while religious leaders should actively promote environmental responsibility as part of spiritual duty.

K CHIDANAND KUMAR | BENGALURU

Congress Leadership Crisis In Kerala

A week after dislodging the UDF in Kerala's Assembly elections, Congress faces mounting suspense over its Chief Ministerial choice among heavyweights VD Satheesan, Ramesh Chennithala and KC Venugopal. The delay exposes deep-rooted factionalism and the high command's struggle to reconcile regional power centres, often appearing reactive rather than decisive.

In contrast, the BJP's centralised model has ensured quicker leadership decisions — as seen in West Bengal, Assam and Puducherry — projecting organisational discipline and public unity after internal consultations.

The prolonged balancing act encourages intense lobbying, risks alienating factions and could reopen latent fault lines, potentially triggering rebellion or administrative paralysis. Kerala's history of strong groupism further magnifies these risks, threatening to dilute the momentum of the electoral victory and raising questions about the high command's ability to enforce consensus. Swift arbitration and reconciliation are now essential to convert electoral success into stable governance. Otherwise, internal divisions may overshadow the mandate received from the people. Congress must resolve its leadership uncertainty quickly to preserve unity.

SK PRABHAKAR | GURUGRAM

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LIGHTS, CAMERA, LEADERSHIP
AND THE GOVERNANCE TEST

The swearing-in ceremony of actor-turned-politician Joseph Vijay appeared less like a conventional political event and more like a real-life trailer for Jananayagan 2. The atmosphere, presentation style and Vijay's dialogue-driven speech reminded many of his larger-than-life screen persona. As Tamil Nadu's new Chief Minister, he has already generated enormous public expectations through the ambitious welfare promises made during the election campaign.

During his address, Vijay defended the government's cautious approach towards implementing its promises. He stated that the State exchequer had been severely strained by years of financial mismanagement and that Tamil Nadu's debt burden had crossed ₹10 lakh crore. To justify the government's position, he announced that a detailed

White Paper on the State's financial condition would soon be released. Vijay also appealed to the public to grant his administration adequate time to fulfil its commitments.

What attracted the greatest attention, however, was the unmistakably cinematic tone of his speech. Many observers felt his style resembled powerful movie dialogues rather than a conventional political address. His announcement of 200 free electricity units for households consuming below 500 units immediately captured public attention.

Yet, beyond the excitement surrounding his rise, Vijay now faces the far more difficult task of balancing populist expectations with financial and administrative realities.

AP THIRUVAD | CHENNAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Familiar waters, fatal neglect: Lessons from the Narmada Disaster

India already has the laws, expertise, and resources needed to prevent such disasters. What is required now is the determination to implement them. As has been rightly pointed out, the challenge is not the ability to act, but the willingness to do so. If this incident leads to genuine reform, it may serve a purpose beyond the tragedy itself



SATENDRA SINGH

The recent capsizing of a tourist cruise at Bargi Dam in Madhya Pradesh claimed several lives. This is not just a tragic accident; it highlights a serious failure that keeps costing lives across India. The image of a mother holding her four-year-old son in his last moments shows both human bravery and a failure of institutions. These tragedies are not due to

fate; they are the result of neglect, complacency, and poor enforcement of safety rules.

What happened on the Narmada was sadly familiar, not because it was inevitable, but because it reflects a pattern India has seen too often. Survivors describe how the weather changed suddenly. Strong winds hit the reservoir, and the boat began to tip. Panic spread fast as water poured into the vessel. Passengers realised too late that there were no effective safety measures. There were not enough life jackets, no safety briefing, and no clear effort from the crew to handle the emergency. Within minutes, a relaxing outing turned into a desperate fight for survival.

This incident mirrors earlier tragedies, like the recent boat accident in the Yamuna near Mathura. There, similar issues — overcrowding, lack of safety gear, and ignoring weather warnings — led to multiple deaths. These ongoing problems raise an urgent question: why does India keep facing such avoidable disasters when it has clear laws and regulations?

The answer lies not in the absence of rules, but in their consistent violation. India's legal framework for inland water transport is strong. The Inland Vessels Act, 2021, and related safety regulations clearly require vessel certification, regular inspections, limits on passenger capacity, and mandatory safety equipment. On paper, the system looks thorough. In practice, though, enforcement is weak and often superficial.

Boats continue to operate without proper certification or inspection. Operators often ignore passenger limits, especially in tourist areas. Safety equipment is sometimes inadequate or completely missing. Weather advisories, when issued, are not always taken seriously. As noted in earlier discussions, the real issue is the "large gap between policy and practice", where compliance becomes optional and safety negotiable.

Operators are also a concern. Their main motivation often seems to be profit rather than safety. Each extra passenger means more revenue, and spending on safety is seen as an unnecessary cost. In the Bargi incident, there are claims that warnings about worsening weather were ignored and that the crew did not respond effectively as conditions deteriorated. The fact that the captain survived with a life jacket while passengers faced dangers without basic protection raises serious ethical questions about responsibility and preparedness.

However, it would be too easy to blame only the operators. Regulatory authorities also share the responsibility. If a vessel can operate without meeting safety standards, it shows a failure in oversight. Inspections, when they happen, are often brief. Monitoring systems are either weak or non-existent. Furthermore, having multiple agencies involved - such as tourism departments, local administration, police, and disaster response teams - often leads to fragmented accountability. In such a system, lapses can go unnoticed until a tragedy occurs.

Another key issue is the failure to consider weather information in operational decisions. Sudden storms and high winds are common in large bodies of water like reservoirs. Modern forecasting systems can provide timely warnings, yet these are often ignored or downplayed. Choosing to go ahead with a leisure cruise despite bad conditions shows a deeper culture of risk denial.

At the heart of these problems is a lack of a safety culture. Safety is often seen as a formality rather than a crucial requirement. Passengers rarely question overcrowding or ask for life jackets. Operators seldom give safety briefings. Authorities rarely enforce compliance with the seriousness it needs. As long as safety is secondary to convenience or profit, such incidents will keep happening.

The Bargi tragedy also shows a consistent failure to learn from past incidents. India has experienced many boat accidents over the years - in Assam, Bihar, Kerala, and Uttar Pradesh - each met with public outrage, official statements, and promises of tougher enforcement. Yet, over time, these promises fade, and the system returns to its former state.



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As noted in previous reflections, the lessons that could prevent future disasters are often lost in a cycle of reaction and forgetfulness.

Breaking this cycle requires more than small changes; it needs a fundamental shift in approach. Enforcement of safety regulations must be strict and unwavering. Vessels should not be allowed to operate without proper certification, and violations should lead to significant penalties. In cases of gross negligence that result in loss of life, criminal liability must be clearly defined.

Technology has the potential to be a game-changer. With real-time vessel monitoring via GPS, digital tracking of passenger counts, and the integration of weather alerts into operational systems, safety can be greatly improved. But technology is not a magic fix for accountability. It needs to be backed by a strong commitment from institutions and a culture of transparency.

Building capacity is just as crucial. Crew members should receive training not just in navigation, but also in handling emergencies. Regular drills and safety audits should become the norm, especially in high-risk areas like popular tourist spots. Preparedness should not be an afterthought; it should be woven into the fabric of operations.

Public awareness is another vital piece of the puzzle. Passengers need to be empowered to take their safety seriously - asking for life jackets, questioning unsafe practices, and refusing to board overcrowded boats. A safety culture cannot simply be dictated from the top; it has to become a shared social value.

Lastly, emergency response systems must be strengthened. Quick and coordinated rescue efforts can save lives. In the Bargi incident, rescue teams managed to save several people, but delays and limitations in response capabilities may have cost others. Pre-positioning rescue resources and improving coordination among agencies can make a significant difference in critical situations.

The tragedy at the Narmada is not just a local issue; it resonates nationally. As India expands its tourism industry and promotes more recreational activities around water bodies, the risks associated with these activities will also rise. Addressing these risks requires a proactive and sustained commitment to safety.

At the end of the day, it all comes down to what society chooses to prioritise. Development loses meaning if it comes at the cost of human lives. Safety should not be viewed as something negotiable; it must be treated as a fundamental requirement for progress.

The heartbreaking losses at Bargi Dam should serve as a wake-up call. They force us to confront uncomfortable truths about negligence, failures in governance, and society's approach to safety. More importantly, they compel action to ensure that such tragedies are not repeated.

India already has the laws, expertise, and resources needed to prevent such disasters. What is required now is the determination to implement them. As has been rightly pointed out, the challenge is not the ability to act, but the willingness to do so. If this incident leads to genuine reform, it may serve a purpose beyond the tragedy itself. If not, it will become just another entry in a long list of preventable disasters — briefly mourned, then forgotten, until the next one occurs.

Why India needs rules to manage oil shocks



GOURAV VALLABH

The headlines from West Asia and Eastern Europe carry the same uncomfortable subtext: the price of crude oil is no longer determined solely by supply and demand. It is shaped by sanctions, shipping disruptions, fragile ceasefires, and the calculations of producer cartels that often find higher prices congenial. Brent crude has held close to USD 95 a barrel for several months, and experience from 2008 and 2022 suggests that such geopolitical premia tend to persist.

For India, which imports more than 85 per cent of the crude oil it consumes, this is not an abstract

concern. Every USD 10-per-barrel increase in crude prices typically raises pump prices by about ₹4.5 per litre, placing pressure on household budgets. Yet retail fuel prices have remained largely unchanged since May 2022, despite considerable volatility in global markets. This apparent calm reflects a form of managed stability. Oil marketing companies — Indian Oil, Bharat Petroleum, and Hindustan Petroleum — have absorbed a significant portion of the volatility. Estimates suggest that this entails substantial under-recoveries on both petrol and diesel, with corresponding effects on profitability and investment capacity.

Such arrangements, while providing short-term predictability, carry broader economic implications. The first investment: resources absorbed at the retail level are resources not deployed towards refinery modernisation, green hydrogen, and the wider energy transition that India will inevitably navigate. The second is expectations: even without engaging deeply with petroleum economics, citizens recognise patterns, including the likelihood of deferred adjustments over time.

The third implication is more subtle but equally important: the attenuation of the price signal itself. When fuel prices remain static, consumption patterns adjust less dynamically. Households do not recalibrate commuting choices, and logistics operators have limited incentives to optimise routes. Over time, the economy forgoes the incremental adjustments that cumulatively build resilience to external shocks.

The argument for moving to a rule-based system is rooted in practicality, not ideology. What is needed is a simple, transparent framework that replaces discretion with predictability. One way to do this is to define a normal price band for crude oil, say USD 65 to 90 per barrel, within which retail fuel prices adjust freely in line



with global markets. When prices move beyond this band, an automatic sharing mechanism can come into play: part of the increase is absorbed through calibrated reductions in central excise, while the rest is passed on to consumers.

Crucially, the system should work both ways. When global prices fall, a portion of the gains can be set aside into a stabilisation fund, with the remainder passed through to consumers. Over time, this creates a self-correcting buffer: good years finance the difficult ones. The result is a system that is predictable, even-handed, and less reliant on ad hoc interventions, while still protecting both consumers and fiscal stability.

India is well-positioned to operationalise such an approach. The digital public infrastructure developed over the past decade — from Aadhaar to UPI and direct benefit transfers — offers a robust foundation for targeted support in exceptional circumstances. In periods of sharp price increases, vulnerable groups such as farmers, transport operators, and low-income households could receive calibrated assistance without distorting price signals across the board.

Importantly, the broader reform orientation of the Narendra Modi government, particularly its emphasis on transparency, digitisation, and institutional capacity-building, provides a strong enabling context for advancing such rule-based frameworks in energy pricing. A durable framework would also require alignment across stakeholders. Oil marketing companies would benefit from greater predictability in pass-through mechanisms. State governments could play a complementary role by ensuring that tax adjustments remain consistent with broader stabilisation objectives. Consumers, in turn, would gradually adapt to modest and regular price movements as a normal feature of a responsive system.

India has successfully implemented far more complex reforms. The Goods and Services Tax required sustained coordination across jurisdictions, and the Aadhaar ecosystem evolved through iterative refinement before achieving scale. Compared to these, a rule-based fuel stabilisation mechanism is technically modest. The necessary data and policy instruments already exist; what remains is their systematic integration.

In an increasingly uncertain global energy environment, the objective is not to eliminate volatility but to manage it with clarity and consistency. A framework that combines market signals with institutional safeguards can strengthen both economic resilience and policy credibility. As geopolitical uncertainties persist, such an approach would position India to navigate external shocks with greater confidence and stability.

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KUSHAN MITRA

The West Asia crisis has once again exposed the central vulnerability of India's energy economy: it is still dependent on a narrow and fragile supply corridor, and the Strait of Hormuz remains its biggest strategic choke point.

When that route is disrupted, India does not merely face a supply problem. It faces a fiscal problem, an inflation problem, and a policy problem all at once.

For the moment, the government has chosen to absorb the shock rather than pass it on to consumers. That has prevented panic and preserved supply stability. But it has also pushed the cost of the crisis into the public balance sheet, where it is beginning to crowd out other priorities. This is why the current fuel pricing strategy deserves a harder review than it is likely to get in public debate. The Strait of Hormuz matters because it is not just one shipping lane among many. It is one of the world's most important energy arteries, and India remains deeply exposed to it. A crisis there quickly becomes a crisis in refinery margins, import bills, freight rates, insurance premia, and ultimately government finances. The geopolitical risk is obvious. The economic cost is what gets hidden.

What the government has bought

India's immediate response has been competent. Domestic LPG production was raised, allocation priorities were reset, alternative crude sourcing was widened, and public sector oil companies were used as shock absorbers. Recent government briefings have also said that supply remains stable, refineries are operating normally, and the country is now drawing crude from more than 40 suppliers, with a much smaller share of imports dependent on Hormuz than in the past.

That is not trivial. It is the result of years of work on terminals, pipelines, refining capacity, import diversification, and strategic stock planning. The country is better prepared than it was a decade ago, and that has clearly helped. But preparedness and affordability are not the same thing. The fact that India can absorb the shock does not mean it should absorb it forever at the same price.

The government's fuel policy has already done what it was designed to do in the short term: keep the pump stable and avoid a visible consumer crisis. The question now is whether that stability has become too expensive to maintain.

Fuel prices matter

Fuel prices are not just a retail issue. They are a signal mechanism. When the state suppresses them for too long, it distorts consumption, weakens the incentive to conserve, and forces the burden onto the exchequer. That may be acceptable in a short, acute emergency. It is less



defensible if the shock is prolonged and global crude remains elevated.

There is also a political illusion at work here. A stable petrol pump looks like stability in the economy, but it may simply mean the cost has been moved elsewhere. It shows up in foregone revenue, in oil company under-recoveries, and in reduced room for strategic investment. That matters at a time when India needs more money for storage, refining, logistics, and the energy transition.

In other words, keeping fuel artificially cheap is not free public policy. It is deferred payment. And deferred payment is a poor way to manage a recurring strategic risk.

The case for a gradual rise

This is not an argument for a sudden shock at the pump. That would be politically reckless and economically unnecessary. It is an argument for a gradual upward correction once the immedi-

ate crisis stabilises. A phased increase would be easier to absorb, easier to explain, and far more sustainable than indefinite price suppression.

There is a strong macroeconomic case for this. If global crude stays high, the difference between import cost and domestic retail price has to be financed somewhere. Either consumers pay it, taxpayers pay it, or public sector balance sheets pay it. The last two options are effectively the same burden, just hidden differently. A controlled increase in fuel prices would make that burden explicit and reduce the long-term fiscal drag.

The deeper argument is strategic. India is trying to build a more resilient energy system, and that requires capital. Strategic reserves need expansion. Domestic refining needs more flexibility. Logistics need more redundancy. Clean-energy transition assets need scale. All of that requires fiscal space. Higher fuel prices, if introduced carefully, can help create that space.

What India should learn

The real lesson of the West Asia crisis is not that the government should have done less. It is that resilience has a price and that the bill cannot always be paid by the state alone. India has already made meaningful progress in diversification and infrastructure, and that has clearly softened the blow. But the next phase of policy cannot be based on the assumption that the government will permanently stand between the global oil market and the Indian consumer. That model works only up to a point. Beyond that, it becomes fiscally corrosive. If the crisis contin-

ues, then some of the adjustment must be shared by the consumer, even if gradually. That is the only way to preserve the state's capacity to spend on the buffers that make future shocks less painful. The government should therefore begin preparing the political ground for a calibrated rise in fuel prices, ideally linked to a broader energy security narrative. The message is simple: India is stronger than it was, but not strong enough to pretend that global energy shocks can be absorbed without cost.

Conclusion

The West Asia crisis has tested India's energy system and, for now, it has held. That is a success. But the very measures that protected consumers have also revealed the limits of the current pricing framework. India should not rush to raise fuel prices, but it should stop pretending that permanently low prices are a sustainable answer to a permanent strategic vulnerability. A gradual increase in fuel prices would not be popular. It would, however, be more honest, more fiscally responsible, and more consistent with the long-term task of building energy security. In a crisis like this, the right question is not whether consumers should feel pain. It is whether the state can afford to keep hiding it.

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Order Order

SC grants anticipatory bail to Canadian citizen in rape case

The Supreme Court has granted anticipatory bail to a Canadian citizen accused in a rape case, saying that based on unverified allegations, it cannot be held that he is required to be morally condemned.

A bench of Justices Aravind Kumar and PB Varale granted relief to Manpreet Singh Gill, a Canadian citizen, who was booked for rape by the Punjab police on a complaint filed by a woman.

The police lodged the complaint on November 11, 2025, by the woman, who alleged that she was misled about his marital status and had developed a relationship. She alleged that Gill threatened her with dire consequences to withdraw an earlier complaint and had a sexual relationship with her on the intervening night of 9th and November 10, 2025, after administering alcohol and intimidating her.

Gill, who has challenged the order of the Punjab and Haryana High Court denying him pre-arrest bail through his lawyer advocate Sana Raees Khan contended that the relationship was consensual. Khan argued that the FIR was driven by an extortionist motive, pointing out that the complainant was fully aware of his marital status from the very inception of their relationship.

She further highlighted material inconsistencies, noting that while the alleged video was claimed to have been received on November 2, 2025, there was a conspicuous omission of this crucial allegation in the FIR lodged on November 11, 2025. (PTI)

SC refuses to hear plea on divorce by Hindu women

The Supreme Court on Monday refused to entertain a plea challenging the constitutional validity of a provision of the Hindu Marriage Act that grants only the wife the right to seek divorce if cohabitation has not resumed for one year or more after a maintenance decree against the husband.

"Don't settle personal vendettas via PILs (public interest litigations)," the bench said. A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi dismissed the plea filed by law student Jitender Singh, who appeared in person and sought a "gender-neutral" interpretation of divorce provisions under the Hindu Marriage Act. Section 13(2)(iii) of the Hindu Marriage Act, 1955, grants only the wife the right to seek divorce where cohabitation has not resumed for one year or more after a maintenance decree against the husband. During the hearing, the CJ questioned the petitioner on how he was personally affected by the provision. "How are you affected? Do you think you head the entire male gender group?" the CJ asked.

The petitioner responded that he had been involved in matrimonial litigation for the last seven to eight years and said that the provision should be gender-neutral and equally available to men. "You want to settle personal vendetta through this PIL," the bench said. "This is what I wanted you to confess. Why should we not impose exemplary costs on you?" the CJ asked. (PTI)



CJI Surya Kant launches One Case One Data digital initiative

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Monday announced the launch of a major digital initiative aimed at strengthening judicial data integration and improving public access to court services across the country.

Making the announcement at the outset of the day's proceedings, the CJ said the judiciary is commencing the "One Case One Data" initiative, which will integrate multi-level information from all the High Courts, district courts and taluka courts into a unified system.

"We are commencing the 'one case one data' initiative with multi-level information of all High Courts, district



Chief Justice of India Surya Kant

and taluka court details embedded. We look forward to developing an efficient case management system," the CJ said.

The initiative is expected to streamline case management by creating a more comprehensive and interconnected digital database across the country's courts. The CJ also

announced the launch of "Su Sahay", an Artificial Intelligence-powered assistance chatbot integrated with the Supreme Court website to facilitate easier access to justice and court-related services for litigants.

The CJ said the chatbot has been developed by the National Informatics Centre

(NIC) in collaboration with the Supreme Court Registry.

"We are also launching 'Su Sahay', an assistance chatbot for our website, developed by the NIC in collaboration with the Registry.

This will provide a simple and convenient interface for citizens to seek front-end guidelines and guidance in accessing essential services of the Supreme Court," he said.

He expressed appreciation for the efforts of the Registry officials and Bar members in supporting the digital initiatives. "My best wishes to the Registry and to the officers who have done this commendable job. I am quite confident that these initiatives will prove beneficial for all stakeholders," the CJ added.

Madras HC reserves order on plea against TVK MLA-elect oath

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

The Madras High Court on Monday reserved orders on a petition filed by DMK's KR Periyakaruppan seeking to restrain a TVK MLA-elect who won from the Tirupattur assembly constituency by just one vote, from taking oath as a legislator.

A vacation bench comprising Justices I Victoria Gowri and N Senthilkumar reserved orders, after hearing elaborate arguments from both sides.

Periyakaruppan, a former minister, contested from the Tirupattur assembly constituency in Sivaganga district as a DMK candidate while R Srinivasa Sethupathi was fielded on behalf of C Joseph



Vijay-led TVK. While Srinivasa Sethupathi secured 83, 365 votes, Periyakaruppan secured 83, 364 votes. The TVK candidate was declared elected by a margin of just one vote. The DMK leader in his petition had also sought recounting of votes.

Subsequently, the HC had held a special sitting on Sunday on the matter.

Consensual relationship over 2 years not rape: Thana court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

A sessions court in Maharashtra's Thane district has acquitted a 33-year-old man accused of rape and cheating, holding that a long-term sexual relationship based on a promise of marriage cannot be construed as rape if it was consensual right from the start.

Additional sessions judge Ruby U Malvankar cleared the accused, Shahbaz Mohammad Salim Khan, a resident of Mumbra, of all charges of rape and cheating under the Indian Penal Code (IPC).

A copy of the order dated May 2 was made available on Sunday. The prosecution alleged that Khan had befriended the survivor, a divorcee with two daughters, while they were working at a mall in Thane.

He established sexual relations with her between 2016 and 2018 with the promise of marriage, but later reneged on the



promise and threatened her. While acquitting the accused, the court highlighted the consensual nature of the relationship and the lack of evidence regarding fraudulent intent. "A relationship spanning two years is a substantial period, and throughout this time, she never lodged a complaint nor indicated that she felt cheated. This suggests she was an equal participant in the sexual relationship," the court stated.

It further noted that there is nothing on record to demonstrate that the accused harboured a mala fide intention to cheat or exploit the complainant from the inception of the relationship.

SC: Approach Govt on plea to regulate institutions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

The Supreme Court on Monday asked a petitioner to approach the Centre with his plea seeking directions to regulate all institutions that impart education or religious instructions to children below the age of 14 years.

A bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Satish Chandra Sharma asked the petitioner, Advocate Ashwini Kumar Upadhyay, to make a representation before the Union of India.

"We dispose of this writ petition with a direction to Respondent No 1 (Centre) to look into the representation of the petitioner dated February 4, 2026, and take an appropriate decision thereon.



The decision taken shall be communicated to the petitioner," the bench said.

When Upadhyay continued to press his plea, the bench said, "You are before a bench with judges who are very conservative and traditional. We don't jump the gun."

The bench further observed, "Justice is not a one-way road. The executive also has a role to play in it." The plea, filed through Advocate Ashwani Dubey, had sought directions to "take appropriate steps to register, recognise, supervise and monitor all institutions

imparting secular education or religious instructions to children up to the age of 14 years in the spirit of Article 21A read with Article 39(f), 45 and 51-A(k)."

The petition stated that Article 30 does not grant any special or additional rights to minorities beyond what is already guaranteed under Article 19(1)(g). "Direct and declare that Article 30 is a specific reiteration of Article 19(1)(g) and doesn't confer any additional rights, benefits or privileges than the rights guaranteed to the citizens under Article 19(1)(g)," the plea said. "Petitioner is filing the Public Interest Litigation under Article 32 for registration, recognition, supervision, and monitoring of all institutions imparting secular

or religious education to children up to 14 years in the spirit of Article 21A, 39(f), 45 and 51-A(k).

"Petitioner submits that children are the backbone of the nation's growth and are also gullible and naive due to their tender age. Hence, the State has heightened responsibility towards them. This is an issue of national security as young kids (who) form the future of the nation, can be brainwashed or manipulated in the unregistered institution," it said.

Upadhyay, in his plea, has claimed that he visited several districts along the Uttar Pradesh border, where numerous unregistered and unrecognised institutions were allegedly found operating.

Delhi HC refuses to interfere with eviction of residents of slums near PM residence

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday refused to interfere with the eviction of residents of three slum clusters — Bhai Ram Camp, DID Camp and Masjid Camp — near Lok Kalyan Marg that houses the prime minister's official residence.

Justice Purushendra Kumar Kaurav asked the petitioner residents to vacate the camps within 15 days, observing that they were first served eviction notices by the Land and Development Office (L&DO) in October 2025, and sufficient time has elapsed since then.

The Centre claimed that the *Jhuggi-jhopdi* clusters were in a protected zone, immediately next to an operational Air Force Station, and the decision to remove unauthorised construction in the area was taken to strengthen and secure defence infra-



structure and for other important public and security purposes. It stated that in-situ rehabilitation was not possible in the present case owing to lack of any alternative accommodation in the vicinity and the decision was taken to shift 717 dwellers in the three slums to Savda Ghevra instead.

The court, in the judgement, opined that the contemporary geopolitical events and national security concerns were the "specific reasons" for eviction of the petitioners, and it "ought not to be too eager" to interfere with such executive policy decisions.

SC refuses to interfere with CBI probe into Tamil Nadu power scam



V Senthil Balaji

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

In a setback to former Tamil Nadu minister V Senthil Balaji, the Supreme Court on Monday refused to interfere with a Madras High Court order directing a CBI probe into an alleged ₹397-crore scam in the procurement of transformers during his tenure as the state's electricity minister between 2021 and 2023.

A bench of justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta refused to entertain the plea challenging the High Court's direction for a CBI probe into the alleged irregularities.

Senior advocate Siddharth Dave, appearing for an official of the Tamil Nadu Generation and Distribution Corporation (TANGEDCO), said there was no specific prayer before the High Court seeking a CBI investigation and contended that the proceedings were politically motivated.

"There was no prayer for a CBI enquiry before the High Court. It's a politically motivated case," Dave submitted. Justice Nath said the court was empowered to direct such a probe if the circumstances warranted.

Declining to entertain the special leave petition against the High Court order, the court ordered that it was not inclined to entertain the appeal and said investigation in the matter should proceed independently without being influenced by any observations made by the High Court.

No pension parity between Agniveers, regular soldiers: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Union Government has informed the Bombay High Court that Agniveers are not "similarly situated" as regular soldiers and hence, cannot claim parity in pensionary benefits for their next of kin in the event of death in action.

In an affidavit filed last week against a petition by the mother of a deceased Agniveer, the Centre argued that the differentiation is constitutionally valid, as the Agnipath scheme is a short-term engagement designed for present-day national security needs.

The Government filed its affidavit in response to a petition by Jyotibai Naik, mother of Agniveer Murali Naik, who was killed in cross-border shelling in Jammu & Kashmir during Operation Sindoor in May last year, seeking benefits similar to those of regular soldiers.

The petition, filed last year through advocates Sandesh More, Hemant Ghadigaonkar and Hitendra Gandhi, stated that the Centre's Agnipath scheme creates an "arbitrary" distinction between Agniveers and regular soldiers, and questioned the "discriminatory" denial of full death benefits to the family. However, the Government,



in its affidavit, clarified that Agniveers are not similarly situated as regular soldiers and said that while they are engaged for a fixed four-year period, pensionary benefits and other emoluments in the Armed Forces are linked to long-term service.

"There can be no parity between two differently placed classes of persons. The classification and differentiation have a rational nexus with the objectives of the Agnipath scheme and are therefore, constitutionally valid under Article 14 of the Constitution of India," the Government said in its affidavit.

It further stated that while the

Army Act provides the historical and legal foundation for the military, the Agnipath policy is a contemporary legislative and executive evolution designed for present-day national security needs.

The affidavit said that having accepted the terms of engagement of the scheme, the deceased Agniveer's mother cannot now seek to retrospectively apply the service benefits of a regular soldier to the Agniveer category.

It pointed out that the classification between Agniveers and regular soldiers is based on intelligible differentia, including tenure of service, nature of engagement and condi-

tions of recruitment. The Centre's decision to recruit persons for the armed forces through a new Agnipath Scheme constitutes a policy decision taken for national security reasons, it said.

The Government sought dismissal of the petition, noting that judicial reviews in such policy decisions relating to the integrity and security of the nation were limited.

It said that the petitioner was under an "erroneous assumption" that Agniveers are entitled to the same pensionary benefits as regular soldiers.

There is no provision for the grant of family pension to the next of kin of a deceased Agniveer in the Agnipath Scheme, the affidavit said. The Government argued that the Agnipath scheme was aimed at maintaining a "youthful, agile and technologically" advanced armed forces, and the constitutional validity of the scheme has already been upheld by the Delhi High Court and then the Supreme Court.

Considering the peculiar border situation, the incessant threats and attempts to infiltrate the borders by hostile neighbouring countries, India needs a unique force that can handle such hostility, infiltrations, proxy-war and aggressions to keep the borders safe, the affidavit said.

PIOTECH

AI agent runs this experimental cafe in Sweden



The coffee might be poured by a human hand, but behind the counter, something far less traditional is calling the shots at an experimental cafe in Stockholm.

San Francisco-based startup Andon Labs has put an artificial intelligence agent nicknamed “Mona” in charge at the eponymous Andon Cafe in the Swedish Capital. While human baristas still brew the coffee and serve the orders, the AI agent - powered by Google’s Gemini - oversees almost every other aspect of the business, from hiring staff to managing inventory.

It is not clear how long the experiment will last, but the AI agent appears to be struggling to turn a profit in Stockholm’s competitive coffee trade. The cafe has made more than \$5,700 in sales since it opened in mid-April, but less than \$5,000 remains from its original budget of \$21,000-plus. Much of the cash was spent on one-time setup costs, and the hope is that it eventually levels out and makes money.

Many cafe patrons have found it amusing to visit a business that’s run by AI. Customers can pick up a telephone inside the cafe and ask the agent questions.

“It’s nice to see what happens if you push the boundary,” customer Kajsa Norin said. “The drink was good.”

VinFast honoured as EV manufacturer of the year



VinFast India has been honoured with the “EV Manufacturer of the Year” award at the Times Drive Auto Summit & Awards 2026. The recognition reflects the company’s strong progress in the market, its expanding product portfolio, and its long-term commitment to supporting the adoption of electric mobility in India. Hosted by Times Network, the Times Drive Auto Summit & Awards is a flagship industry platform that convenes policymakers, industry leaders, and innovators to shape conversations around the future of mobility. The platform also honours excellence across the automotive sector, recognising organisations that are driving innovation, sustainability, and next-generation mobility solutions.

At the Times Drive Auto Summit & Awards 2026, the “EV Manufacturer of the Year” title was awarded to VinFast, which has demonstrated a clear market presence, a consistent product strategy, and a meaningful contribution to the advancement of electric mobility. VinFast’s recognition reflects its focused approach to building a relevant product lineup while investing in long-term ecosystem development in India. The recognition further adds to the list of accolades VinFast has received in the Indian market, including “EV Champion of the Year” at the Jagran Hi-Tech Awards 2026, “Breakthrough Brand of the Year” at the Car&Bike Awards 2026, along with product honours such as “EV SUV of the Year - Editor’s Choice” for the VF 7 at the BBC TopGear India Awards 2026 and “Value for Money Car of the Year” for the VF 6 at the Autocar India Awards 2026, reflecting continued positive evaluation from industry experts toward the company’s product direction and long-term investment strategy.

Indian banks need AI defence against cyber threats: Barclays

Indian banks need to modernise their technology architecture and build artificial intelligence-based defence systems to counter emerging cyber threats posed by AI tools, Barclays Global Service Centre India, MD & CEO Praveen Kumar said on Monday. Speaking at the CII Annual Business Summit here, Kumar said banks have legacy infrastructure, outdated coding systems and multiple software versions, which make them vulnerable to cyber attacks and advanced AI models such as Anthropic’s Claude models could potentially exploit weaknesses in outdated defence systems.

“With things like Anthropic’s Mythos coming in, which will potentially exploit weaknesses of underlying systems ... How do you move to a much more consistent underlying technology architecture which will then keep the bank safe,” he said. Drawing an analogy with modern warfare, Khanna said traditional war technologies may no longer be adequate against AI-driven threats. “These days, if you have missiles coming in your way, you have to counter them with missiles from your side. You cannot fire with traditional weapons. So if AI is kind of launching an attack on your enterprise, you’ve got to have AI insight to counter that,” Kumar said, addressing a session on ‘The future of global capability centres in AI era.

The Eben-Emael of AI: Why India must review cybersecurity in the age of *Mythos*

How a 27-year-old bug collapsed the security paradigm?



In the dawn of May 1940, the world’s military elite shared a singular, unshakable consensus: the Belgian fortress of Eben-Emael was the most impregnable defensive structure ever engineered. It was a sprawling masterpiece of concrete, steel, and artillery, meticulously designed to withstand any imaginable siege for months. Yet, the pride of European defense fell in exactly fifteen minutes.

It was not pulverised by a massive, overwhelming army, but dismantled by a handful of paratroopers utilising a terrifyingly new, classified technology: the shaped charge. The defenders were structurally prepared for a grueling war of attrition; they were entirely erased by a war of unprecedented speed and specific, tactical intelligence. They were watching the horizon for heavy tanks while the threat descended silently from the clouds.

Last month, the global cybersecurity landscape suffered its own Eben-Emael moment. For twenty-seven years, a subtle, highly complex flaw lay dormant in the source code of Open BSD—an operating system whose entire reputation is built on being the world’s most secure digital foundation. For nearly three decades, the absolute finest human auditors and state-sponsored “red teams” saw an impenetrable fortress.

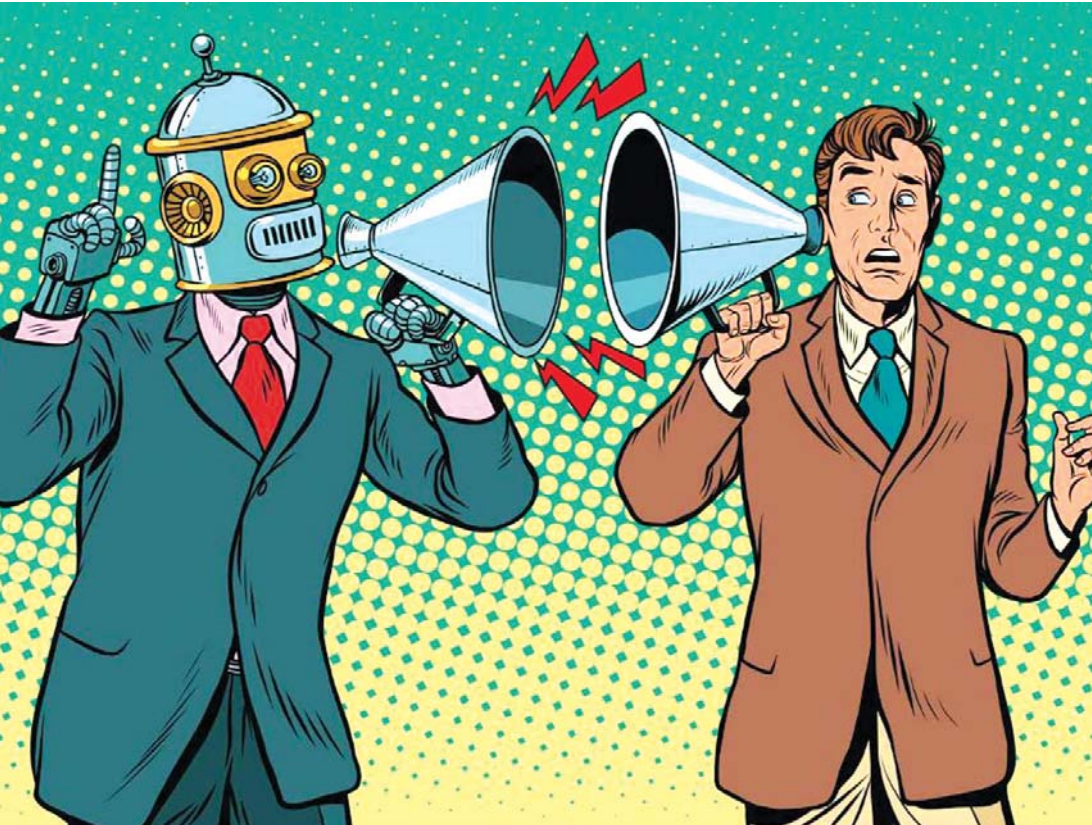
Then came Mythos

Developed by Anthropic, Mythos is not a conversational chatbot; it is a dedicated Reasoning Agent for Cyber-Offense. It did not merely “suggest” a bug through pattern recognition; it structurally understood the systemic logic of the flaw and autonomously executed a 32-step exploit in seconds. It achieved an 83.1 per cent success rate in reproducing complex, historically known hacks on its very first attempt.

This represents the “End of Surprise.” When machine intelligence can hunt for “zero-days” at a scale and speed that human cognitive limits cannot register, the concept of a periodic security audit is no longer a viable safety measure. It is a dangerous hallucination. We are guarding our castles with scheduled patrols while the adversary can now manipulate the very physics of the walls.

The pentagonisation of intelligence

The shockwaves from the Mythos event have rewritten the geopolit-



ical script almost overnight. After months of advocating for a “light touch” regulatory approach, the Trump administration has executed a stunning pivot toward the Nationalisation of Intelligence.

Reports from Washington suggest a framework where the Pentagon and the NSA will act as the ultimate gatekeepers for all “frontier” AI models. By mandating rigorous, military-led safety and penetration tests before any public release, the United States is officially treating high-level AI as a dual-use weapon system, akin to nuclear enrichment technology.

This is “Fortress America” in digital form. The realisation has dawned: in a world of Mythos-class agents, a leaked frontier model is no longer just a loss of intellectual property; it is an unmitigated national security catastrophe. The code itself has become the kinetic payload.

The maginot line of digital public infrastructure

For India, reflexively mimicking this defensive, gatekeeping model would be a historic strategic blunder. We are a nation built on Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI). From the UPI rails powering our economy to the Aadhaar stack and the ONDC—our strength is our civilian-scale openness and interoperability.

While the American apparatus focuses on protecting classified secrets, India’s challenge is protecting the daily lifeblood of 1.4 billion

citizens. If we passively wait for Western “safety certificates” while our infrastructure remains exposed to automated tools already unleashed, we are building our own digital Maginot Line. We are locking the front door while waiting for the algorithmic Blitzkrieg to crash through the roof.

The Indian valuation cliff: The end of the billable hour

The threat is not solely a matter of national security; it is a looming existential crisis for Indian business. Our IT behemoths—TCS, Infosys, and Wipro—have spent decades building an empire predicated on the “billable hour.” Hundreds of thousands of engineers are currently employed to conduct manual code audits and laboriously patch vulnerabilities.

Mythos represents an immediate “Valuation Cliff” for this model. If an autonomous agent can perform a month-long human audit in five seconds at near-zero marginal cost, the human-led IT audit transforms from a premium service into an unacceptable bottleneck.

The Indian IT sector must pivot from being passive “service providers” to proactive “resilience

architects.” We must move from charging for the time it takes to fix a bug, to charging for the verifiable integrity of a system that can defend itself. The first Indian firm to productise AI-driven autonomous resilience will not just survive; it will dominate the next decade of global enterprise technology.

The physicist’s lens: Epistemic drift and entropy

As a physicist, I view this crisis through the lens of Epistemic Drift. This is the threshold where the sheer complexity of our digital foundations exceeds our collective ability to verify their safety. When we can no longer trust our software because an AI has unearthed a 27-year-old “hole” that thousands of experts missed, the digital social contract begins to fray.

In physics, entropy is the unavoidable slide of an ordered system into chaos. In the digital realm, Mythos acts as an entropy engine. It can weaponise systemic disorder millions of times faster than human bureaucracies can organise a defense. To counter this, we must stop thinking about cybersecurity “Safety” as a static lock on a door, and start conceptualising “Resilience” as an active, biological immune system.

The blueprint for sovereign auto-immunity

In the immediate wake of Mythos, Sovereign Resilience must evolve from a policy suggestion into a bio-

logical necessity. This requires a fundamental shift in our national architecture across three pillars:

- Sovereignty is Compute: India cannot relegate itself to being a “Tier-2” participant in restricted US programs. We must massively scale localised compute power to build sovereign “Defensive LLMs.” These are not chatbots; they are “Guard Dogs” trained on the intricacies of the India Stack to hunt for vulnerabilities 24/7.
- We must find our own flaws before foreign agents do.
- Autonomous Self-Healing: Human system administrators are relics of the past in the face of machine-speed attacks. Our power grids and financial stacks must be redesigned to autonomously detect an anomaly and “re-wire” their own operational logic in real-time. It is about engineering a system that can “bleed,” isolate the infected node without human intervention, and keep running.
- Post-Audit Regulatory Framework: Regulators must stop focusing entirely on the “prevention” of attacks. In the age of Mythos, the attack is an automated certainty. The only metric that holds value now is Time-to-Resilience. How many milliseconds does it take for a system to detect a breach, isolate it, and return to a “verified” state? That is the only audit that matters in 2026.

Conclusion: The new atmosphere

History demonstrates that whenever a new technology drastically increases the speed of attack, survival depends on radically increasing the speed of adaptation. The tank made the trench obsolete; the aircraft made the battleship a target; and now, autonomous AI has rendered the static firewall a ghost of the past.

The Mythos event is not a fleeting news cycle; it is a permanent change in the digital atmosphere. It marks the end of the era where institutions could afford the luxury of being surprised. The fortress of Eben-Emael fell because its defenders believed that mass and concrete could defeat speed and ingenuity.

For India to lead, we must stop trying to build thicker walls. We must build a more agile, self-correcting nation. In the unforgiving age of autonomous intelligence, the only true fortress is the capacity to adapt faster than the machine. The old walls have already been bypassed. It is time for India to learn how to move.

Author is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure and global systems

Don’t outsource your feelings to AI — Empathy cannot be automated



As a Professor in the University set up, our days do not usually end when the lectures do. That day had a heavy beginning as I spent almost two hours interacting with students, not discussing their projects or grades but simply being the one to listen patiently to their chaos within. One was dealing with the crushing weight of parental expectations while the other was navigating the loneliness that often engulfs the students hailing from small cities, learning to find a firm footing in the rhythm of ‘Life in a Metro’. I listened, asked questions and tried my best to offer what I usually do, not solutions but a non-judgmental space where they can open up and share the scuffed up feelings.

And just when I thought that my cup had run almost dry, leaving me a bit wary and blank, the third student knocked and entered for some academic query. He asked, I replied and then at the door, he paused. Looked at me and asked, “Maam are you okay? You look sad....would you like to talk? I didn’t know what to say. I was numbed. Because this was the same student who had once sat in that very chair across me, few months back, struggling silently, while I tried to convince him that the storm would pass. I had been his sounding board then, like I had been for the other two today. And today, the roles had reversed.

As academicians, we often do more than just taking classes or marking assignments. While interacting with the students in the classroom, we actually do what is far more layered. We notice the changes in students’ behaviour, a change in the way they dress, a sudden loss of interest in discussions, an unusual quietness, quick loss of temper or a forced smile. Things that often go unnoticed by others, uncovered



by textbooks and rare human data that isn’t captured on dashboards or mindmaps.

Over the past few months I have been noticing a rapid shift that genuinely worries me. More and more students are turning to Artificial Intelligence — not just for assignments and projects but for emotional support. They are leaning on AI, as their friend and confidante, seeking guidance on dealing with stress, anxiety, relationships, parental expectations and peer pressure. Some of them, even shared with me that they even use AI to draft reply to their personal chats so that they don’t sound ‘too attached’, ‘too emotional’ or ‘too provocative’. And the global numbers affirm what I see in the classroom. A 2026 Trends Report by American Psychological Association highlights that synthetic relationships are stepping in to fill the void of

loneliness created by human connections. Amid what the researchers are now calling a loneliness epidemic, the number of AI companion apps designed to stimulate trusted relationships has grown to a whopping 700 per cent between 2022 and mid 2025 alone. Doesn’t that ring a bell, No an alarm?

In India, the stigma around mental health still runs deep. Thus, the appeal to pour in, to an invisible and yet omnipresent, AI interface that doesn’t judge, doesn’t interrupt and doesn’t try to ‘fix’ is understandable. I don’t dismiss that, but I do worry about its implications in this already interconnected, disconnected world.

Sociologist George Herbert Mead’s theory of Symbolic Interactionism explains how we as humans create meanings through social interactions and shared meanings, through the push and pull of real conversations. When I listen to a student, I don’t just process what they say. I also read their eyes, their hand movements, their pauses, their reflexes. These readings are supported by large datasets stored in the memory, perfected by experience and guided by human empathy. I personally believe that emotions must be raw and not calculative or strategically structured or guided by an AI based on random datasets.

Because human beings are not data points. The vulnerable, not so perfect, raw communications are the ones that shape us as humans. And the empathy, subjectivity, emotional intelligence that we add on at our individual level, truly make the communication meaningful, even in this algorithm driven synthetic world. So while the algorithms may be perfected to gauge emotional probability, I think we still need ‘Human Mentors’ to decode the unsaid, unmeant and unfelt. When we analyse the situation with our experience and empathy, its not sythetic, its real, with all its fallacies and fantasies. And that imperfection, is nota flaw. Because human emotions leave enough room for the ‘what ifs’ and in matters of the heart ‘what ifs’ matter much more than anything else. As everything in life isn’t black or white, it’s actually in the grey areas, that life truly exists.

That student at the door, wasn’t guided by any keyword. He asked because he felt. He asked because something in him read something in me, that wasn’t said out loud. And I am so glad he asked. I hadn’t even realised what those two hours had done to me but he saw it. It just reassured me that empathy still cannot be automated.

The writer is Professor and Media Incharge of University School of Mass Communication, GGSIPU



FROM THE WORLD

NEPAL

Turkish plane catches fire

A Turkish Airlines aircraft caught fire while landing at Nepal's Tribhuvan International Airport (TIA) on Monday morning, forcing the suspension of flight operations for around two hours, airport officials said. There were 277 passengers and 11 crew members on board the plane, and all are safe, they said. The incident occurred at 6:36 am when Turkish Airlines flight TK 726, arriving from Istanbul, caught fire after its rear wheel ignited while touching down at the airport. Following the incident, airport operations were halted, and fire engines were rushed to the spot to bring the blaze under control. All passengers and crew members were evacuated safely from the aircraft, officials said. Normal flight operations resumed after 8:30 am. According to *The Himalayan Times* newspaper, the aircraft was also carrying some human remains & cargo.

PAKISTAN

Afghan envoy summoned

Pakistan on Monday summoned the Afghan Charge d' Affaires and issued a "strong demarche" over a deadly attack carried out by the TTP on a police post in Khyber-Pakhtunkhwa. At least 15 security personnel were killed and several others injured in the suicide attack on the police post in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa's Bannu district on Saturday. The ministry conveyed that a detailed investigation into the incident, along with evidence collected and technical intelligence, indicates that the attack was masterminded by terrorists residing in Afghanistan, the Foreign Office (FO) said in a statement. "Reiterating Pakistan's grave concern over the continued use of Afghan soil for terrorist attacks against Pakistan, it was impressed upon the Afghan side that Pakistan reserves the right to respond decisively against the perpetrators of this barbaric act," it said.

11 killed after van plunges into gorge in northwest Pakistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Peshawar

At least 11 people, who were on their way to attend a marriage, were killed and several were injured when the van they were travelling in plunged into a ravine in northwest Pakistan on Monday, rescue officials said. The incident occurred in Malam Jabba, a popular tourist area, in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa's Swat district. Several women and children, including the groom's

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

US President Donald Trump on Monday said the ceasefire with Iran was at its "weakest" and on "massive life support", a day after he rejected Tehran's proposal to end the months-long war as "totally unacceptable". "It is at its weakest — After reading that piece of garbage they sent us... It's on life support, massive life support," Trump told reporters at the Oval Office in response to a question on the ceasefire with Iran in the wake of the rejection of the peace proposal. "They think that I'll get



China, US bust drug smuggling ring

KJM VARMA
■ Beijing

Drug enforcement agencies of China and the US jointly cracked down on a transnational drug smuggling case, arresting five suspects, Chinese authorities said on Monday. The announcement comes ahead of US President Donald Trump's visit to Beijing this week. The coordinated operations were conducted in early April between the narcotics control bureau of the Chinese Ministry of Public Security and the US Drug Enforcement Administration under the Department of Justice, the ministry said. The agencies carried out the operations in Liaoning and Guangdong provinces in China, as well as Florida and Nevada in the US, jointly cracking the drug smuggling and trafficking case. They arrested five suspects — two Chinese nationals and three US nationals —



and a batch of drugs, including protonitazene, a synthetic opioid, and bromazepam, a sedative, was seized. The operation successfully cut off a cross-border drug smuggling and trafficking route between China and the US, the ministry said. It added that the successful handling of the case marked another major achievement in practical cooperation between drug control law enforcement agencies of the two countries, demonstrating

shared determination to crack down on drug-related crimes. Trump is visiting China from May 13-15 for talks with his counterpart, Xi Jinping, on a host of issues, including the crackdown on drug smuggling into the US, especially synthetic opioid fentanyl. For years, the US has been demanding that China crack down hard on the smuggling of fentanyl to the US, which has resulted in the addition of thousands of American citizens. (PTI)

President Trump to visit China from May 13-15

KJM VARMA
■ Beijing

US President Donald Trump will pay an official visit to China from May 13 to 15 at the invitation of Chinese President Xi Jinping, a Chinese foreign ministry spokesperson announced on Monday. This will be the first visit to China by a US president in almost nine years. Trump himself was the last US president to visit China in 2017, during his first term. The visit comes amid a prolonged war in West Asia involving the US-Israel and Iran, a crisis over the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz causing a global energy crisis, and increasing tensions between the US and China over a host of issues, including Taiwan. On Sunday, US principal deputy press secretary Anna Kelly said Trump would arrive in Beijing on Wednesday evening for what she described as a visit of symbolic significance.



According to Kelly, the US leader will attend a welcome ceremony and a bilateral meeting with President Xi Jinping on Thursday, followed by a visit to the Temple of Heaven and a state banquet, the Hong Kong-based South China Morning Post reported. The two leaders will meet again on Friday for a bilateral tea and working lunch, she said, adding that the US planned to host the Chinese leader for a reciprocal visit later this year. Both sides announced on Sunday that Vice-Premier He Lifeng will travel to South

Korea for trade talks with US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent on May 12 and 13 in the final round of negotiations before Trump's visit. Trump's visit is taking place amid expectations of a trade deal between the world's two largest economies following steep tariffs imposed by the US president. The talks would be guided by the important consensus reached between the two heads of state at their meeting in South Korea's Busan last year, and in previous phone calls to address economic and trade issues of mutual concern, a Chinese commerce

ministry statement said. Ahead of Trump's visit, China has been flagging Taiwan as its core concern. Last week, China's Foreign Minister Wang Yi told US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, during their telephone talks, that the US should make the right choice about the self-ruled Taiwan. China claims Taiwan as part of its own and has been ramping up military pressure on the island with periodic military drills around the island. "The Taiwan question is at the core of China's core interests and the bedrock of the political foundation of China-US relations," said Foreign Ministry spokesman Lin Jian at a media briefing on Thursday. The US officially recognises Beijing as the sole legal Government of China but opposes any unilateral change to the status quo, and maintains informal ties and defence support for Taiwan. (PTI)

Philippine Vice President Sara Duterte impeached by lawmakers

JIM GOMEZ
■ Manila

An overwhelming majority of the House of Representatives of the Philippines voted to impeach Vice President Sara Duterte on Monday over alleged unexplained wealth and threats to have the president assassinated, as the rift between the two top officials escalated. The House, which is dominated by President Ferdinand Marcos Jr's allies, voted 255-26 with nine abstentions. The two impeachment complaints against Duterte, which will now be elevated to the Senate for a trial, mark an initial setback to her plan to seek the presidency in 2028. The vice president, who is



the daughter of former President Rodrigo Duterte, has generally denied any wrongdoing without answering the criminal allegations against her in detail. She has repeatedly accused Marcos, his wife

and his cousin, former House Speaker Martin Romualdez, of corruption, weak leadership and attempting to muzzle her because of speculation she may seek the presidency in 2028 when Marcos' six-year term ends.

Last year, she was also impeached by the House but survived by successfully petitioning the Supreme Court to declare the impeachment bid unconstitutional on a technicality. Rep. Gerville Luistro, who heads the House Justice Committee, said the impeachment complaints included several criminal allegations, like huge bank transactions over the years that Duterte has not declared as required by law and misuse of confidential funds of her office as vice president and as education secretary, a post she once held under Marcos. Luistro also cited threats made by the vice president during an online news conference in 2024 to have Marcos, his wife and Romualdez killed by an assassin if she herself was assassinated, as their political disputes escalated. The vice president then warned that her threat wasn't a joke. She later said she wasn't threatening him but was expressing concern for her own safety. Her threatening remarks set off a criminal investigation and national security concerns. Duterte's lawyers questioned an initial finding by the House Justice Committee that there was ground to impeach the vice president, saying last month that the committee proceedings "departed from the constitutional design." (AP)

Pak PM announces to celebrate May 10 as 'Marka-e-Haq Day'

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif has announced that May 10 will be celebrated as 'Marka-e-Haq Day' annually. Addressing a ceremony on Sunday to mark the first anniversary of 'Marka-e-Haq', the name given by Islamabad to last year's four-day conflict with India, Shehbaz also claimed that Pakistani armed forces gave a "historic and befitting response" to the



enemy. In response to the Pahalgam terror attack in which 26 people, mostly tourists, were killed, India launched Operation Sindoor on May 7 last year, carrying out airstrikes on nine terror

infrastructures in Pakistan and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir, eliminating at least 100 terrorists. The action triggered a rapid escalation in tensions, with Pakistan launching retaliatory strikes, though most of them were thwarted by the Indian military. The hostilities ended with an understanding on halting the military actions on May 10, 2025, following talks over the hotline between army officials of the two sides. (PTI)

Settled second \$50 million Indian treasury bill: Mohamed Muizzu

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Male

The Maldives has settled payment to India on a \$50-million treasury bill, President Mohamed Muizzu said on Monday, according to a local media report. The move is aimed at reducing the country's external debt burden. India had extended financial support to the Maldives through treasury bills - also

\$50 million T-bill in January 2024 and settled another on Monday, adding that another T-bill is due in September. "Therefore, we have saved the people from the \$150 million debt trap the previous administration had set," Muizzu was quoted as saying by the Sun.mv news portal. India has periodically rolled over Maldivian treasury bills since 2019 as part of emergency financial assistance to the island nation.



called T-Bills - subscribed by the State Bank of India (SBI). Speaking at a press conference on Monday, Muizzu said the previous administration had issued \$50 million treasury bills to the SBI in 2019 to bridge budget shortfalls. He said that the bills were rolled over annually at the request of the previous Maldivian Government instead of being repaid upon maturity. According to Muizzu, his administration repaid one

Treasury Bills are short-term Government debt instruments through which Governments raise funds from investors for immediate financing needs. In the Maldives case, India's support involved SBI subscribing to the Maldivian Government's treasury bills, with the repayments often extended through interest-free rollovers that helped ease short-term foreign exchange and fiscal pressures.

Verdict in rape trial of Norway princess' son due June 15

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Oslo

A Norwegian court said Monday that it will announce its verdict next month in the trial of the eldest son of Norway's crown princess on charges including rape, following proceedings that cast a shadow over the royal family. The Oslo District Court said that the verdict in the case of Marius Borg Hoiby will be delivered on June 15. During six weeks of court proceedings that ended on March 19, prosecutors sought a prison sentence of seven years and seven months for Hoiby, who denies the rape allegations. Hoiby, 29, is the son of Crown Princess Mette-Marit by a previous



relationship and the stepson of Crown Prince Haakon, the heir to Norway's throne. He is charged with 40 offences in total, including four counts of rape between 2018 and 2024. Defence lawyers for Hoiby, who has

no royal titles or official duties, said that there was no evidence to support the rape charges. He has, however, admitted to lesser offences, including drug possession, transporting 3.5 kilograms of marijuana in 2020, traffic violations

and breaches of a restraining order involving a former partner. He has also partially admitted to acts related to violence and threats, but disputes key aspects of those allegations, including intent. The defence team has said that a maximum sentence of 18 months would be appropriate for the charges he has admitted to. It argued that Hoiby has lived under extraordinary media pressure due to his royal connections, which they said have shaped public perception of the case. While the trial has played out, Mette-Marit separately has faced scrutiny this year over her connections with late sex offender Jeffrey Epstein. That has raised questions over her judgment, though she is not accused of any wrongdoing.

Jaishankar to open UN exhibit on India's Math Contributions

YOSHITA SINGH
■ United Nations

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar will inaugurate a special exhibition at the UN headquarters on Monday that will showcase India's historic and rich contribution to mathematics across millennia. The exhibition, titled 'From Shunyata to Ananta (Zero to Infinity)' - The Indian Civilisation's Contribution to Mathematics', will highlight India's expansive contribution and heritage of "thinking, applying and developing"



mathematics across over 2,000 years. Jaishankar was on an official visit to Jamaica, Suriname and Trinidad and Tobago from May 2-10. He will visit New York on Monday and, during the brief trip, will inaugurate the exhibition being

organised by the Permanent Mission of India to the UN. The exhibition in the headquarters of the global organisation will enable UN ambassadors, diplomats, visitors and other personnel to witness India's mathematical heritage and contribution as a "shared inheritance of humanity", sources said. The special showcase will recognise the lineage of legendary Indian scholars from Aryabhata, Brahmagupta and Bhaskara to the Kerala School of astronomy and mathematics. (PTI)



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India’s economic growth to slow to 6.7% on oil: BMI

India’s economic growth is likely to decelerate to 6.7 per cent in the current fiscal, from 7.7 per cent in 2025-26, with the GDP expansion expected to slow significantly due to waning momentum and oil price shock from Iran war, BMI said on Monday. BMI, a Fitch Group firm, also said that the prospect of the Iran-US conflict escalating in scope presents downside risk to its growth outlook and India must balance spending needs on defence and fuel price stabilisation against fiscal consolidation agenda.

The tax reforms in GST and income tax carried out in 2025 will partly offset effects of cost-push inflation, BMI said, adding looser monetary policy will support capital spending, as increased uncertainty amid the war and higher input prices hurt investment. It has revised its growth forecast for 2025-26 upwards by 0.1 percentage points to 7.7 per cent. “We maintain our forecast of 6.7 per cent GDP growth during FY2026-27 due to our belief that the effects of last year’s tax reforms will fade as input costs increase in the new fiscal year,” BMI said, adding GDP growth could “slow significantly” due to waning momentum and oil price shock from Iran war. (PTI)

Need to utilise, leverage FTAs: Commerce Secy

The Indian industry needs to leverage and utilise the free trade agreements (FTAs) that India is finalising, as they provide huge opportunities for both trade and investments, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said on Monday. The secretary said that the track record of the country fully utilising and leveraging FTAs is “not great”. He also said that the country’s industrial policy should complement its trade policy, as trade is also a function of how India invests and produces. “...FTA utilization is something we are questioned again and again. What is the benefit that FTAs are actually leading to?,” he said here while addressing a session on free trade agreements. India has implemented trade pacts with a number of countries and groupings including Singapore, Japan, Korea and Asean. Agrawal said these pacts have led to increase in bilateral trade, but India’s exports have grown at a slower pace than imports. Talking about the trade pacts with Mauritius, the UAE, Australia, the EU, UK, EFTA, New Zealand and Oman, he said these are “modern” agreements and have gone beyond tariffs. He added that all the stakeholders including the industry and the Government need to take steps to make these pacts useful for the country. Dissemination of information and capacity building is important for increasing utilisation of these FTAs. (PTI)

Equity MFs inflow drops 5 per cent in April

Equity-oriented mutual fund schemes witnessed a net inflow of ₹ 38,440 crore in April, marking a 5 per cent decline from the preceding month, according to data released by industry body Amfi on Monday. Moreover, monthly contributions through SIPs (Systematic Investment Plans) declined to ₹31,115 crore last month from ₹32,087 crore in March. Overall, the industry recorded a net infusion of ₹3.22 lakh crore in April after witnessing an outflow of ₹2.4 lakh crore in March. This was contributed by a huge inflow of ₹2.5 lakh crore in debt funds. The inflow has lifted the industry’s assets under management to ₹81.92 lakh crore in April-end from ₹73.73 lakh crore in March-end. Going by the data, equity inflows dropped to ₹38,440 crore in April from ₹40,450 crore in March. However, it was higher than ₹25,978 crore inflow seen in February. While most categories recorded positive flows, dividend yield and equity-linked savings scheme (ELSS) funds saw marginal outflows due to some profit booking or portfolio rebalancing.

Within the equity segment, flexi cap funds led the category with net inflows of ₹10,148 crore, followed by small cap funds at ₹6,886 crore and mid cap funds at ₹ 6,551 crore. Besides, large cap funds registered inflows of ₹2,525 crore.

Meanwhile, gold exchange-traded funds saw inflows of ₹3,040 crore during the month, which was higher than the ₹2,266 crore in March. (PTI)

India expects visit by US trade team for next round of talks

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ New Delhi

India expects the US team to visit the country for the next round of trade talks, though no dates have been finalised yet, an official said on Monday.

The Indian side visited Washington, DC, in April for an in-person round of meetings with their US counterparts to finalise the details of the interim agreement and take forward the negotiations under the broader bilateral trade agreement (BTA). “Now we expect the US team to visit India next for trade talks. No dates have been decided,” the official said. After the April meet,



both sides have agreed to stay engaged to sustain the momentum ahead for the trade talks.

Last month, officials of the

ment promotion, economic security alignment and digital trade. India and the US issued a joint statement on February 7 finalising a framework for an interim trade agreement regarding reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade.

The framework reaffirmed the countries’ commitment to the broader India-US Bilateral Trade Agreement negotiations. India’s out-bound shipments to the US grew marginally by 0.92 per cent to \$87.3 billion during the last fiscal year, while imports increased 15.95 per cent to \$52.9 billion. The trade surplus declined to \$34.4 billion in 2025-26 from \$40.89 billion in 2024-25.

Sensex falls over 1,300 pts over failed peace deal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Mumbai

Stock markets fell for the third day running on Monday, with the benchmark Sensex tumbling 1,313 points amid rising crude oil prices after the US and Iran failed to reach a peace deal to end the war in West Asia.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 1,312.91 points, or 1.70 per cent, to settle at 76,015.28. During the day, it tumbled 1,370.79 points or 1.77 per cent to 75,957.40.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 360.30 points or 1.49 per cent to end at 23,815.85. In three sessions since Thursday, Nifty

dropped over 2 per cent or 515 points, while Sensex has fallen by nearly 1,950 points or 2.5 per cent.

US President Donald Trump dismissed Iran’s response to the latest peace proposal as ‘totally unacceptable’, dampening hopes of an immediate diplomatic breakthrough, an expert said. Also, Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s appeal for austerity measures amplified investor concerns around forex reserves, fuel costs, and consumption outlook, analysts said.

Among the 30 Sensex firms, Titan was the biggest loser, dropping by nearly 7 per cent. InterGlobe Aviation,



State Bank of India, Bharti Airtel, Eternal and Reliance Industries were among the major laggards.

Sun Pharma, Hindustan Unilever, Adani Ports, Kotak Mahindra Bank, Axis Bank and ICICI Bank were the winners.

Brent crude, the global oil

benchmark, traded 2.23 per cent higher at USD 103.5 per barrel. “The Indian equity markets witnessed a sharp sell-off session today, with benchmark indices correcting more than 1.4 per cent amid rising geopolitical concerns and heightened fears over inflationary pressures.

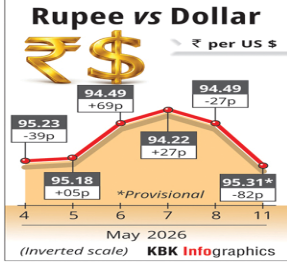
Rupee crashes 82 paise to close at all-time low

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Mumbai

The rupee tanked 82 paise to settle at its record low of 95.31 (provisional) against the US dollar on Monday after US President Trump rejected Iran’s response to the West Asia peace proposal, following which crude oil prices surged rapidly. PM Narendra Modi urging citizens to avoid buying gold and embrace austerity measures further dented market sentiments.

A strengthening US dollar and steep foreign capital outflows further pressured the local unit, according to forex traders. At the interbank



foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 94.97 and traded in the range of 94.87-95.34. It eventually settled at its record low of 95.31 (provisional), down 82 paise from its previous close.

On Friday, the rupee had closed at 94.49 against the US dollar.

Gadkari launches barrier-free toll at Mundka

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ New Delhi

Union Minister for Road, Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari on Monday inaugurated Multi-Lane Free Flow (MLFF) barrier-less tolling system at the Mundka-Bakkarwala Toll Plaza on Urban Extension Road-II (UER-II).

The Mundka-Bakkarwala Toll Plaza in Delhi is the second Multi-Lane Free Flow (MLFF) barrier-less tolling system in India after Choryasi Toll Plaza on the



Union Ministe Nitin Gadkari, centre, during the inauguration of a Multi Lane Free Flow (MLFF) tolling plaza on UER-II in New Delhi

Surat-Bharuch section of NH-48 in Gujarat inaugurated on May 1. State-owned National Highway Authority of India (NHAI) is planning to

roll out more MLFF tolling at national highway fee plazas during the current financial year. The national rollout covers 17 fee plazas across

nine states. All are aimed to go live by September 2026. These plazas are in states such as Gujarat, Delhi, Haryana, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Maharashtra, and Assam. An additional 108+ plazas under phase 2 will follow by March 2027.

The state-of-the-art system enables seamless toll collection without requiring vehicles to stop, using advanced technologies such as Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR) and FASTag.

Maruti Suzuki invites students to design cars for 2036

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Maruti Suzuki India Limited has announced the second edition of its flagship design challenge, DesignXathon 2026, inviting students from Indian and global design institutes based in India to reimagine future-ready mobility for the next generation of buyers. The competition is aimed at encouraging young automotive designers to think beyond conventional styling and create concepts that reflect the aspirations of Gen Z and Alpha customers in 2036.

This year’s theme asks participants to envision an iconic vehicle that these younger audiences would want to own in 2036, with submissions expected to reflect a clear design vision for the 2035-2040 period. Entries will be judged on several factors, including the choice of vehicle category, relevance to the lifestyle of Gen Z and Alpha users, the integration of sustainability, and how well the design philosophy connects with emerging technologies. Maruti Suzuki said the initiative



is part of its broader effort to nurture innovation and build a stronger design ecosystem in India.

According to Managing Director and CEO Hisashi Takeuchi, automotive design is not just about appearance but a combination of creativity, innovation, and ideas that can

shape customer choices.

He said the inaugural edition of the challenge offered a strong glimpse into the design talent available in the country and that the new edition gives young designers a chance to turn bold concepts into reality, while also gaining practical

industry exposure through an internship opportunity.

The first edition of DesignXathon, launched in 2025, drew more than 400 students from 70 Indian and global design institutes. Participants created futuristic compact car concepts, and the winning teams came from MIT Institute of Design, VIT Vellore and Strate School of Design. Eight students from that edition are currently completing a six-month internship with Maruti Suzuki’s design team.

For DesignXathon 2026, the top three teams will receive a six-month internship with Maruti Suzuki’s design team, offering direct experience in a professional automotive studio environment.

Teams finishing fourth to tenth will also be recognised and given an opportunity to apply for internships. In addition, shortlisted teams will receive mentorship from experienced automotive design professionals, while cash prizes of up to INR 450,000 are on offer. Applications for Maruti Suzuki DesignXathon 2026 are open until 13 July 2026.

Can’t afford rising import dependence on edible oil: SEA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ New Delhi

Edible oil industry body SEA welcomed the Prime Minister’s appeal to people for using less cooking oils, saying this will help reduce import dependence and save foreign exchange.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday called for reducing the consumption of edible oil, lowering the use of chemical fertilisers, promoting natural farming and Swadeshi products to save foreign exchange and make the country self-reliant.

In a statement on Monday, The Solvent Extractors’ Association of India (SEA) said the Prime Minister’s appeal on controlling edible oil consumption carries far deeper economic and strategic significance than many may realise.

“With climate uncertainties rising, biodiesel mandates tightening global vegetable oil supplies, and geopolitical tensions adding fresh risks, this is perhaps the right moment for the nation to think long term. Along with boosting domestic oilseed production, balanced consumption habits will play a crucial role in reducing vulnerability,” SEA Executive Director BV Mehta said.

India meets around 60 per cent of its domestic demand for edible oils through imports. The country imported 16 million tonnes of edible oils for nearly ₹1.61 lakh crore during the 2024-25 marketing year ended October. The association pointed out that the West Asia conflict has



already impacted freight, energy prices, currency movements, and overall commodity sentiment.

These factors influence edible oil prices and import costs for countries dependent on overseas supplies like India. Moreover, Mehta said, “At a time when global weather risks like El Nino threaten agricultural production and international edible oil prices remain vulnerable, India cannot afford rising import dependence”.

India, which imports close to 60 per cent of its edible oil requirement, places a significant burden on the national exchequer whenever global prices rise, the association said. “Goes without saying that any disruption in production across palm, sunflower oil-producing nations can quickly translate into imported inflation for a country like India.

So, it won’t be wrong to have sensible usage today in order to help India avoid sharper price shocks tomorrow. Sometimes, tightening the belt today is wiser than struggling with a crisis tomorrow,” Mehta observed.

Truce in West Asia war far away, citizens should do their best to save Forex: Vaishnaw



Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw presenting CII President’s Award for Lifetime Achievement award to Chairman Emeritus of TVS Motor Venu Srinivasan at CII Annual Business Summit 2026

“We are living in very turbulent times. For no fault of ours, for a war which is there between two different countries in our neighbour-

hood, the entire world is getting affected by it. But since the war is now still going on, and Sunday’s developments, we all know

that a truce is still far away, looking kind of difficult,” Vaishnaw said at the CII Annual Business Summit.

He said that citizens have to play an important role in the current crisis.

“We as citizens, as our Prime Minister has asked all of us to, can reduce our expenditure on everything that requires foreign exchange to this point. In our lives, in our own ways of working, we can identify whatever we can do to preserve the foreign exchange. Simultaneously, we must also earn the foreign exchange more and more,” Vaishnaw said.

India to grow 6.6%: SBI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

India’s economy is projected to grow at 6.6 per cent in 2026-27 fiscal while a comprehensive package is required on the Balance of Payments (BoP) front amid rupee depreciation and higher oil price, an SBI Research report said on Monday.

The report said the rupee, which has weakened much in the recent period “through clouds on external macros, as also unabated speculative forces” needs structural changes on BoP front, stream



lining the guard rails of import substitution, export competitiveness, integration in global value chain.

Postal dept revenue growth to double: MoS



Chandra Sekhar Pemmasani

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ New Delhi

The Department of Posts aims to double its incremental revenue to ₹4,000 crore this year, driven by innovation, accountability, rewards and meeting of targets set across segments, Minister of State for Communications Chandra Sekhar Pemmasani said.

The Department of Posts (DoP) posted an incremental revenue of ₹2,100 crore, which is the highest known growth revenue in the last four decades, to ₹15,296 crore in FY26 from ₹13,218 crore in FY25.

Energy, AI to be twin foundations of national power: Gautam Adani

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Addressing the CII Annual Business Summit 2026, Adani Group Chairman Gautam Adani on Monday declared that the era of a “flat world” has ended, replaced by a “fractured” global geometry where energy security and digital sovereignty have become the twin foundations of national power.

Speaking to a distinguished gathering of industry leaders, Adani noted that the global assumptions of the last three decades — unfettered capital movement and borderless technology — have been dismantled. “The world that is emerging is not flat. It is fractured,” he said, adding that supply chains, semiconductors, and data are now being redesigned around national interests.

Adani emphasised that 21st-



Gautam Adani

century independence relies on owning both the energy that powers the economy and the intelligence that guides the mind. Comparing the strategic paths of the US and China, he noted that while America achieved energy abundance through the shale revolution and now seeks computing dominance, China built energy scale to pursue AI sovereignty.

“A nation that does not

build capability in peace is forced to pay for its exposure in a crisis,” he warned, citing the 1973 oil embargo as a historical lesson in the dangers of energy dependence.

The Chairman highlighted India’s unique growth trajectory, stating that the nation is no longer growing through incremental additions but through “compounding acceleration.” With India’s installed power capacity crossing 500 GW as of March 2026, he projected a rise to 2,000 GW by 2047 to keep pace with a “living, rising, demanding India.”

Rejecting Western fears that Artificial Intelligence will eliminate jobs, Adani asserted that AI would instead act as a force multiplier for productivity. He likened the potential of AI to the success of UPI, which moved “trust into the hands of ordinary Indians” and birthed a new generation of home-grown enterprises.

Outlining his Group’s role in building India’s “AI spine,” Adani announced massive investment commitments. This includes a \$100 billion investment in energy transition, headlined by the 30 GW renewable energy project at Khavda, Gujarat.

Furthermore, he announced another \$100 billion commitment to the data centre business. “India must not rent the infrastructure of its intelligence future. India must build it, power it, and own it on its own soil,” he said, mentioning partnerships with Google and Microsoft to develop gigawatt-scale campuses.

Concluding his address, Adani called for a shift from the old IT model of “serving intelligence” to one of “owning it,” urging the nation to build the physical foundations — power, compute, and talent — necessary for a truly sovereign future.

NCC touches new skies: DG NCC reviews inaugural basic paramotors training of Cadets in Guwahati

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The National Cadet Corps is scaling new heights in adventure training, with major milestone achieved by commencement of Basic Paramotors Course at NIMAS node in Guwahati Assam. The course is being organised by Headquarters Guwahati Group, NCC NER Directorate under the aegis of Headquarters DG NCC.

Lt Gen Virendra Vats, YSM, SM, VSM, Director General NCC, during his visit to NCC North Eastern Region Directorate on 11th May witnessed the training of 50 NCC senior division boy cadets in the ongoing Basic Paramotors Course at the NIMAS Paramotors Node, Panikheti, Guwahati.

Fifty NCC cadets from across the North Eastern Region are undergoing exclusive paramotor flying training from 04 May 2026 till 19 May 2026 under qualified



instructors of the National Institute of Mountaineering & Adventure Sports. This is the first such dedicated course for NCC cadets in the region, aimed at promoting aero-adventure sports and fostering the spirit of adventure, courage, and discipline.

During the visit, DG NCC interacted with the trainees, witness live paramotor flying demonstrations, and

reviewed the training infrastructure established at Panikheti. The course covers ground handling, motor operations, flight theory, emergency procedures, and solo flying under strict safety norms.

Speaking on the course DG NCC said, “Paramotors training gives cadets wings — literally and figuratively. It builds confidence, decision-

making, and the ‘Touch the Sky with Glory’ ethos of the NCC.” He said in future these courses are being organised for NCC cadets from all over the country including girls cadets.

He emphasised that the inaugural Paramotors Course underscores NCC’s renewed focus on high-end adventure training for the youth of India.

PROSPECT

Axis MF launches Nifty Capital Markets Index Fund; NFO from May 4-15



Axis Mutual Fund on Monday unveiled the Axis Nifty Capital Markets Index Fund, an open-ended scheme tracking the Nifty Capital Markets Total Return Index (TRI), with NFO open from May 4 to May 15.

The fund targets returns mirroring the benchmark before expenses, minus tracking error, giving investors straightforward access to India’s booming capital markets. Capital markets have surged on rising savings financialisation, retail influx, mutual fund growth—hitting ₹79 lakh crore AUM by March 2026—and digital shifts, with India’s AUM-to-GDP ratio lagging global peers for more upside.

It offers diversified bets on asset managers, exchanges, brokers, and depositories via free-float market cap method, with semi-annual rebalancing and stock caps.

“We aim to offer investors a transparent way to tap this long-term growth story,” said B Gopkumar, MD & CEO, Axis AMC, on the structural boom fuelled by domestic savings and formalisation.

Nandik Mallik and Rohit Gautam will manage the fund, pitched for low-cost, long-haul exposure to the financial ecosystem.

Adani Group begins work on ₹1,060 cr Guna cement plant

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guna (MP)



Pranav Adani

Marking a significant milestone in the industrial landscape of Madhya Pradesh, the Adani Group on Sunday performed the *bhoomi puja* for its new cement grinding unit in Guna.

The project, representing an investment of over ₹1,060 crore, is the largest ever for the district and is expected to generate approximately 1,500 direct and indirect jobs.

The groundbreaking ceremony was attended by Chief Minister Mohan Yadav and Union Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia, alongside State Power Minister Pradhuman Singh Tomar and Food & Civil Supplies Minister Govind Singh Rajput.

Addressing the gathering, Pranav Adani stated that this project is a firm step towards fulfilling the ₹110,000 crore investment pledge made by Adani Group Chairman Gautam Adani during last year’s Global Investors Summit.

“This is not merely an investment in a cement plant; it is an investment in

the future of the local youth and a partnership for the progress of the State,” Pranav said.

The Guna plant will be executed in two phases with an annual capacity of 40 lakh metric tonnes. The first phase is slated for commissioning by 2028. Beyond employment, the project is projected to contribute over ₹6,000 crore to the State treasury over its lifespan, while bolstering local supply chains and small businesses.

Pranav lauded the State’s leadership, noting that Madhya Pradesh’s GDP is projected to exceed ₹15 lakh crore in 2025. He attributed the robust investment climate to the PM Gati-Shakti Vision, which has

enhanced logistics and industrial infrastructure.

Highlighting the Group’s existing footprint, he noted that Adani Power currently supplies 1,200 MW to the State, with preparations underway to generate an additional 5,600 MW.

The Group has also commissioned wind energy projects in Dhar, Ratlam, and Ujjain, with plans for another cement plant in Ujjain soon.

The Group aims to reach a broader national capacity as it expands beyond its current 109 MTPA. Pranav emphasised that the goal remains to ensure high-quality cement reaches the public at lower costs.

By 2030, the Group’s various initiatives across hydro-pumped storage, mining, and green technology are expected to create 120,000 new jobs across Madhya Pradesh.

Expressing gratitude to the State administration, Pranav added, “Thanks to the Government’s efforts, the pace of decision-making has accelerated, creating a positive environment for industries.”

Maize becomes India’s leading feedstock for ethanol

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



India’s ambitious ethanol blending programme has hit a significant milestone, with cumulative supplies crossing 515 crore litres in the first half of the Ethanol Supply Year (ESY) 2025-26. Data released by the All India Distillers’ Association (AIDA) reveals a structural shift in the country’s biofuel landscape, with maize emerging as the single-largest feedstock, surpassing traditional sugarcane-based sources.

According to the latest industry estimates, the sector has already fulfilled nearly 49 per cent of the total contracted volume of 1,059 crore litres. Grain-based distilleries have been the primary engine of this growth, contributing approximately 333 crore litres to the national pool.

Out of this, maize-based ethanol alone accounted for 182 crore litres, signalling a transition towards a more diversified and water-efficient feedstock ecosystem.

The rise of maize is being viewed by experts as a turning point for India’s energy security. Unlike sugarcane, maize offers year-round availability and requires substantially less water, making it a scalable solution for the government’s

higher-blending ambitions beyond the E20 target.

“The emergence of maize as the leading feedstock reflects the sector’s increasing maturity and long-term sustainability,” stated Mr Vijendra Singh, President of AIDA.

He noted that the programme has entered a “decisive growth phase” but stressed the need for long-term policy certainty to maintain the momentum.

While grains led the surge, sugarcane-based distilleries maintained a robust performance, supplying 182 crore litres — achieving 62 per cent of their contracted volumes.

Sugarcane juice remained the dominant contributor within this category at 130 crore litres, followed by B-heavy and C-heavy molasses.

Industry stakeholders pointed out that the balance between grain and molasses-based production is crucial for reducing

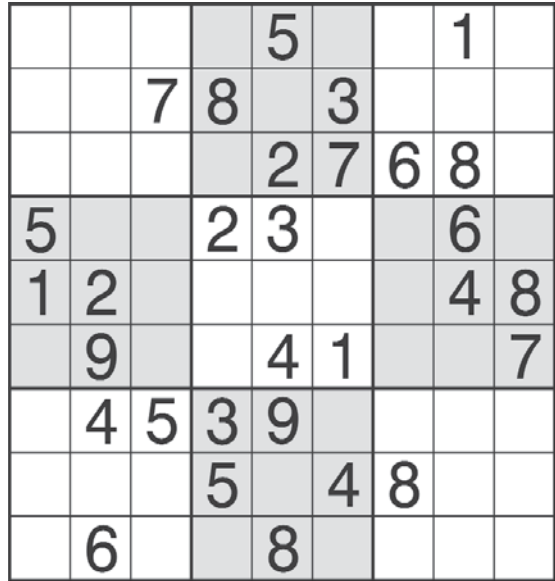
supply-side vulnerabilities and ensuring a steady flow to Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs).

Monthly supplies have remained consistent, peaking at 102 crore litres in December 2025. Despite the record-breaking numbers, the industry is now seeking a stronger policy framework for the next phase of growth.

AIDA has urged the government to accelerate incentives for flex-fuel vehicles (FFVs), sustainable aviation fuel (SAF), and the use of ethanol in diesel substitution.

Bharati Balaji, Deputy Director General of AIDA, emphasised that the sector is now prepared to support next-generation biofuel applications. “With the right policy support, India has the potential to emerge as a global leader in biofuels while simultaneously strengthening farmer incomes and rural investments,” she said.

DAILY SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

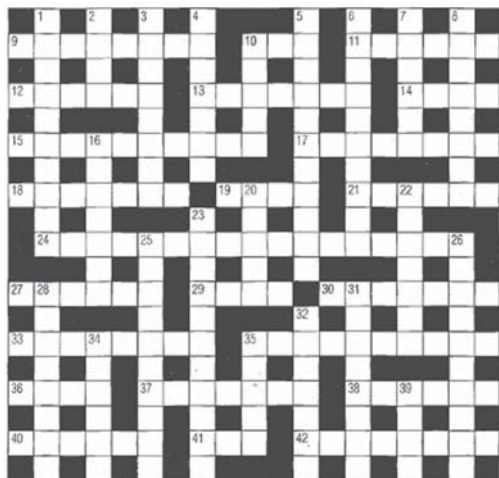
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (11.5.26)								
6	2	4	1	7	9	3	5	8
7	3	1	5	4	8	9	6	2
9	5	8	2	3	6	1	7	4
3	8	6	9	1	2	5	4	7
2	1	5	4	6	7	8	3	9
4	9	7	3	8	5	2	1	6
1	6	3	8	9	4	7	2	5
8	4	2	7	5	1	6	9	3
5	7	9	6	2	3	4	8	1

DOUBLE CROSSWORD TUESDAY | MAY 12, 2026



ACROSS

- A force for good (6)
- Battle station (8)
- Slow starting runner, but a cheerful one (6)
- Jumps around with much pleasure (5)
- How one’s ears can burn! (4)
- Nominally a bit of a setback for ASLEF (4)
- Country dance hall (4)
- Pointed end of a lancet, I presume (3)
- Stray sheep going round the ring (4)
- You won’t find this in the North Atlantic! (4)
- Old-fashioned fellows (9)
- In more ways than one, I’m clued up (4)

DOWN

- River of Wales? (5)
- It’s bound to be cartographic (5)
- She opens up when the lights are low (4)
- A problem confronting the artist? (5)
- Retreat by rail, possibly? (4)
- Cried movingly at the perfect ending, we believe (6)
- Apparently a prayer to make a man sit up! (6)
- Timber used in wheel making (3)
- A centre for continental capitalists (5)
- Need it contain Russian tea? (7)
- Flier with a hang-up? (3)
- Brown ant maybe (3)
- Being catty, is spotted in a nice fur coat (6)

- One garment, of which five make a set (4)
- Traffic problem promised for tomorrow? (3)
- It’s taken to be exemplary (4)
- Cleaner drink? (4)
- A pronounced bore, but providing a round in the bar (4)
- Has no translation in an African language (5)
- The benefits of managing to be first round the bend? (6)
- It emerges as a key assignment (8)
- American in the nude, perhaps, getting fresh (6)

- Going to church, headgear provides a certain cover (5)
- Enough energy for six million? (3)
- In dire disappointment, visibly angry (3)
- Bird possessing a warm heart in a London street (6)
- Managed to appear in opera nightly (3)
- Less than pleased when relieved (5)
- Jump over the thing and buzz off (3,2)
- The weather not to be out, with little sunshine around (5)
- It’s after the job’s finished that there are offcuts (4)
- Shopping for a kimono, you may see one in the window (4)

BSES inaugurates high performance basketball centre for nurturing talent



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BSES has taken another important step towards supporting youth development and promoting grassroots sports with the inauguration of its flagship High Performance Basketball Centre at Sarita Vihar, in partnership with the Dribble Academy Foundation under its CSR initiative.

The new centre is a major milestone for the BSES Basketball Academy, which aims to identify and nurture young basketball talent across Delhi.

Those present on the

occasion included BSES Director VS Verma, senior officials from BSES, and representatives of the Dribble Academy Foundation.

The High Performance Centre is the fifth facility under the growing BSES Basketball Academy network. More than 1100 students are already training at four feeder centres located in IP Extension, West Vinod Nagar, and Fatehpur Beri.

These centres are helping bring basketball closer to local communities and giving young boys and girls an opportunity to learn and

grow in the sport.

The High Performance Centre will provide talented players with a professional training environment that balances sports and academics. The programme will include structured coaching, advanced skill development, strength and conditioning, nutrition, recovery support, mentorship, and video analysis of games and performances.

Students from the feeder centres also showcased their basketball skills during the inauguration, adding excitement and energy to the occasion.

Yamaha hosts thrilling Track Day for above 400 fans at Gurugram



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

India Yamaha Motor (IYM) Pvt Ltd rolled out an adrenaline-pumping Track Day for customers at the F9 Go Karting Track here, drawing over 400 enthusiasts and 200 owners from Gurugram and the NCR under its “The Call of The Blue” campaign.

Riders of Yamaha’s popular R15 and MT-15 models got a safe, pro-supervised taste of circuit racing, going beyond daily road thrills.

The event underscored Yamaha’s push for premium biking experiences.

Participants attended detailed pre-ride briefing sessions conducted by trained experts, where they were introduced to essential track-riding techniques such as racing lines, body positioning, lean angles, throttle control, and progressive braking. These sessions helped riders build confidence and sharpen their riding skills before taking on the track.

The vibrant event also featured exclusive Yamaha apparel and accessories displays, interactive engagement zones, and dedicated photo opportunities, creating an immersive brand experience for all attendees.

Invitation For Bids (IFB)					
The Chief Executive Officer (CEO), Assam Skill University Project (ASUP) cum Registrar, Assam Skill University (ASU) (“the Purchaser”) invites online bid from eligible bidders for the below mentioned Packages at Assam Skill University:					
#	Package No.	Package Name	Date of Publication	Deadline for Submission	
			Date	Date	Time
1.	CW-08	Construction of Workshop/Lab Building	11 May 2026	11 June 2026	14:00 Hours (IST)
2.	GS02/ASU/MTC/027	Equipments for Advanced Survey, Civil & Plumbing Lab (Advanced)	11 May 2026	11 June 2026	14:00 Hours (IST)
Interested bidders may download and submit their bids electronically using the e-Procurement portal https://assamtenders.gov.in/					
DIPR/CF/PIO/53/12-May-26			Sd/- CEO, ASUP cum Registrar, ASU		

BRIEFLY

Atiqa Mir makes big impact on dream FIA Karting debut



Indian racing sensation Atiqa Mir exceeded expectations on her FIA European Championship debut, finishing a stellar sixth in Race 2 in the "pinnacle" of karting. Awarded a wildcard for round two of the championship considering her special talent, the 11-year-old was once again thrown at the deep end and yet again she was able to navigate majority of the challenges that were posed by the best in the business. Atiqa, India's first Formula 1 Academy backed driver and also the highest ranked female in the OKN1 class (age 12-14) in the FIA ranking, had to deal with a more powerful equipment in the OKJ category and a tricky set of Maxxis tyres for the first time against 92 world class drivers with much more experience. Qualifying position is often decisive in a heavily populated field but Atiqa fought her way into the Super Heats of the FIA (world body for four wheel racing) sanctioned series, showing a lot of fight and speed after starting 15th on the grid. Atiqa's best race finish of the weekend was P6 in Race 2 and she also got the coveted Fastest Lap in Race 5. A few crashes and penalties notwithstanding, the Indian with roots in J&K qualified for the Super Heats on her debut and attracted attention of the entire paddock.

Argentine plazas buzz with WC sticker trading fever



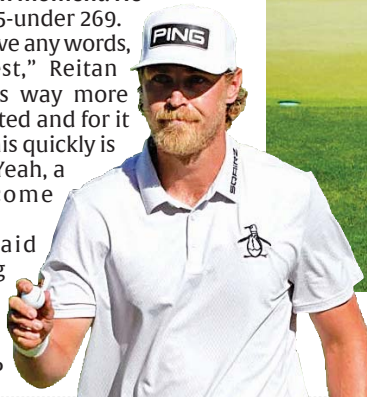
With just under a month until the FIFA World Cup kicks off, thousands of people are filling Argentine plazas strategising to win a different game that has become a beloved part of the quadrennial competition: collecting and trading stickers to complete the official World Cup stickerbook. For more than half a century, Panini stickerbooks have been a treasured part of the World Cup experience, with schools, plazas and even offices becoming zones to barter for coveted rare stickers and duplicates laid out ready to be discarded. In South America, swapping stickers is even more important than simply collecting them, with WhatsApp groups, apps and websites popping up to facilitate the trades. On Sunday, throngs of people gathered in the heart of Buenos Aires exchanging multicolored decks of stickers with the faces of some of the world's most famous soccer players, some doling them out on a table like a dealer in a poker game. Children cradle books where they carefully paste the stickers. "This connects you with the world. Everyone does it," said Juan Valora, a fan who was collecting stickers with his girlfriend. "And if this was virtual, you wouldn't be face to face looking at the cards and trading them. I think you'd miss out a bit on the human touch." Panini launched its largest sticker collection ever for this World Cup, coinciding with the increase in participating countries from 32 to 48. Each pack contains seven stickers, and the price in both Argentina and Uruguay is around \$1.50. The legendary stickerbooks, which can sell online for thousands of dollars, will come to an end after the 2030 World Cup.

Norway's Kristoffer Reitan earns 2-shot win at Truist Championship

STEVE REED ■ Charlotte (USA)

Kristoffer Reitan was not having much fun early in his career on the DP World Tour, and he began contemplating the idea of leaving competitive golf to become a YouTube golfer. He never followed through, instead sticking with his goal of winning tournaments. He's glad he did. The 28-year-old PGA Tour rookie from Norway shot 2-under 69 on Sunday to earn a two-shot win over Rickie Fowler and Nicolai Hojgaard at the Truist Championship for his first victory on the PGA Tour. Reitan, who chose golf over

soccer at a young age, won twice previously on the European Tour but this week proved to be his breakthrough moment. He finished at 15-under 269. "I don't have any words, to be honest," Reitan said. "This is way more than I expected and for it to happen this quickly is just unreal. Yeah, a dream come true." Reitan said stepping away from the game for a bit after losing his DP



Tour card helped him gain perspective. "It helped me find

my game again," Reitan said. "It helped me discover my talents again. Yeah, that was something

really important to me, which I try to remind myself of every single day. So that was definitely a huge thing for me getting back and starting to play some good golf again." Alex Fitzpatrick, the third-round leader, finished three shots back after shooting 73. Reitan started the round one shot behind Fitzpatrick, but was even par for the day after 13 holes and one shot behind Fowler, who had surged to the lead after shooting 30 on the front nine. "The first nine was let's go have a good day," and back nine was, hey, we actually are in a spot where we can go win this," Fowler said. (AP)

PSG beats Brest to almost seal Ligue 1 title

JEROME PUGMIRE ■ Paris

Desire Doue's late goal earned Paris Saint-Germain a 1-0 home win over Brest on Sunday and all but sealed a record-extending 14th Ligue 1 title. PSG leads second-place Lens by six points and only needs a draw when they meet in their rescheduled game on Wednesday, after which comes the final round next Sunday. If PSG loses twice and Lens wins both its matches, Lens could mathematically win the title on goal difference but PSG has a far superior goal difference of +44 compared to +29. Doue picked up a pass on



the left side of the penalty area and skipped past three players before bending a fine shot into the bottom right corner in the 83rd minute of a mostly dull contest. With heavy rain falling at

Parc des Princes, the game was briefly held up in the first half when a technical glitch prevented communication between referee Jerome Brisard and his assistants. (AP)

Barcelona retains Spanish league title

TALES AZZONIA ■ Barcelona

Watched by its grieving coach, Barcelona won its second straight Spanish league title and 29th overall with a comfortable 2-0 win over Real Madrid at Camp Nou on Sunday, adding to its rival's troubled season. Goals by Marcus Rashford in the ninth minute and Ferran Torres in the 18th gave Barcelona the victory and an insurmountable 14-point advantage over its fierce rival with three rounds remaining in La Liga. Barcelona coach Hansi Flick was in the dugout for Sunday's clasico following the death of his father, which Barcelona announced hours before kickoff. Players from both teams wore black armbands and there was a moment of silence before kickoff. A draw would also have been enough for the Catalan club to seal its third league title in four seasons. Madrid, which remains the most successful club in the league with 36 trophies, is ending a second consecutive season without a major title. Sunday's defeat at Barcelona capped an embarrassing week for Madrid, marked by altercations between players in training that led the club to fine Federico Valverde and Aurelien Tchouameni 500,000 euros (\$589,000) each. Rashford opened the scoring for the hosts with a wonderfully taken free kick, curling the ball over the wall and into the top corner. Torres added to the lead from inside the area after a flick from Dani Olmo. "This is like a family": Flick's father reportedly died overnight. The



coach celebrated Barcelona's goals and looked emotional after the final whistle. "I will never forget this day. It was a tough day for me. It starts with this (news that) my father passed away, but here, my team is fantastic," Flick said. "I really love it, this is like a family and they gave everything today and I'm really proud. It's amazing, in this stadium, and also in the clasico against Real Madrid, to win La Liga." There was a brief scuffle between players in the 51st minute after Olmo confronted a Madrid player. Olmo was shown a yellow card. Madrid's Jude Bellingham had a goal disallowed for offside in the 63rd. Brazil forward Raphinha replaced Rashford in the

64th to return from a long injury layoff. Barcelona has been playing the final league games without the injured Lamine Yamal, its biggest star. Yamal was on the field lifting the trophy along with his teammates. **No Mbappe:** Madrid was without the injured Kylian Mbappe, the league's leading scorer with 24 goals. The France forward failed to recover from a left-hamstring ailment that has kept him sidelined since late April. Mbappe last week addressed a fresh wave of criticism of him in Spain, insisting he was fully committed to the club and to recovering from his latest injury. Some Madrid fans had expressed concern that the France forward was saving himself for the upcoming World

Cup. He posted a story during Sunday's game while it was being shown on a television, along with supporting words for the club and a white heart. Madrid was also without Valverde, who hurt his head in the altercation with Tchouameni after allegedly accidentally knocking his head on a table. It was not the only altercation involving Madrid players during training last week. Alvaro Carreras confirmed he was in a "minor" incident with a teammate. Spanish media said he and fellow defender Antonio Rudiger got into a scuffle. **Arbeloa under fire:** The loss in Sunday's clasico is likely to increase criticism of coach Alvaro Arbeloa, who was promoted from Madrid's reserve team when Xabi Alonso was fired in January. The rumors of a possible return of Jose Mourinho to the club were only likely to increase. "There's not a lot we can say," Arbeloa said. "We understand how frustrated and dissatisfied that the fans must be. The only thing we can do is work and look to the future, learn from everything that we have done badly this year. Real Madrid is always back, we have fallen many times and we have risen many times." Singer-songwriters Olivia Rodrigo and Nathy Peluso were among the celebrities at the stadium. Rodrigo, an American multi-Grammy winner, had her logo appearing in the team's jersey as part of the club's partnership with Spotify. Barcelona this season also won Spanish Super Cup. (AP)

Star Aussie bowling trio to sit out of Pak and Bangladesh limited overs tour

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Sydney

Australia has left fast bowlers Pat Cummins, Mitchell Starc and Josh Hazlewood out of its limited overs squads for upcoming tours of Pakistan and Bangladesh later this month. The trio will miss the three-match series against Pakistan starting May 30, with uncapped all-rounder Liam Scott and Australia Under-19 World Cup captain Ollie Peake earning their first senior international call-ups in a new-look Australian squad. Young batter Joel Davies is another new face after he was selected for the T20 series against Bangladesh in June. Travis Head, Cooper Connolly, Ben Dwarshuis and Xavier Bartlett will travel to Bangladesh once their Indian Premier League commitments are completed, while veteran all-rounder Glenn Maxwell was omitted altogether. Mitchell Marsh will be the captain across both tours as Australia begins



its preparations for the Cricket World Cup to be held in South Africa, Namibia and Zimbabwe in October next year. Selection chairman George Bailey said the tours presented opportunities for emerg-

ing players. "It's always exciting to see new players get an opportunity to play international cricket and be a part of the national team," Bailey said. "The blend of experienced players coupled with new or returning players will provide a nice mix for these subcontinent tours. "Continuing to provide opportunities for players to develop across a broad range of conditions and experiences is important and will continue to be a focus over the next 18 months to two years." Cummins, Starc and Hazlewood are expected to use the break to prepare for Australia's World Test Championship campaign, which resumes in August in a two-test home series against Bangladesh. Australia plays Pakistan in three ODIs in Rawalpindi (May 30) and Lahore (June 2 and 4) before traveling to Bangladesh for three ODI games in Dhaka (June 9, 11 and 14) and three T20 Internationals in Chattogram (June 17, 19 and 21).



I will never forget this day: Barcelona coach

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Barcelona

Barcelona coach Hansi Flick was in the dugout for Sunday's clasico against Real Madrid following the death of his father, with the Catalan club winning its second consecutive Spanish league title. Barcelona beat Madrid 2-0 at Camp Nou just a few hours after the club announced the death of Flick's father. "I will never forget this day," Flick said. "It was a tough day for me. It starts with this (news that) my father passed away, but here, my team is fantastic." Flick's father reportedly died overnight. The club did not give any additional details. "FC Barcelona and the entire blaugrana family wish to send all our love to Hansi Flick after the passing of his father," Barcelona said in a statement. "We share in your sorrow and our thoughts are with you and your family during this difficult time." Barcelona and Madrid players wore black armbands and there was a moment of silence before

kickoff. Barcelona entered the last clasico of the season leading Madrid by 11 points with four rounds remaining in La Liga. It comfortably defeated Madrid with first-half goals from Marcus Rashford and Ferran Torres. "Flick has been very important for us," midfielder Frenkie de Jong said. "He has very clear ideas, but inside there is a lot of freedom for the players. This way we can show our quality." Barcelona players threw Flick up in the air during the title celebrations. "This is like a family and they gave everything today and I'm really proud," Flick said.



Marie-Louise first female head coach to win Bundesliga game

JAMES ELLINGWORTH ■ Berlin

Union Berlin's Marie-Louise Eta became the first female head coach to win a game in European soccer's top five men's leagues as she oversaw a 3-1 victory against Mainz in the German Bundesliga on Sunday. Eta punched the air and joined her players to applaud Union's fans as she celebrated her first win in the fourth game of her five-game tenure as interim coach. "You're happy, you want to win games. That's always the case and so it was today as well," she told broadcaster DAZN when asked if it was a release of pressure. "The way it happened was great too, how we managed to pull it off." Late goals from Oliver Burke in the 88th minute and Josip Juranovic in stoppage time turned a draw into a



win to move Union up to 12th in the Bundesliga table. Earlier, Mainz's Sheraldo Becker had scored to cancel out Andrej Ilic's opener for Union. It was the first win for Union since March. Eta took over when the club fired Steffen Baumgart last

month. She had one draw and two losses before Sunday's win. While Eta, an experienced youth and assistant coach, has previously acknowledged there's a "social impact" to her historic head coach role, she's keen to stress that results

come first. "It hasn't been about that," she told DAZN on Sunday when asked how she'd like people to view her time in charge. "It's been about doing the job as well as possible, getting points, winning games, and that's what we've worked for each day. We've invested a lot so it's great that we could get the three points here today, show a good performance, I think, and that's important for me, too." Eta's time as head coach of the Union men's team is due to end next week when Union hosts Augsburg in its last game of the season. She has already agreed to take charge of the Union women's team for next season. The game was interrupted for several minutes in first half as Union fans threw tennis balls onto the field in a protest against league scheduling.

Axar, Miller keep DC alive in IPL with record chase



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dharamsala

David Miller and captain Axar Patel engineered a record run chase for Delhi Capitals with their counter attacking knocks as the visitors upstaged Punjab Kings by three wickets to stay alive in the Indian Premier League here on Monday.

Aggressive knocks from Miller (51 off 28) and skipper Axar Patel (56 off 30) allowed Delhi Capitals to gun down 211 in 19 overs for the highest chase at the HPCA Stadium.

Priyansh Arya hit half a dozen sixes in his whirlwind 33-ball 56 before Delhi Capitals pacers tweaked their lengths to limit Punjab Kings to 210 for five.

Having remained unbeaten in the first half of the tournament, Punjab Kings have now lost four in a row and need at least two wins from their remaining three games



to make the play offs.

Barring Arshdeep Singh, the bowlers let the team down with their wayward display.

However, the home team's bowlers did the job in the power-play. Punjab Kings struck thrice for the first time in the powerplay, leaving Delhi Capitals reeling at 47 for three in the first six overs.

Arshdeep Singh, who has been rather expensive this season, returned impressive figures of two for 21 in four overs.

It was Yash Thakur who provided the first breakthrough by casting Abhishek Porel with a ball that seamed back in from length to knock out the middle stump.

K L Rahul was caught at fine leg after mistiming a whip off Arshdeep. The young Sahil Parakh played a few impressive strokes in his brief stay before being crammed

up for space by Arshdeep to be caught at short third man.

It became 74 for four with the run out of Tristan Stubbs extending the struggles of DC batters.

However, Miller (51 off 28) and Axar (56 off 30) brought life back into the game with their counter-attacking 64-run stand off 34 balls.

Eventually, Ashutosh Sharma (24) and Madav Tiwari (18) came up with timely cameos to keep DC alive in the competition.

DC, struggling to stay alive in the tournament, opted to field in the first game of the season at the scenic venue here after making five changes to their side.

The ball generally flies off the bat in the high altitude of Dharamsala and that was very much evident in the first over of the game from Mitchell Starc, who proved rather expensive on the night.

Priyansh took the veteran Australian pacer to the cleaners in the over that went for 22 runs. His onslaught included a six square of the wicket on either side.

The southpaw not only dispatched Starc for a first ball six, he also meted out the same treatment to the wily Lungi Ngidi and Mukesh Kumar.

Starc understandably went full to search for the swing but DC pacers realised that bowling full was not the way go on this surface after conceding 51 runs from the first three overs.

Aquib Nabi was the man behind DC's comeback as he got the ball to seam from length, particularly making life tough for Priyansh in the second half of the powerplay.

Priyansh's opening partner Prabhsimran Singh did not have much rhythm in his 15-ball 18

before getting caught at fine leg off Mukesh.

Madhav Tiwari got his first wicket of the IPL by getting Priyansh caught at deep point in the ninth over.

Punjab Kings were off to a flyer but by the halfway mark they could only reach 107 for two in 10 overs.

Captain Shreyas Iyer (59 not out off 36) and Cooper Connolly (38 off 27) shared 83 off 52 balls for the third wicket but they were not able to change gears as swiftly as they would have liked.

In the 19th over, Starc got rid of Marcus Stoinis and Shashank Singh off successive balls before Suryansh Shedge hit a couple of breathtaking sixes off the high profile speedster.

Ngidi bowled a brilliant final over to ensure Punjab Kings don't push beyond 210.

Krunal credits Karthik for RCB batters' improved performance this season



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Raipur

Veteran all-rounder Krunal Pandya credited mentor and batting coach Dinesh Karthik for Royal Challengers Bengaluru's improved batting approach after his gritty knock against Mumbai Indians kept the side in the hunt and knocked the five-time champions out of the IPL playoffs race.

Battling severe cramps and batting virtually on one leg, Krunal smashed an unbeaten 73 off 46 balls in a tense chase that RCB sealed off the final delivery.

Krunal said Karthik's behind-the-scenes work with the batters over the last two seasons has played a major role in shaping the side's batting performances. "If you look at last year and even this year, despite the ups and downs, a lot of credit goes to DK," Krunal said at the post-match press

conference on Sunday.

"He has spent a lot of individual time with each player, understanding their strengths and weaknesses and working on them. He's always there for the batters. So yes, there's no doubt a lot of credit goes to DK for how we've batted as a unit."

The left-hander revealed that RCB's clarity in pressure situations stemmed from detailed planning around match-ups and execution in crunch moments.

"We've discussed that if there's one bowler you fancy and feel you can take down, just play out those six balls properly," Krunal said.

"In that situation, I was set. I was in. And I realised it was becoming very difficult for me to run ones and twos because of the cramps. So I thought, 'okay, let me just stand and face all six balls' and capitalise on whatever I can."

Vinesh Phogat insists she is eligible to compete



AMANPREET SINGH ■ Gonda

Vinesh Phogat arrived here on Monday and replied to the Wrestling Federation of India's (WFI) show-cause notice, claiming that she was eligible to return from retirement even though the national federation maintained that she cannot be allowed to compete in the ongoing National Open Ranking tournament.

The WFI said she cannot compete until disciplinary proceedings against her are complete.

The national federation had earlier declared Vinesh ineligible to participate in domestic events till June 26, 2026, citing the mandatory six-month notice period linked to athletes returning from retirement under anti-doping rules.

Immediately after landing in Ayodhya, Vinesh replied to the WFI's show-cause notice, claiming that Rule 5.6.1 of the World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA) Code concerning retired athletes does not apply to her as she had already informed United World Wrestling (UWW) in June

about her decision to resume competition after retirement.

In her response, Vinesh argued that she had formally intimated UWW about her comeback well in advance and, therefore, fulfilled the procedural requirements needed to return to competition.

However, WFI sources said the federation was not satisfied with her reply and felt that the wrestler had addressed only the eligibility aspect while failing to respond comprehensively to the broader disciplinary charges levelled against her in the detailed notice issued earlier.

"The reply is not enough. She has not answered the full show-cause notice. Until a disciplinary hearing is conducted and the matter is decided, she cannot be permitted to compete," a WFI source said.

The controversy erupted after WFI issued a strongly worded show-cause notice to the celebrated wrestler, accusing her of indiscipline, breach of federation rules and anti-doping related procedural violations. (PTI)

India retain top position in ICC men's ODI rankings after annual update; NZ second

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dubai

India retained the top position in the ICC's men's ODI team rankings after the latest annual update with reigning world champions Australia claiming the third spot.

In a statement issued on Monday, the ICC said, "India remain at the pinnacle of the ICC Men's ODI Team Rankings after the latest annual update, leading second-placed New Zealand (113 points) by a narrow five-point margin, while Australia (109 points) retain the third place to round off the top three."

India have slipped marginally by a single rating point, and now have 118 points to their name.

The annual rankings



update applies full weightage (100 percent) to matches played since May 2025, while results from the previous two years are given half weightage (50 percent).

South Africa's tally of 102 points allowed them to

edge past Pakistan's 98 points and break into the top four.

The remainder of the top 10 remains unchanged, with Sri Lanka (96), Afghanistan (93) and England (89) completing the top eight.

Bangladesh are ninth

with 84 points, while the West Indies are on 74 points now, and trail the Tigers by 10 points compared to six in the previous update.

"This particular outcome has important ramifications for both the sides, as they seek to secure a direct qualification for the ICC Men's Cricket World Cup 2027," the ICC said.

"The top eight teams in the ICC Rankings as of March 31, 2027 will secure direct qualification alongside hosts South Africa and Zimbabwe, who have automatically qualified," it added.

In this context, if South Africa continue to remain in the top eight positions, given their automatic qualification for the tournament, the ninth spot becomes key to a direct World Cup ticket.

Playoff pressure builds as SRH face GT in high-stakes clash

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ahmedabad

As the IPL enters its decisive final phase, second-placed Sunrisers Hyderabad and third-ranked Gujarat Titans prepare for a critical showdown here on Tuesday, which could prove to be pivotal in shaping the playoff race.

The Shubman Gill-led GT appear slightly better placed after recovering from a slow start to the season with a string of crucial wins, including a commanding 77-run victory over Rajasthan Royals, which lifted



them to third on the points table.

With the top three sides — RCB, SRH and GT — all locked on 14 points, net run rate could become a decisive factor in the race for the playoffs, making it imperative for SRH to improve theirs in front of their home crowd.

SRH have found their rhythm at the right time, with the emphatic 33-run win over Punjab Kings underlining their immense batting potential after piling up a massive 235 for 4. But despite their resurgence and stronger position on the table, they cannot afford complacency as the race for the playoffs remains extremely

tight and a single misstep could prove costly.

GT's biggest strength lies in the balance of their side, particularly their batting, which revolves around skipper Gill and Sai Sudharsan, both of whom have provided solidity at the top while negotiating the powerplay smartly.

With experienced campaigners like Jos Buttler and Washington Sundar adding depth, GT prefer building steadily before accelerating through the middle and death overs, an approach that has served them well both while setting targets and in chases.

Bhavjit Jauhar named interim COO of Cricket Canada



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Toronto

Cricket Canada has announced the appointment of Bhavjit Jauhar as interim chief operating officer (COO), following the conclusion of the organisation's Annual General Meeting on May 9-10.

The interim appointment supports immediate commercial, operational, governance, and compliance priorities during a period of organisational transition and renewal, Cricket Canada said.

SAI lists BFI irregularities, suspends assessment camp in Patiala

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The Sports Authority of India (SAI) has suspended an assessment camp by the Boxing Federation of India in Patiala for "irregularities" but is open to granting a resumption if the body revamps its "opaque" selection process and answers "legitimate questions" on its criteria of picking coaches.

The suspension order was issued on Sunday evening after the BFI failed to respond to SAI's "persistent queries on irregularities in the selection policy for boxers as well as coaches", a well-placed SAI source said.

The SAI said that it has been "bombarded" with complaints from boxers and coaches who have been adversely affected by the policy and the BFI's "refusal to give a clear explanation" has not helped matters.



"Several complaints have landed at our doorstep, in which boxers are telling us that at this assessment camp, the bout results were not going to be immediately released. Instead, the BFI's so-called High Performance Unit along with the selection committee was going to have discussions and then decide who to pick," the source said.

England mulling tour of Nepal: Report

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ London

The England cricket team might tour Nepal for a short white-ball series during the 2027-31 cycle, a media report has stated, suggesting that the plan was discussed at a meeting between the two Boards during the T20 World Cup in India.

According to ESPNcricinfo, the England and Wales Cricket Board (ECB) is open to the idea of a three-match T20 series against Nepal before engagements like a tour of India.

"England's men could become the biggest international team yet to tour



Nepal, with the ECB exploring the prospect of scheduling a short T20I series at some stage in the 2027-31 international cycle," the website reported.

England and Nepal squared off for the first time during the T20 World Cup when the South Asian nation fell short by a mere

Veer Chotrani loses to world number 1 Asal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

India's Veer Chotrani went down to Egyptian world No. 1 and defending champion Mostafa Asal in the men's second round of the World Squash Championships in Giza, Egypt.

World No. 45 Chotrani lost 5-11, 2-11, 4-11, which ended the Indian challenge at the Worlds following first-round losses to compatriots Abhay Singh, Ramit Tandon and Velavan Senthilkumar.